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INSIDE



Arlekar to be full-time T.N. Governor

NEW DELHI
President Droupadi Murmu has effected changes in Governors across six States, with Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar set to be full-time Governor of Tamil Nadu. Sudha Yadav will be Karnataka Governor while Om Prakash Mathur will take over in Keralam. » PAGE 6

SIPs see inflow of ₹32,490 crore in September

MUMBAI
Foreign institutional investors remained net sellers in Sept., according to the latest data released by the Association of Mutual Funds in India on Monday. On the other hand, Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) participation continued to rise, with retail investment participation marking a record inflow of ₹32,490 cr. » PAGE 12

Russia unwilling to accept 'energy truce': Zelenskyy

KYIV
Russia does not want to accept an "energy ceasefire" in Ukraine announced by Donald Trump, Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, accusing Moscow of attacking six sites on Monday. "It is evident that Russia is unwilling to accept an energy ceasefire proposed by the U.S.," he said on social media. » PAGE 14

INDIA bloc rally takes SIR protest to SC's door

- Opposition alliance comes together amid heavy police deployment to march to Supreme Court
- Cong. says on social media 2.5 lakh people took part in the four-hour-long 'March for Democracy'
- Petition filed in the SC over alleged large-scale deletions in poll rolls, electoral irregularities

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

A massive crowd on Monday walked down arterial roads in the national capital, tailing a procession of buses carrying leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) from Constitution Club to the Supreme Court, where Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and other top leaders of the bloc filed a petition over the alleged large-scale voter deletions and irregularities in the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The Congress, on its social media handles, said 2.5 lakh people participated in the protest. The "March for Democracy", which began at 1.30 p.m. at the Constitution Club, went on for more than four hours, mostly unhindered by police barricades and intervention, and also allowing for an occasional break for the protesters from waving flags and sloganeering at ice cream and juice carts.

The march had several such light moments, including when Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge donned a Batman mask. There was heavy deployment of police, who stood on the sidelines watching.

Stopped near SC

After winding through central Delhi and doubling back via Mandi House, the procession was finally stopped by the police near the Supreme Court. Several leaders, including Mr. Gandhi, Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, Tejashwi Yadav and Akhilesh Yadav, climbed atop a vehicle for the last leg of the march, which rang with slogans against the government and the Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar.

Several top Congress leaders, including Sachin Pilot, were seen marching along with the protesters.

Despite a proposal from INDIA bloc leaders that only the National Flag should be flown, Congress flags dominated the scene. Flags of Left student bodies, CPI (M)'s SFI, CPI's AISF and CPI(ML)'s AISA, could also be seen.

A majority of the protesters were Congress supporters who had travelled from different parts of the country – from Salma Begum, who came from Koraput in Odisha on her maiden trip to Delhi, to Mayank Chaudhary, a former Youth Congress leader leading a cavalcade of SUVs from Badkal, Haryana, slipping by police barricades on the way.

The lead bus in the procession had a carefully selected mix of INDIA bloc leaders to present a united front, with Congress's K.C. Venugopal standing at the landing waving at the crowd, and the front row occupied by Mr. Kharge and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi.

The bus also had Samajwadi Party's Dharmendra Yadav, RJD's Tejashwi Yadav, Shiv Sena (UBT)'s Sanjay Raut, Trinamool's Saugata Ray, CPI(M) general secretary M.A. Baby, CPI (ML) general secretary Dipankar Bhattacharya, and CPI leader P. Sandosh Kumar. AISA president Neha Bora and former president Sai Balaji were also there. SFI leader Aishe Ghosh was also on the bus.

The protesters who walked alongside the buses waved at the leaders. Every time Mr. Gandhi stood up, a loud cheer ensued. Several ran with their cameras held aloft at the sight of Ms. Bora, a recognisable face of the student movement. Mr. Kharge had requested all parties to inform their parliamentarians to reach the Constitution Club at 1 p.m. Despite the coordination difficulties, there was a wide assembly of leaders.

Former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee was among the leaders who gathered there. She did not join the procession, having to return to Kolkata. Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav, who reached Delhi only after 2 p.m., joined the protest around 4 p.m., for the last stretch of the march.

Thirty-six-year-old Ms. Salma, who left her two children behind in Koraput to fly down to Delhi, said, "I have come to meet Rahul Gandhi." She had been waiting since morning to catch a glimpse of her leader.

Davinder Singh came from Jalandhar, Punjab, dressed as the mythical god of death, Yamraj, and explained his sartorial choice, saying: "I am here to remind the government, which is stealing our votes, that they too have to face their makers."

Amid all this rhetoric, Narayan Saha made a brisk sale of papads, ₹20 a pop. His basket emptied rapidly. He was not as bothered about the SIR as the crowd around him appeared to be. Instead, he was worried that his brother's name had been cut from the ration card back home in Sitamarhi, Bihar.

MORE REPORTS ON
» PAGES 4 & 5



Major momentum: INDIA bloc supporters and activists during the march to the Supreme Court in New Delhi on Monday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Jantar Mantar no more designated protest venue

NEW DELHI
The Delhi Police on Monday denotified Jantar Mantar as a designated venue for protests and demonstrations, replacing one of the capital's longest-established sites of public dissent with three alternative grounds farther from the seat of power. The move drew criticism from activists, who said relocating demonstrations would make it harder for citizens to draw the attention to their demands. Under a standing order by Delhi Police Commissioner, Ramlila Maidan, around 4 km from Jantar Mantar, Burari Ground, around 15 km away, and CBD Ground, about 13 km away, have been designated as protest venues. » PAGE 4

Form 6 changes made after ruling on Bihar SIR: SC

NEW DELHI
The Supreme Court on Monday clarified that it had neither approved nor disapproved the controversial alterations made to Form 6 in its May 27 judgment, which was entirely about the legality of the pilot special intensive revision (SIR) process in Bihar. The court said the May 27 ruling pre-dated the changes made to Form 6. The changes and modified declarations, which required applicants to provide ancestry details or linkage to previous SIR rolls on the ECINet portal, were introduced subsequently in July. » PAGE 4

Retail inflation rises to two-year high of 5.5% as food, fuel become costlier

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

Retail inflation rose to a nearly two-year high of 5.5% in September, driven up by a continued acceleration in food and fuel inflation, official data released on Monday showed.

Inflation as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI) in September was the highest since October 2024. The rate in September also marked a substantial increase over the 4.8% rate seen the preceding month. The Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s upper comfort limit for retail inflation is 6%.

According to economists, this acceleration of inflation shows the RBI's Monetary Policy Committee was correct in hiking rates in its most recent policy review last week.

"With the CPI inflation jumping to a slightly higher than forecast 5.5% in September 2026 and appearing set to cross 6% in the ongoing month, the MPC's recent rate hike appears prescient," Aditi Nayar, chief economist at ICRA, said. "While the monsoon has turned out to be fairly dismal, with inadequate replenishment of reservoirs clouding the outlook for rabi sowing, another rate hike in December seems quite certain," she added.

Inflation in the food and beverages category jumped to 7.4% in September 2026 from 5.7% in the previous month. The new series of the CPI does not provide category-wise historical data before January 2026. The data shows September's food inflation rate is the highest during the period for which there is data.

Inflation in the transport segment came in at 5% in September 2026, having risen for the last five consecutive months. Taken together, the food and transport prices pushed inflation in the "restaurant and accommodation services" segment to 9.4%, capping off a seven-month streak of consecutive acceleration.

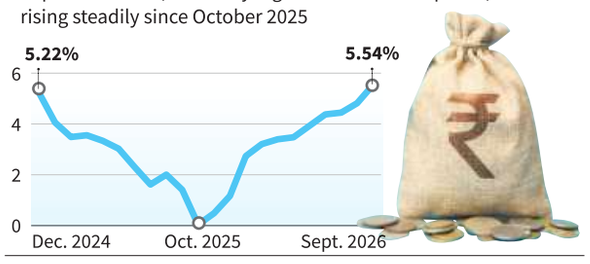
The third segment that saw elevated inflation was that of "personal care, social protection and miscellaneous goods & services", which saw inflation come in at 13.75% in September 2026, although this was the lowest it has been in the period for which there is data.

"Crude oil prices currently remain elevated, and their trajectory will keenly influence the likelihood and extent of further rate tightening in 2027," the ICRA chief economist said.

"In the case of personal care, where inflation was 13.8%, it is mainly due to silver and gold where prices are determined externally," Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at the Bank of Baroda, said. "Industries like durables, FMCG, automobile have announced an increase in prices and this should get reflected in the CPI over the next few months."

Prices climb

Retail inflation rose to a nearly two year high of 5.54% in September 2026, driven by higher food and fuel prices, after rising steadily since October 2025



Inflation as measured by the Consumer Price Index (CPI) in Sept. was the highest since October 2024

American economists win Nobel for linking household trends to policies

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

American economists Robert E. Hall and Michael Woodford were on Monday announced recipients of the 2026 economics Nobel for providing an empirical formula to help government frame policies that are aimed at stabilising the economy while incorporating household demand behaviour and supply behaviour of companies.

Professor Hall, 83, is currently the Robert and Carole McNeil Joint Hoover Senior Fellow and Professor of Economics at Stanford University while Mr. Woodford, 71, is the John Bates Clark Professor of Political Economy at Columbia University.

The official citation of the economics Nobel, formally the Sveriges Riksbank Prize in Economic Sciences in Memory of Alfred Nobel, said the duo was awarded for establishing the "microeconomic foundations of macroeconomic stabilisation".

"This year's laureates in the economic sciences have developed new macroeconomic models that have significantly improved our ability to implement effective stabilisation policy," the Royal Swedish Academy of Sciences said.

About their work

In a paper published in 1978, Professor Hall brought empirical backing to the idea that, while a household's current disposable income does impact its current spending, its expectations about the future path of disposable income matters almost just as much.

Professor Woodford, on the other hand, focused on supply, particularly on firms and how they set prices, and combined both his work and Professor Hall's into a composite framework. This combination helped with understanding business cycles, what causes them, how they play out, and the impact of these on government policy.

"On the basis of these models, well-timed fiscal and monetary policy measures can reduce the economy's peaks and troughs," the statement by the Royal Swedish Academy said. The research done by Professor Hall and Professor Woodford also provides an empirical basis, as Professor Woodford himself explained on Monday, for the idea that the effectiveness of economic policy is also determined by how well the government communicates the need for implementing those policies.

A matter of perspective

"One of the themes in my work is that government authorities shouldn't view stabilisation of the economy as an exercise that is simply conducted by people pulling levers to control the economy independently of what people in the economy understand about this," Professor Woodford said on Monday during the press conference announcing the Nobel results.

He explained that his work has stressed the need for consumers to understand the future course of policy, which is "crucial" to the effects of policy.

Beyond the big picture

American economists honoured for developing macroeconomic models that derive insights from microeconomic trends



Robert E. Hall
Stanford University, U.S.
Brought empirical backing to the importance of households' expectations of future path of disposable income



Michael Woodford
Columbia University, U.S.
Set up a composite framework to understand business cycles and their impact on government policies

INBRIEF



Delhi HC seeks police reply on Narwal's plea to visit U.K.

The Delhi High Court on Monday sought a response from the Delhi police on activist Natasha Narwal's plea seeking permission to travel to the United Kingdom to attend an academic conference while on bail in a case linked to the 2020 north-east Delhi riots. Justice Amit Bansal issued notice on Ms. Narwal's petition challenging an October 6 trial court order denying her permission in a case registered under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The matter has been listed for hearing on October 15. Ms. Narwal's counsel said she planned to visit from November 2 to December 1.

RLM leader nominated by rebel MLAs for MLC poll suspended

Upendra Kushwaha-led Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) on Monday suspended party leader Ram Pukar Sinha, the MLC candidate from the Saran Teachers' Constituency backed by three rebel MLAs of the party. On October 5, Mr. Sinha filed the nomination as an Independent candidate for the upcoming Legislative Council election despite Anand Pushkar contesting the seat as the Janata Dal (United) candidate from the ruling National Democratic Alliance. Three out of four MLAs of RLM were present during Mr. Sinha's nomination, and they all supported him instead of the JD(U) candidate.

'Limits of injustice crossed': Shivraj attacks M.P. govt. over demolition of tribals' houses

Their votes secured our victories, made Mohan Yadav the CM, says Union Minister after meeting affected families; govt. to order an investigation; Congress links incident with BJP's 'internal tussle'

Mehul Malpani
BHOPAL



Ex-M.P. CM Shivraj Singh Chouhan consoling a woman who lost her home in the Forest Dept. demolition drive. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The demolition of houses of several tribal families in Madhya Pradesh's Budhni prompted Union Agriculture Minister and former Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, who represented the Budhni Assembly seat for nearly 20 years, to remark that "the limits of oppression and injustice had been crossed".

Speaking to a wire agency after meeting the affected families on Sunday night, a visibly angry Mr. Chouhan asserted that Mohan Yadav, his successor, had become the CM "with their [tribals'] votes".

On Monday, Mr. Yadav said the matter had come to his attention and that an investigation would be conducted into it.

Houses of nearly 12 tribal families in Kosmi village were demolished by the Forest Department over alleged encroachment on Sunday. The village falls under the Vidisha Lok Sabha constituency, which Mr. Chouhan won in 2024.

'Heights of oppression'

"My constituency has witnessed the heights of oppression and extreme injustice. Women are weeping and beating their chests. Their homes have been demolished and their crops buried under the rubble. The fruits of their hard labour crushed, and their wells filled in. These were homes that had stood for years, yet today, these people have been left destitute and displaced," said the Vidisha MP.

He added, "The Chief Minister needs to be apprised of this injustice. I will convey everything to him... It is their votes that secure our [BJP's] victories, and it was their votes that made Mohan*ji* the Chief Minister. This is truly deeply distressing for me."

A close aide of Mr. Chouhan told *The Hindu* that the former CM had spoken to Mr. Yadav on Sunday morning and requested him to halt the drive as the Forest officials had earlier served eviction notices to families in the area.

"The CM had assured him [Mr. Chouhan] that the action would be stopped. But the drive seems to have been conducted anyway without the CM's knowledge," the aide said.

The question was put to Mr. Yadav during a press conference on Monday. In response, he said, "The matter has come to my attention. We will get it inquired. If a senior leader of our party has said something, we'll look into it."

The Opposition Congress linked the incident with the "power tussle" within the ruling party.

'CM must clarify'

Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly Umang Singhar said, "Mohan Yadav*ji*, when your own former Chief Minister is raising questions, you too must clarify when the government will take concrete steps. Is the internal power struggle within the government overshadowing even questions of public interest?"

MPSC chairman going on leave a big win for students, says Rahul

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI



Cong. leader Rahul Gandhi said the move will lead to a proper probe into 'corruption'. PTI

Congress leader and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Monday welcomed reports of Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) chairman Vivek Bhimanwar proceeding on leave, hours after the State government formed an inquiry panel to probe "irregularities" in exams conducted by the recruitment body and named IAS officer Tukaram Mundhe as its secretary.

"The MPSC chief had to go – now there will be a comprehensive probe into corruption," said Mr. Gandhi in a post in Hindi on X. He termed it a big win for students, youth and their agitation.

The Opposition has put its weight behind the agitating students who have been demanding Mr. Bhimanwar's removal and changes in the MPSC's functioning.

The ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) said the protests are "politically motivated" and have nothing to do with the official.

"No paper leak had occurred during his tenure as chairman. Nevertheless, he decided to go on leave on moral grounds. I wholeheartedly welcome his decision and thank him," said State BJP chief spokesperson Navnath Ban.

Meanwhile, Mumbai Police on Monday arrested another accused in connection with the MPSC Drug Inspector recruitment question paper leak, taking the total number of arrests in the case to 12. The accused, Mayur Chandrakant Thakre, was produced before a court, which sent him to police custody till October 17. Six persons, including three MPSC employees, candidates and alleged intermediaries were arrested in August.

(With inputs from PTI)

Have no reason to participate in Cong.-led protests after exiting INDIA bloc, says DMK

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



The DMK accused the BJP of unleashing violence against the youth participating in protests against the CEC. FILE PHOTO

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) said on Monday that it had no reason to participate in protests organised by the Congress after the latter "betrayed" it for the sake of power, forcing the DMK to leave the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA).

"We left the INDIA bloc after the Congress betrayed the DMK for the sake of power. There is no need for us to participate in the Congress's protests, and the party cannot compel us to join them," read a release issued from the DMK headquarters.

'Question CM's absence'

Reacting to Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president B. Manickam Tagore's claim that the DMK had stayed away from protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar out of fear of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the DMK said Mr. Tagore should question Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay's absence from the agitation.

"Mr. Vijay does not have the courage to open his mouth against Mr. Gyanesh Kumar, the BJP, or the Prime Minister," the DMK said.

Accusing the BJP of unleashing violence and using repressive measures against young people participating in protests in the national capital demanding the CEC's resignation, the DMK said former Chief Ministers and MPs had also faced such measures.

Party chief's stance

It pointed out that party president M.K. Stalin had strongly condemned the Union government's action against the protesters.

"Members of the Trinamool Congress, the SFI, and the Cockroach Janta Party have thanked Mr. Stalin and shared his message. Mr. Tagore claims the DMK is afraid of the BJP. The DMK is not afraid of anyone. Our leader wore a black shirt and burnt a copy of the Delimitation proposal during the election campaign," read the statement.

The DMK said the State Congress president should question the "deafening silence" of Mr. Vijay and his government's alleged suppression of protests in Tamil Nadu. "But Mr. Tagore has prostrated himself before the Panaiyur *Pannaiyar*," it added.

Need no lesson

Asserting that no one needed to teach the DMK how to oppose the BJP, the Opposition party said it had forged a strong alliance against the BJP in two Lok Sabha elections [2019 and 2024] and secured victories.

Billboard with Goddess Durga beside pot of biryani sparks row in West Bengal's Hooghly

Senjuti Sengupta
KOLKATA



U.S. Ambassador to India Sergio Gor in Kolkata on Monday. PTI

A billboard featuring an image of Goddess Durga next to a pot of biryani in West Bengal's Hooghly sparked a row, with a Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) legislator saying it had hurt the sentiments of the Hindu community.

The billboard was placed outside a high-rise residential complex in Uttarpara's Hindmotor area.

Billboard taken down

A group of residents gathered in the area on Sunday and raised objections, a police officer said. The establishment owner was later asked to remove all such marketing material, the officer said.

BJP's Uttarpara MLA Dipanjan Chakraborty said, "This cannot be tolerated. It is not about eating non-vegetarian food. How could anyone dare place an image of Maa Durga alongside biryani?" He warned of action if similar posters are seen again.

On Sunday, a controversy erupted after a Hindu outfit circulated a poster in Siliguri, asking people to buy biryani only from Hindu shopkeepers.

The incidents come against the backdrop of a controversy over calls to keep non-vegetarian food away from Durga Puja pandals.

Appeal against meat

On August 26, the Vishwa Hindu Parishad issued a statement asking that non-vegetarian food be kept away from Durga Puja pandals to maintain the sanctity of the religious festival.

A few days later, on September 6, the chief priest of Bageshwar Dham, Dhirendra Krishna Shastri, made a similar appeal, urging Bengalis to give up non-vegetarian food during the pujas. His comments sparked sharp reactions from the Opposition parties, which denounced the attempt to "impose vegetarianism" in the State.

Congress supporters lodged complaints at several police stations across West Bengal against the self-styled godman for "hurting the sentiments of Bengalis".

Several BJP leaders distanced themselves from the controversy. State BJP president Samik Bhattacharya attempted damage control by asserting that "nobody can ask Bengalis to give up non-vegetarian food". On October 10, the party circulated videos of Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari partaking of the traditional fish and pulao feast at Kalighat temple in Kolkata.

Delhi plans SOP for humane sterilisation of street dogs

Soibam Rocky Singh
NEW DELHI



MCD and NDMC will conduct pilot exercises, which will serve as a model for expanding the programme across the city. FILE PHOTO

Delhi is drafting a standard operating procedure (SOP) for the sterilisation and anti-rabies vaccination of street dogs, focusing on humane capture, proper post-operative care and the animals' return to the localities from which they are picked up.

The initiative comes amid continuing judicial scrutiny of compliance with the Animal Birth Control (ABC) Rules, 2023, and the Supreme Court's directions on street dog management and rabies prevention.

During a recent hearing, the Delhi High Court took note of a roadmap prepared by noted animal welfare expert Gauri Maulekhi, who is assisting the court as amicus curiae, for implementing sterilisation camps in the capital.

"The model SOP can be shared with the Supreme Court and it can send it to all other High Courts, which can adopt it. Because it has been successful," the court observed during the hearing.

In an order dated October 5, the High Court directed the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) to prepare a roadmap incorporating the Amicus' recommendations and submit it for the court's approval.

Expanding the pilot

The court was informed that sterilisation camps had been held in Anand Vihar and in Circles 6 and 14 of the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), with the results described as satisfactory.

Ms. Maulekhi has prepared detailed, step-by-step roadmaps for the MCD and the NDMC to conduct the pilot exercises, which are intended to serve as a model for expanding the programme across the capital.

The court observed that the initiative could grow into a movement, with residents themselves bringing street dogs to sterilisation centres once they were assured that the animals would be treated humanely.

Ms. Maulekhi has recommended the use of public notices, signboards and placards to inform residents and prevent confusion. The local police station would also have to be notified before an operation begins.

"Each dog shall be collared at the time of arrival at the Centre and ear-notched during sterilisation surgery for the purpose of identification. Dogs must be given a minimum of four days' post-operative care and released in the same area after sterilisation and immunisation in coordination with the registered feeders," the proposed roadmap states.

Need for improvement

During the hearing, Ms. Maulekhi pointed to disparities in the condition of ABC centres across Delhi like absence of isolation wards, staffing and veterinary facilities.

Ms. Maulekhi, a member of the Uttar Pradesh State Animal Birth Control Monitoring Committee, said that following her intervention, the Lucknow Municipal Corporation (LMC) had agreed to conduct a training workshop in Delhi.

The court has directed the MCD and NDMC to coordinate with the LMC.

Former BJP MLA killed in clash with villagers over stone crusher dispute in Rajasthan's Bharatpur

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR



Atar Singh Bhadana

Former Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) MLA Atar Singh Bhadana, 73, died after being allegedy attacked in a clash with villagers over a stone crusher in Rajasthan's Bharatpur district on Sunday night.

Mr. Bhadana, a Haryana native who represented Bayana in the Assembly from 2003 to 2008, was trying to reopen the crusher in Bhonda village, under Weir police station, after about a year. Villagers had been protesting against the proposed reopening of the crusher for the past fortnight. They also opposed the movement of heavy mining vehicles through land they claimed belonged to the village panchayat and was reserved for grazing.

When Mr. Bhadana and his supporters tried to remove protesters, a group of villagers allegedly attacked him and his associate Gagan Sharma with sticks and stones. Villagers accused him and his supporters of assaulting them.

Both were taken to Weir's Community Health Centre. Mr. Bhadana was referred to Sawai Man Singh Hospital in Jaipur, where he died during treatment.

His wife, Kamlesh, named 30 persons in a complaint on Monday, alleging police and administrative inaction despite repeated reports of problems. "The electricity connection to the mining lease was disconnected, the water pump was damaged, and people visiting the site were frequently driven away," she said.

Police registered an FIR and handed over the body after a post-mortem by a medical board. More than 200 personnel were deployed in Bhonda, Raipur and adjoining areas.

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Karnataka HC strikes down law increasing SC/ST quota

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

In a major blow to the State government, the Karnataka High Court on Monday struck down an attempt to increase reservation for Scheduled Castes (SCs) and Scheduled Tribes (STs) beyond the 50% ceiling, holding that the enhancement was "constitutionally impermissible."

A Division Bench with Chief Justice Vibhu Bakhru and Justice K.S. Hemalekha declared Sections 3 and 4 of the Karnataka Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (Reservation of Seats in Educational Institutions and of Appointments or Posts in the Services under the State) Act, 2022 *ultra vires* the Constitution and struck down these two provisions.

During Bommai regime

The Act, which came into force retrospectively from November 1, 2022, during the previous Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government under Basavaraj Bommai, had increased reservation for SCs from 15% to 17% and for STs from 3% to 7%.

Since the 32% reservation for Other Backward Classes (OBCs) remained unchanged, the aggregate reservation in the State rose from 50% to 56%, breaching the judicially established 50% ceiling laid down by the Supreme Court in the 1992 case of *Indra Sawhney vs Union of India (1992)* and subsequently reaffirmed in numerous decisions.

How can Karnataka clear Cauvery water backlog amid drought, SC asks T.N.

Tamil Nadu says 11.719 tmc ft shortfall is hurting Samba cultivation; Karnataka cites water scarcity and drinking-water needs, says the neighbouring State had advantage of northeast monsoon

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI



Water woes: The court said it would pass its order on Tamil Nadu's application shortly. K. MURALI KUMAR

The Supreme Court on Monday questioned Tamil Nadu on how Karnataka could be expected to make good the backlog in the release of Cauvery water when the latter was itself grappling with water scarcity and drought conditions.

"A backlog can be covered only when there is excess water. If there is less rainfall and there is scarcity, how do you expect them to fulfil the backlog? They are also reeling from water scarcity. If they have excess water and are not giving it to you, then only can you recover the backlog," a Division Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath observed.

The Bench reserved its order on an application filed by Tamil Nadu in the decades-old Cauvery water-sharing dispute. The State has contended that there is a shortfall of 11.719 thousand million cubic feet (tmc ft) in the flows due to it at Billigundulu, the inter-State boundary measuring point, up to October 6.

The State also accused Karnataka of withholding water despite having sufficient reserves, pointing to a combined reservoir storage of approximately 49 tmc ft, which it maintained was adequate to meet its water-sharing obligations to the lower riparian State.

Senior advocate Mukul Rohatgi, appearing for Tamil Nadu, argued that deficient rainfall could not mean that one State alone should bear the brunt of the resulting shortage. He submitted that in a distress year, the available water must be apportioned proportionately among the States, and that Tamil Nadu continued to face a deficit of 11.719 tmc ft even after its entitlement was reduced to account for the prevailing conditions.

"In a distress year, you cannot get the same [quantity] as in a normal year. So there has to be a proportionate reduction from the full flow to a distress flow. Even in the distress flow, the backlog is 11 tmc ft," Mr. Rohatgi submitted.

The court was told that the continuing shortfall was severely affecting Samba cultivation and the livelihoods of farmers in the Cauvery Delta. "11 tmc ft is my shortfall. A shortfall is not a shortfall of money that you can make up after one year or six months," Mr. Rohatgi said.

Karnataka's stand

Karnataka, represented by senior advocate Shyam Divan, however, sought to distinguish its position from that of Tamil Nadu. He submitted that while both States were grappling with water scarcity, Tamil Nadu had the advantage of the impending northeast monsoon, which was expected to replenish its reservoirs in the Cauvery basin.

"They have one great advantage which we don't have, and that is the northeast monsoon. It feeds their reservoirs, but it does not help us... There is hope for Tamil Nadu to get replenishment through this monsoon," Mr. Divan submitted.

He said Karnataka was itself facing an acute drought, with several districts notified as drought-affected. The prevailing conditions, he said, had forced the State to curtail irrigation releases and conserve its limited water reserves to safeguard drinking water requirements.

"Several districts of ours have been notified in phases as drought-affected... The available water for Karnataka might be around 57 tmc ft, out of which around 45 tmc ft is required to meet the drinking water requirements of Bengaluru metropolitan city and other urban areas," he said.

Karnataka also submitted that it was complying with the direction of the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) to ensure a daily average flow of 3,000 cusecs at Billigundulu for Tamil Nadu.

The Bench said it would pass its order on Tamil Nadu's application shortly.

Keralam VACB registers two FIRs in CMRL pay-off case

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Kerala Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) has registered two separate cases in connection with the allegations surrounding the financial transactions between Cochin Minerals and Rutile Limited (CMRL) and Exalogic Solutions Pvt. Ltd. involving former Chief Minister and present Leader of the Opposition in the State Assembly Pinarayi Vijayan, his daughter T. Veena and her husband, former Minister P.A. Mohamed Riyas, MLA.

Mr. Vijayan has been included in the one of the two First Information Reports, which concerns the alleged corruption and payments made by CMRL to Exalogic Solutions, a now-defunct IT company owned by Ms. Veena, the second accused in the case.

According to the FIR, Mr. Vijayan has been accused of entering into a criminal conspiracy with the others, abusing his official position and adopting corrupt means to obtain illicit pecuniary benefits for himself, his daughter and her company from 2016 to 2020.

Second case

Mr. Riyas and Ms. Veena have been booked as the first and second accused respectively in the second case, in which they have been accused of involvement in hawala transactions and transfer of illicit cash to foreign countries.



Encouraging innovation: Prime Minister Narendra Modi interacting with start-up entrepreneurs in the presence of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay during their Metro Rail ride on Sunday. PTI

T.N. start-ups pitch their ideas to PM during Metro ride

Sangeetha Kandavel
CHENNAI

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay took an inaugural Metro Rail ride from Porur Bypass to Poonamallee and back on Sunday, some people carrying files and folders were seen interacting with him on board.

Upon watching the videos of the ride, many presumed they must have been officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limited.

However, those seated with the files, were actually start-up entrepreneurs from across Tamil Nadu explaining about their ventures to Mr. Modi, as Mr. Vijay looked on. It is learnt that over 15 start-up founders were on board the Metro Rail to meet the Prime Minister.

Vignesh Kandasamy from Tirunelveli, who is the founder and CEO of Thazhal Geospatial Analytics Pvt. Ltd., said: "We explained about Thazhal's space technology solutions and how satellite-based assessment can track physical construction and its progress, delays, and risk, which helps to get greater transparency and accountability to the nation."

Those who met Mr. Modi said they had been allotted around under two minutes each for the interaction.

Suseendar Marimuthu, CEO of Blunav, said Mr. Modi enquired about how his company's solutions could help airports operate more efficiently and make air travel accessible to the wider population.

Ramesh Kumar, co-founder & CEO of Grahaa Space, said: "In July, we successfully launched and deployed our nano-satellite (called SOLARAS) in low-earth orbit through Vikram-1 by Skyroot Aerospace. We attempted an orbital launch from Alcantara Space Center, Brazil, through a South Korean rocket."

Mr. Modi encouraged Mr. Ramesh to contribute to the space economy.

INBRIEF



Four killed as car catches fire after hitting a railing in A.P.

Four people, including a three-year-old boy, died on the spot, and one woman suffered grievous injuries after a car carrying them hit the roadside railing and caught fire on West Bypass Road on the outskirts of Vijayawada in Andhra Pradesh on Monday. The victims were returning after attending a function at Namburu. The vehicle was gutted, said NTR District Fire Officer A.V. Shankar Rao. "We are examining CCTV footage and gathering information from eyewitnesses [about the incident]," the police said.

Srisailam Project gets a place in World Book of Records

The Srisailam Dam Project earned a place in the World Book of Records for its remarkable engineering features and extraordinary resilience. It is the first project in India to achieve this distinction, said M. Venugopal Reddy, Superintending Engineer of Srisailam Project. The project, whose construction began in 1960 and was completed in 1980, serves both the irrigation and hydel power generation purpose. Mr. Reddy attributed the award to the project's engineering features, which includes the massive crest gates measuring 60x55 feet.

Former security guard held for murder of five-year-old girl

A former security guard, who allegedly kidnapped and murdered a five-year-old girl before concealing her body in a water sump at a gated community in Kowkoor in Telangana, was arrested by Malkajgiri police. The accused had planned to extort ₹20 lakh from the child's parents but decided to kill her after realising that keeping her captive until the ransom was paid would be difficult, the police said. Families residing in the gated community in Kowkoor gathered at a camp office in Begumpet and demanded strict action against the accused.

Keralam Assembly passes resolution seeking CEC's exit

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam Assembly on Monday passed a resolution seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and steps to improve transparency in the functioning of the Election Commission of India (ECI).

The ruling United Democratic Front (UDF) and the Opposition Left Democratic Front (LDF) supported the resolution moved by Keralam Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan.

The Bharatiya Janata Party objected to the contents of the resolution and proposed amendments, but they were rejected.

The House expressed concern over the accusations levelled against the ECI, while observing that free, transparent, and impartial elections and universal adult franchise constituted the basis of Indian democracy. "Given the circumstances where serious doubts have been raised about the impartiality of the ECI, it is imperative that steps be taken to remove the CEC...," the resolution said.

It also urged the Centre and the ECI to address the defects in the special intensive revision (SIR) exercise.

100 detained as police crack down on anti-SIR protesters in Bengaluru

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Protesters who tried to march to the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO), Karnataka's office here on Monday, to condemn the Delhi Police's treatment of demonstrators protesting against the special intensive revision (SIR), faced similar heavy-handedness from the Bengaluru City Police.

At least 100 people were detained, and students, lawyers, and women protesters were allegedly manhandled. Senior journalist and activist Aakar Patel was detained. The police threatened journalists covering the protest and ordered them to leave the spot, while three photographers were manhandled, despite repeatedly identifying themselves as members of the press.



A protester being detained by the Bengaluru Police during an anti-SIR protest near KR circle on Monday. J. ALLEN EGENUSE

Several protesters, most of them students, were forcibly pushed into buses by police personnel, many of whom were not in uniform. Male police personnel were seen forcing women protesters into buses, with the police arguing that the protesters would return to the spot if they were released.

A senior police officer, however, defended the actions, arguing that the police did not know about the protest and were taken by surprise. Given only Freedom Park is the designated protest site, they were bound to detain protesters outside that venue. He said that since the police were not aware, the force included mostly male personnel. The protest was organised by Left student and youth bodies across Karnataka.

New Keralam Bill to focus on dignity of senior citizens, protection of rights

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Keralam Senior Citizens (Care and Protection) Bill, 2026, that will be tabled in the Assembly on Tuesday aims at promoting healthy and active ageing, registration and regulation of senior citizen care centres, and protection of rights, dignity, and social security of the elderly.

The Bill underscores the principles of right to dignity, ageing in place and home-based care, safety and social care ecosystem, and senior citizens' participation in policy making. Thrust is given to rights such as access care, safe public spaces, digital inclusion, legal aid, reporting of abuse, and access to dignity-preserving products.



Giving care: The Bill points out that the population of the elderly has been increasing in Keralam. GETTY IMAGES

The Bill points out that the population of the elderly has been increasing in Keralam. However, modernisation and globalisation had paved the way for nuclear families, adversely affecting the living conditions of the elderly. In order to accommodate their needs, various systems need to be put in place and long-term forward planning is required.

It calls for urgent policy intervention to integrate and standardise home-based health-care services and create a legal framework for their operation.

It aims at ensuring that older persons are not marginalised or left unprotected, advocating for their financial security, health care, shelter, and protection of rights.

Protection unit

According to the Bill, the government will set up a State Senior Citizen Protection Unit, besides a District Senior Citizen Protection Forum in each district.

Training to caregivers, with phased certification compliance, is another aspect. It proposes that the government establish a 'Keralam Geriatric Care Certification Framework' providing progressive certification pathways for caregivers. A 'State Register of Caregivers' is also mooted in the Bill.

Lakshadweep turns 100% literate under govt.'s ULLAS scheme

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

Lakshadweep was declared a 100% literate Union Territory on Sunday. The declaration was made by Administrator Praful Patel, marking the achievement of full literacy status under the ULLAS-Nav Bharat Saaksharta Karyakram, according to a communication.

According to the Department of Education, an initial survey identified 1,113 adult non-literates across the islands. Intensive teaching and assessment drives were subsequently undertaken to equip the identified learners with foundational literacy and numeracy skills.

The department claimed that all eligible learners had successfully cleared the Foundational Literacy and Numeracy Assessment Test (FLNAT), enabling Lakshadweep to attain full literacy status under ULLAS, a Centrally sponsored scheme.

Doorstep assessments

Teachers and supervisors volunteered to conduct doorstep and home-based assessments for learners who were unable or hesitant to attend designated examination centres. Follow-up assessments and retesting were also organised to ensure that eligible learners completed the evaluation process, according to the communication.

BJP slams Rahul's remark, says Cong. aiming for anarchy

Devesh K. Pandey
NEW DELHI


Shivraj Singh Chouhan

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Monday slammed Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi for describing the Opposition's protest march in Delhi as "*Shiv ki baraat*" (Lord Shiva's wedding procession). The BJP also accused him of harbouring anti-Hindu sentiments and alleged that the Congress-led agitation was aimed at creating anarchy.

"The top leadership of the Congress is completely directionless. Just a moment ago, they were saying that the Congress is like *Shivji ki baraat*. Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan said at a press conference. He described the protesters as troublemakers attempting to spread chaos on the streets.

He added, "The Congress leader has not even the right to invoke Lord Shiva's name." He also alleged that the principal Opposition party and its allies had become puppets in the hands of foreign powers.

Former Union Minister and BJP leader Anurag Thakur, at a separate press briefing, said: "Wherever Rahul Gandhi and his party find an opportunity, whether in Parliament or on the streets, they make remarks about *Sanatana Dharma*, insult it, or invoke it for their own political objectives. That is what they do, Ali, Ali at night; bajrang bali during the day."

BJP spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari, in a post on X, described Mr. Gandhi as a "*chunavi Hindu*" (election-time Hindu) and accused him of comparing himself to Lord Shiva. "Shame on Rahul Gandhi! He compares his protest to *Shivji ki baraat*. This not only exposes his anti-Hindu hate; this also tells you that this man, who is a *chunavi Hindu*, is comparing himself to *bhagwan Shiv!* (lord Shiva)," he said.

Police denotify Jantar Mantar as designated protest venue

Ramlila Maidan, Burari Ground, CBD Ground named as alternative sites; police yet to issue SOPs for protests; activists oppose decision, cite Jantar Mantar's proximity to Parliament, govt. offices

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI


The denotification comes amid protests over the role of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

The Delhi Police on Monday denotified Jantar Mantar as a designated venue for protests and demonstrations, replacing one of the capital's longest-established sites of public dissent with three alternative grounds farther from the seat of power. The move drew criticism from activists, who said relocating demonstrations would make it harder for citizens to draw the attention of political leaders and decision-makers to their demands.

Under a standing order issued by Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, Ramlila Maidan, around 4 km from Jantar Mantar, Burari Ground, around 15 km away, and CBD Ground in East Delhi, around 13 km away, have been designated as protest venues.

The order follows recommendations from a committee constituted by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs to examine alternative venues where citizens could protest. The police said revised standard operating procedures (SOPs) for demonstrations at the three grounds would be issued separately.

Standing Order

The decision partially modifies Standing Order No. L&O/48/22, dated April 28, 2022, which laid down guidelines for organising protests, sit-ins and public demonstrations in Delhi. The earlier order identified Jantar Mantar as a designated site, with the stated aim of ensuring adequate space for demonstrations while minimising disruption to residents and traffic. It restricted protests to hours between 10 a.m. and 5 p.m., and did not permit a programme to continue for more than a day at a time.

For protesters who have used Jantar Mantar for years, its significance lay not merely in the availability of space to assemble, but in its proximity to Parliament, government offices and the press.

Bhim Kumar, who has been part of protests for more than 15 years, said the location had enabled demonstrators to bring their demands directly to elected representatives and those in power.

Social activist Shabnam Hashmi, who has been part of protests since 1975, traced the significance of Jantar Mantar to the gradual narrowing of the space available for public demonstrations in the capital.

The denotification comes amid protests over the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and demands for Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar's resignation.

HC to hear plea against protest site 'closure'

NEW DELHI
The Delhi HC will hear on Tuesday two petitions concerning the closure of Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site in Delhi and the alleged assault on protesters during the October 10 protests, with petitioners seeking urgent intervention over restrictions on peaceful protests.

Opposition, CJP flay 'assault' on people's fundamental rights

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI


Saurav Das

Opposition parties and youth groups on Monday strongly condemned the Delhi Police's decision to denotify Jantar Mantar as the designated protest site in Delhi.

Hours before the decision, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leaders Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka had submitted a letter to the Deputy Commissioner of Police, New Delhi district, seeking a date and time to hold a peaceful protest at Jantar Mantar within 24 hours. "CJP will also announce a new date for mass protest if you fail to respond and allocate us the designated protest site Jantar Mantar," the group said in the letter.

Reacting to the Delhi Police's decision, the CJP called it "unacceptable" and warned that the "entire country will become Jantar Mantar". "Jantar Mantar belongs to the people of India. Did the Ministry of Home Affairs consult the people of India? CJP does not accept this arbitrary decision as it an assault on people's fundamental right to protest and peaceful assembly," Mr. Das said. Hitting out at Prime Minister Narendra Modi, he said: "The Prime Minister will soon denotify democracy in India."

CJP's founder Abhijeet Dipke said, "Jantar Mantar is not just a location but a spirit of resistance."

Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh called the decision a sign of "extreme panic". "It is a definite sign of the extreme panic that has gripped the PM-HM duo that the historic Jantar Mantar will no longer be a place where our democracy is given a daily booster dose," he posted on X. Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav also criticised the decision, calling it the "biggest defeat" of the BJP government.

SC had flagged need for alternative protest sites

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI


In 2018, the Supreme Court had declared the 'golden rule' that the right to protest must be balanced with the right of the residents to live peacefully. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

Exactly three days before the Delhi Police denotified central Delhi's Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site on Monday, the Supreme Court and the Union government were on the same page about finding an alternative site to "peacefully and lawfully" express dissent in the national capital.

On October 9, both the court and the government had reasoned that central Delhi was too cramped for protests. Observations and remarks were also exchanged about how inconvenient protests in and around Jantar Mantar were to ordinary commuters in Delhi. The Chief Justice of India remarked that central Delhi did not have any washroom, medical and drinking water facilities.

The four-page order passed on October 9 actually records the Supreme Court Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant urging the Union government to look for a "spacious, open" alternative site.

The order was passed during the October 9 hearing on petitions challenging the government's move to restrict access into and within the national capital, aimed at halting the October 10 protests demanding the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. At the time of hearing, the protest was expected to happen at Jantar Mantar.

The order said all the parties, including the petitioners, were in favour of finding an alternative protest site in Delhi.

'No basic amenities'

"During the course of hearing, it was suggested, and counsel for the parties were *ad idem* [of the same mind], that it is high time **The SC order said all the parties were in favour of finding an alternative protest site in Delhi**

basic amenities were provided to those engaged in peaceful and lawful protest. To that end, suitable alternative sites capable of housing such infrastructure need to be identified and designated. Let the competent authority consider this suggestion and take an appropriate decision thereon," the October 9 order said.

Previously, in August, the court had made a similar suggestion to Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, who was appearing for the Union government authorities.

Another protest venue

The petition had sought the discontinuation of Jantar Mantar as the ordinary designated venue for public protests and demonstrations, and to designate Ramlila Maidan, or another sufficiently large and secure ground, as the principal protest venue.

As per a Standing Order on Guidelines For Holding Protests or Demonstrations in Delhi issued by Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar, Ramlila Maidan, Burari ground in north Delhi and CBD ground in East Delhi have been designated as new protest venues.

In 2018, the top court had declared the "golden rule" that the right to protest must be balanced with the right of the residents to live peacefully.

In its 2020 judgment in the *Shaheen Bagh* case, the court had held that fundamental rights did not live in isolation. "The right of the protester has to be balanced with the right of the commuter," the court said.

Won't allow autopsy of beheaded man: Naga bodies to govt.

The Hindu Bureau
GUWAHATI

The Working Committee of the Joint Tribes Council-Manipur has set the Centre and the Manipur government a 48-hour deadline to find the missing head of a Naga man from the "Kuki SoO-sheltered terrorists".

SoO stands for Suspension of Operations, which the Centre had signed with 25 Kuki and Zomi armed groups in 2008. In a statement on Sunday night, the council also said it would not allow the authorities to conduct a post-mortem on the man's body while "terrorists" treated his head as a trophy.

Naga organisations have accused Kuki extremists of attacking Naga villagers in the Kuki-majority Kangpokpi district on Saturday. Ajinbou R. was beheaded in an attack in which three other Nagas – Dibambou Ringkangmai, Machungamang Daimai and Ramningpou Gangmei – were also killed. Their killing followed that of five others – two Nagas, two Kukis and a Gurkha farmer – in separate attacks in Naga-dominated Kamjong and Ukhrul districts on Friday and Saturday.

The council declared that it would not let the authorities conduct post-mortemon Ajinbou and Dibambou until the former's decapitated head was recovered and returned to the family. The organisation warned that if the two governments failed to comply within 48 hours, it would be forced to take the most stringent measures "at our disposal to secure justice."

MP moves SC alleging 'illegal detention', 'torture' of DYFI leaders

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Rajya Sabha MP A.A. Rahim moved the Supreme Court on Monday alleging illegal detention, "secret transportation" in specialised compartmentalised vehicles, and custodial torture of Democratic Youth Federation of India (DYFI) office-bearers, Central Committee members and activists by the police on October 11 at Connaught Place in the national capital.

Mr. Rahim, represented by advocate Subhash Chandran K.R., sought a declaration, binding guidelines, an independent inquiry and compensation from the Union government. The MP has arraigned the Home Ministry as a respondent.

He has sought an independent court-monitored inquiry into the illegal detention and custodial torture, with directions to register an FIR against the officers found responsible for the detention of the members, office-bearers and Central Committee members.

"They were not taken to any police station. Instead, while still near Connaught Place, the bus was driven to a closed and heavily guarded space in front of the Daryaganj restaurant, away from public view...The detainees were then forcibly shifted into a specialised police van divided into five separate cells," the petition said.

"Inside the cells of the van, the detainees were beaten. Several of the personnel wore no name badges," the petition said.

"The detainees were released only at about 7.30 p.m. on October 11," the petition said.

The plea sought a declaration that the detention and the use of curtained, compartmentalised or otherwise sealed vehicles as places of detention as illegal and violative of fundamental rights.

Neither approved nor disapproved changes to Form 6, clarifies top court

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI


The May 27 judgment on the Bihar SIR had observed that Form 6 was a guide to the SIR verification process. FILE PHOTO

The Supreme Court on Monday clarified that it had neither approved nor disapproved the controversial alterations made to Form 6 in its May 27 judgment, which was entirely about the legality of the pilot special intensive revision (SIR) process in Bihar.

The court said the May 27 ruling pre-dated the changes made to Form 6. The changes and modified declarations, which required applicants to provide ancestry details or linkage to previous SIR rolls on the ECINet portal, were introduced in July.

"When the Bihar SIR issue was heard and decided, the new Form 6 was not there. The new Form 6 was neither approved nor disapproved by us. But we will examine it now," Justice Joymalya Bagchi, who is part of the Bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, observed orally. The remarks came in response to a petition filed by Priya Mishra against the Union government challenging the alterations made to Form 6 to register new voters during the SIR exercises undertaken across multiple States.

The counsel for the petitioner recounted the Chief Justice of India's oral remark on October 5.

The lawyer said that the CJI had commented that alterations in Form 6 were "not approved by us". He said that despite the CJI's remarks, the Election Commission has continued to justify the changes to Form 6, claiming the court has approved them.

SIR judgment

The May 27 judgment on the Bihar SIR had observed that Form 6 was a guide to the SIR verification process. The court said that the Form 6 used in Bihar SIR "set out a framework of documentation".

"It is neither practicable nor desirable for the verification process to be left entirely unguided or subjective. It is true that Form 6, as prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, sets out a framework of documentation; however, the same is tailored to the process of revision contemplated under Section 21(2) of the Representation of the People Act," the May 27 judgment authored by Chief Justice Kant had observed.

On October 5, dthe CJI had sharply reacted to submissions about the July alterations in the Form 6. "We are making it clear, any modifications to Form 6 have not been made by us," the Chief Justice had said.

Form 6 is a statutory document in the Schedule of the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960. Modifications to Form 6 should be done only through a proper lawmaking process.

Dipke hits out at Modi, says he and his family faced mental torture due to Delhi Police

Vinaya Deshpande Pandit
MUMBAI

The CJP founder seeks release of 'unedited interaction footage' with the Delhi Police officials

Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Monday accused the Delhi Police of mentally torturing him and his family after informing him of his grandmother's death during his preventive detention last week. He alleged that the police did not allow him to speak to his cousin about his grandmother's death and instead asked him to call his grieving parents.

"Today, Modi denotified Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site. Tomorrow, he will denotify democracy itself. The dictator's problem was never the protest site. It was the very idea of people protesting," he posted on X. He asked the Delhi Police to release the complete, unedited footage of their interaction with him when they informed him of his grandmother's death.

"They wanted to stress me out and cause tension to my parents. This was mental torture that my family and I faced due to the Delhi Police. If they told me about the death of my grandmother, why did they come to me with arrest papers at 3:30 a.m. and ask me to sign them? They asked me to talk to my parents, but I said they had health issues and asked them to call my cousin, who was with my grandmother. But they did not even allow me to retrieve his number from the phone," he told presspersonsin Hingoli.

Reacting to the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site, he warned that the entire country would become Jantar Mantar now. "They have removed Jantar Mantar as a designated protest site. Yes, it's no longer a protest site, as it was turned into a war zone by the coward dictator. Ab poora desh Jantar Mantar banega!" he posted on X.

Expressing solidarity with the protestors who hit the streets in Delhi on Monday, he said, "Delhi is once again flooded with people standing up to save democracy. If Modi thinks taking away Jantar Mantar will put an end to protests, he is mistaken. Jantar Mantar is not just a location but a spirit of resistance that nobody can ever take away."



United front: Neha Bora and Yogendra Yadav during the INDIA bloc's protest march to the Supreme Court. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA



Dissenting voices: Students and party workers raise slogans against the special revision exercise and CEC on Monday. ANI



Appeal for change: Lawyers joining the protest March led by Rahul Gandhi to the top court in New Delhi. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP



Team effort: INDIA bloc leaders proceed towards the Supreme Court during the 'March for Democracy' in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

Rahul likens Opposition protest to Shiva's *tandav*

Congress leader claims the CEC has sent him messages, and over 200 government officials give information to them; he asks Mr. Kumar to turn approver saying the latter has made a mistake

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI



Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi addressing media at Congress Headquarters in New Delhi on Monday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, on Monday compared the repeated protests by the Opposition against alleged "vote *chori* (theft)" to Lord Shiva's *tandav* (cosmic dance), while claiming that Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar had sent him messages.

"This is *tandav*, Lord Shiva's dance. There is no planning here," Mr. Gandhi said in response to a question on the Opposition's future strategy on the issue, adding, "There is no need for a plan. A dance is going on, Lord Shiva's dance. And anyone can join Shivji *ki baraat* (the wedding procession of Lord Shiva)."

The Opposition leader addressed a press conference at the Indira Bhavan, before parties belonging to the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) marched towards the Supreme Court from the Barakhamba Road intersection.

Mr. Gandhi claimed that as many as 200 officers of the Narendra Modi government had kept providing information to them, and used his press conference to address Mr. Kumar directly, reiterating his suggestion that the CEC turn an approver in the alleged vote *chori* issue.

"We know Gyanesh Kumar is unable to sleep at night. I am telling him directly – you will not survive as CEC," he said.

To a specific question on whether the CEC had tried to get in touch with him at any point of time, Mr. Gandhi said, "Messages come and I know he is watching this press conference."

"Turn approver. You [Mr. Kumar] have made a mistake but you are not the mind behind the mistake. We are after the people who are behind what you did," Mr. Gandhi said, when asked if he had any message for the CEC.

Mr. Gandhi also talked of patience and perseverance, saying the principle of resistance is not "a matter of one day".

"We will not retreat and we will not get tired. Why? Because the truth is with us. Those who are trying to protect lies will get tired," he said, adding, "Mr. Modi, let me tell you that 200 officers of your government are in touch with us, giving information, from with the ED (Enforcement Directorate), CBI (Central Bureau of Investigation), Foreign Ministry. Do whatever you want, the truth is with us."

Asked to comment on parallel protests by various civil society groups, Mr. Gandhi said: "There are no parallel protests, there is one protest, the protest is to remove Gyanesh Kumar and then after that remove Mr. Prime Minister, Mr. Amit Shah. We are not going to stop."

Rahul, other INDIA leaders move SC for full disclosure of records on SIR

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Collective action: Congress leaders K.C. Venugopal and Mallikarjun Kharge at the Supreme Court to file a petition against SIR. PTI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, along with other leaders of Opposition parties, moved the Supreme Court on Monday seeking a full and complete disclosure of "files, agendas, minutes, notings and objections" recorded by Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi on the special intensive revision (SIR) process, which has so far led to the deletion of about 13 crore voters from electoral rolls across India.

Mr. Gandhi sought a judicial examination of the Election Commission of India (ECI) records to verify whether Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar acted arbitrarily and unilaterally during the ongoing SIR. The Congress leader said the petition highlights serious concerns regarding the integrity of the electoral process itself under the SIR.

He argued that the aftermath of the SIR has witnessed the infringement of the constitutional right of eligible citizens to be registered as voters and to exercise their right to vote.

He sought an interim direction from the Supreme Court to suspend the SIR pending consideration and adjudication of the issues raised in the petition in order to protect the rights of eligible electors and preserve the integrity of the electoral process.

"The right to vote belongs to every eligible citizen irrespective of political affiliation, and its protection is a constitutional imperative that transcends party politics," the petition, represented by senior advocate A.M. Singhvi and filed through advocate Prasanna S., said.

The petition reproduced an excerpt of Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant's response to Mr. Gandhi and co-petitioner and Congress party president Mallikarjun Kharge to their letter seeking a meeting on Monday. While the CJI had declined the meeting, the top judge had pointed out that pending petitions on identical issues were coming up for hearing on Tuesday.

"If so advised, you may submit your petition on Monday (October 12), either physically at the Supreme Court of India, between 10:30 a.m. and 4:30 p.m... You have my assurance that any such petition shall be heard at the earliest possible opportunity, in accordance with law," the CJI's letter had promised. Mr. Gandhi said the petition was filed banking on the Chief Justice's promise for an early hearing.

Mr. Gandhi and other Opposition leaders marched to the Supreme Court on Monday even though their petition was technically filed at 4.37 p.m. They entered the Supreme Court Registry, verified their supporting documents with the Registry officials and left. The petitioners including Saugata Roy, Akhilesh Yadav, Tejashwi Prasad Yadav, Sanjay Raut, M.A. Baby, D. Raja, Mahua Majhi, Supriya Sule and E.T. Mohammed Basheer – leaders from various political parties in the Opposition bloc – asked the court to direct the ECI to provide ECINET and ERONET access logs and the complete file recording of the June 24, 2025 decision to commence SIR.

The petition asked the court to constitute an independent panel to conduct an independent audit of the deletions and modifications made during the SIR.

Delhi Police accused of denying detainees basic rights

Shrimansi Kaushik
NEW DELHI

Detainees' accounts of beatings, assaults, and excessive force used by the Delhi Police over the past few days have raised concerns about post-detention practices of law enforcement personnel.

Thousands of protesters have been detained by the police in the national capital on October 10, 11, and 12, including journalists, members of youth organisations, and minors.

There was a fresh round of detentions on Monday as youth organisations, including the Naujawan Bharat Sabha, Revolutionary Workers' Party of India (RWPI), and Disha Students' Organisation, carried out a flash mob rally at Barakhamba Road, protesting the denotification of Jantar Mantar as a protest site. They were stopped by the police at Sansad Marg and detained.

"We were put inside a prison-looking van, beaten up, and taken to a detention centre. Women protesters were abused verbally and held by the neck by the police," said RWPI member Vishal.

Another RWPI member, Nishu, said that the police denied requests for water, even after detainees fainted inside the police van. "One of our members fainted and another was feeling dizzy after police detained us brutally from near Jantar Mantar. We shouted and screamed for water but despite having several water bottles with them, they did not give us water," she said, also displaying the multiple bruises and marks on her hands, face, and legs.



Activists detained by Delhi Police in New Delhi on Sunday. ANI

Pattern of violence

This pattern of police violence against detainees caught the spotlight on October 10, when Disha member Aranya was held by the throat by two policewomen inside one of the buses used for detainees, swept off the streets after a rally at Raj Ghat. The next day, on October 11, she was again detained along with other Disha members from Connaught Place. This time, however, the police isolated her and allegedly beat her up. Her fellow activists could hear her screaming from inside a moving prison-van, they said.

"They were beating us up and stealing away our phones from our pockets. Then they isolated Aranya and she was made to lie down on the ground. A policewoman was sitting on her and choking her. Another police woman was hitting her with her elbow. We told her she was facing difficulty breathing but instead of listening to us, she threatened us for making videos and recording the police action on our phones," said Naureen, a Disha member.

Another group of detainees taken to Pandwalan Khurd alleged that they were made to sit down in rows inside the van and hand over their phones before they were thrashed by the police. Arjun Unnikrishan said he, along with fellow protesters, had been transported by bus to an "isolated, enclosed police camp near the LIC building to cut off contact with the public and media."

One of the detainees was journalist M. Rajshekhar, who witnessed the assaults on other detainees though he himself was not beaten.

"I was saved because I told them I was not a protester," he said.

'Democratic protest must take place, but don't drag SC into it'

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI



Justice Surya Kant

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on Monday said that peaceful, democratic, and political protests need to take place, but the "Supreme Court should not be dragged into it" nor become a site for agitations.

"Democratic activities must take place peacefully, but the Supreme Court's functioning should go on smoothly... We are not concerned about any political party... The court should not be dragged into anything. Protests should happen peacefully. There should not be any impediment or obstruction to the movement of lawyers, court staff, litigants... I am requesting," Chief Justice Kant, heading a three-judge Bench comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, said in open court.

Heavy security

The CJI's remarks come even as Opposition leaders were expected to march to the Supreme Court as part of the anti-Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) protests on Monday. The court premises witnessed heavy security presence.

On Monday, the CJI was reacting to an oral mentioning made by the Supreme Court Bar Association, represented by its president and senior advocate Pradeep Rai, against the illegal detentions of lawyers, and the suspension of the Internet.

"We are doing our professional duties. They (the authorities) should not interfere. I have made a statement that political parties should not bring the court into all this. They should be responsible political parties," Mr. Rai submitted.

Another petition represented by senior advocate A.N.S. Nadkarni, appearing for a lawyer, also sought the same protection.

Senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan, in a separate oral mentioning, said he was still waiting for the Bench to admonish the police to maintain restraint, "at least once".

The CJI reiterated that the Bench would not allow the Supreme Court to become a site for protests.

"I don't want to say anything now, but I am only requesting. Every member of the Bar has the right to be part of the protest, wherever the identified locations are there," Chief Justice Kant said.

The senior counsel is also seeking a hearing on October 13. None of the Section 163 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) prohibitory orders were publicly available, he said.

The court agreed to hear all three petitions on October 13.

After 2 days of crackdown, thousands march in capital

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

Thousands of people poured onto central Delhi's streets on Monday, marching alongside buses carrying leaders of the Indian National Developmental, Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) and chanting slogans against the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Election Commission of India (ECI). Personnel of the Delhi Police and the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) facilitated the procession towards the Supreme Court as protesters waved placards and jostled for a glimpse of the leaders.

The scene was a stark departure from the preceding two days, when student protesters attempting to mobilise in the same parts of the Capital were rounded up, bundled into police buses and taken away. Several alleged that they had been assaulted during detention, while journalists covering the protests also reported being detained.



In lockstep: The INDIA bloc rally began at the Constitution Club of India on Rafi Marg in New Delhi on Monday. PTI

Protest demands

The demands remained the same: rollback of the special intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls and the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar. But Monday's mass rally, led by senior Opposition leaders and joined by student organisations including the All India Students' Association (AISA), the Students' Federation of India (SFI) and the Krantikari Yuva Sangathan (KYS), presented a striking contrast to the police action against students and activists who had tried to demonstrate over the weekend.

The INDIA bloc rally began at the Constitution Club of India on Rafi Marg.

Placards and banners reading 'Gyanesh Go Back' rose above the crowd as demonstrators chanted, "*Vote chor kahan milenge, BJP ke daftar mein*" and "*Modi-Shah haye haye*". Others hailed Mr. Gandhi and student leader Neha Bora.

As the buses moved through the crowd, protesters pushed their way forward to catch a glimpse of the leaders, waving their hands and holding up placards. The rally moved amid announcements about the prohibitory restrictions imposed under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS) in New Delhi and heavy security deployment.

As the march moved from Raisina Road, police personnel opened the barricades at the Shangri-La roundabout to let the procession pass.

'Allow free movement'

On Sunday, the Supreme Court convened what it called an "extraordinary, exceptional" hearing to direct the Union government and the Delhi Police to stop illegal detentions and allow free and smooth movement of people and traffic, as well as the operations of Metro and rail services, but "subject to law and public order".

For Aditi, a student who had joined the protests at Jantar Mantar on both days, the contrast between Monday and the two preceding days raised a larger question: why did people need political leaders alongside them to make their voices heard?

Amel Rahman, who travelled from Bengaluru to Delhi to join the planned October 10 protest, said she was relieved to finally participate in a march. However, seeing police and CRPF personnel facilitate Monday's rally was also a reminder of the treatment protesters had alleged during the preceding demonstrations.

"For the last two days, I was there, ready with a placard, and all set to protest. But the fear was that I would be detained in the first minute. That was the trade-off we had to make, and it is sad," she said.

INBRIEF



Need to balance faith, health in firecracker policy, says SC

The Supreme Court on Monday highlighted the need to balance religious sentiments with public health concerns while considering restrictions on firecrackers in the national capital . "We will not hurt religious sentiments but at the same time, people should themselves come forward and opt for it," Chief Justice Surya Kant said. The Bench, however, cautioned against imposing restrictions that could prove difficult to enforce on the ground. "We have to make people wiser and bring awareness," the CJI said.

13 lakh names dropped from final electoral rolls in Punjab

The final electoral rolls of all 117 Assembly constituencies were published on Monday following the completion of Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Punjab. The names of around 13.60 lakh people went unrecorded as a result of permanent relocation, absence, death or duplicate entries. "During the house-to-house enumeration phase , Booth Level Officers distributed enumeration forms to registered electors . The draft electoral roll was published on August 13, 2026 with a total of 1,93,94,435 electors," Chief Electoral Officer said.

Work out a plan for capping prices of all drugs: SC to govt.

Government proposes a 30% trade-margin cap on patented and non-patented cancer medicines, but the top court asks why the cap cannot be extended to all medicines and medical products

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Even as the Centre informed the Supreme Court on Monday that it had decided to cap trade margins at 30% for non-scheduled cancer drugs, the court questioned why the benefit of such a price regulation should be confined to cancer drugs and not extended to other essential medicines and medical products.

The development comes after a Bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta expressed concern over stark disparities between the price to retailer (PTR) and the maximum retail price (MRP) of certain medicines, particularly cancer drugs, with mark-ups in some instances soaring to 1,000%. The Bench had flagged that such exorbitant mark-ups constituted "broad daylight dacoity".

Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre, informed the Bench that the proposed 30% trade-margin cap would cover both patented and non-patented cancer medicines.



Availability of price-controlled medicine is government's responsibility. GETTY IMAGES

The Bench, however, said that while the intervention was commendable, it was inadequate, and questioned why other medicines and medical devices could not also be brought within the 16% retailer margin prescribed under the Drugs (Prices Control) Order (DPCO), 2013. "This is just the tip of the iceberg... What about other drugs," the Bench asked.

The top court was hearing petitions filed by advocate Kishan Chand Jain and paediatric surgeon Sanjay Kulshrestha seeking stricter enforcement of price controls under the DPCO to curb disproportionate margins across the pharmaceutical supply chain.

Justice Mehta drew attention to steep markups on medical devices and consumables, pointing out that an India-made cardiac stent costing around ₹5,000 was being sold by hospitals for more than ₹25,000.

"We understand that there are transportation costs, raw material costs, R&D costs and other ancillary costs, but all these are included in the MRP. What is the logic behind allowing them to sell at 400 times the actual cost? How can you allow this? What is the benefit for the patients?" the Bench observed.

Additional Solicitor-General Aishwarya Bhati, also appearing for the Centre, cautioned against a uniform cap across medicines. The Bench, however, was not persuaded, observing that ensuring the availability of price-controlled medicines was the government's responsibility. The Bench gave the Centre until October 27 to work out the modalities for capping medicine prices, when the matter will be heard next.

Healthcare centres must display costs of services: Centre

Bindu Shajan Perappadan
NEW DELHI

The Union Health Ministry has asked all States and Union Territories to ensure the prominent display of rates charged for services and facilities offered by clinical establishments.

In a move aimed at strengthening transparency, accountability and patient-centric healthcare delivery, Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava, in a letter to the Chief Secretaries of all States and Union Territories, called for compliance with regulatory provisions, and ensuring information on service charges was clearly visible to patients and their attendants.



The move aims to strengthen transparency. GETTY IMAGES

Two rules

The letter refers to the Clinical Establishments (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2010 and the Clinical Establishments (Central Government) Rules, 2012. Under the Rules, clinical establishments in States and Union Territories where the Act is applicable are required to display the rates charged for each type of service provided, along with facilities available, at a conspicuous place, in the local language as well as in English.

"Display of rates would help patients and their families understand the likely cost of treatment, make informed healthcare decisions, and plan their medical expenditure," Ms. Srivastava said.

The letter emphasises transparency in healthcare pricing for international patients. The States and Union Territories have been requested to prominently display package rates offered to foreign patients travelling to India on medical or Ayush visas.

NSA Ajit Doval speaks to Iran counterpart amid attacks on ships in the Strait of Hormuz

Suhasini Haidar
NEW DELHI

National Security Adviser (NSA) Ajit Doval spoke to his Iranian counterpart, Mohsin Rezaei, on Monday evening, the Iranian government said, a day after two merchant ships with Indian crew members were attacked in the Strait of Hormuz.

The External Affairs Ministry on Sunday condemned the targeting of the two ships, the Nicaragua-flagged MT *Petro Dolphin* and the Marshall Islands-flagged MT *Valthera,* a tanker, that were together carrying 23 sailors.

Two of the Indian sailors on board the *Petro Dolphin*, struck by a drone, are still missing, while 10 others, one Bangladeshi national and nine Indians, were rescued. The second ship was hit by a projectile and caught fire, but officials said all 11 Indian sailors on board were safe.



Ajit Doval

The readout issued by Iran did not give specifics of the conversation between the NSAs, nor did it refer to the incidents in the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran has enforced a blockade for several months.

In a post, the Iranian Embassy in India said that Mr. Doval and Dr. Rezaei, the Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council of Iran, "exchanged views on the latest regional and international developments and issues of mutual interest to the two countries."

The Ministry did not respond to queries about whether the attacks on the ships were discussed. In its statement just past midnight on Sunday, the Ministry had condemned the strikes.

"India reiterates the need for immediate de-escalation and a resolution to the ongoing conflict through dialogue and diplomacy," the statement said.

"Attacks on commercial vessels, seafarers and civilian infrastructure must cease. Freedom of navigation and the safe, unimpeded flow of maritime commerce through international waterways, in accordance with international law, must be upheld," it added.

The Ministry said that the safety and security of Indian seafarers "remain a priority" and that "recurring attacks on commercial shipping are deeply concerning and risk further aggravating an already volatile situation".

Navy commissions its third Mahe-class anti-submarine ship

Saurabh Trivedi
NEW DELHI

The Indian Navy on Monday commissioned *INS Mangrol* (P82), the third Mahe-class Anti-Submarine Warfare Shallow Water Craft (ASW-SWC), at the Naval Dockyard in Mumbai, strengthening its capabilities to detect and counter underwater threats.

Vice-Admiral Sanjay Vatsayan, Flag Officer Commanding-in-Chief, Western Naval Command, presided over the commissioning ceremony. Senior defence officials, representatives from the Ministry of Defence, Cochin Shipyard Limited (CSL), and industry partners attended the function.

INS Mangrol – designed and constructed by CSL in Kochi – has over 80% indigenous content. The ship also embodies the growing contribution of domestic defence industries and micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) to India's naval capabilities. Designed for operations in coastal and shallow waters, the vessel is equipped to undertake anti-submarine warfare, underwater surveillance and low-intensity maritime operations.



INS Mangrol, the Navy's new anti-submarine watercraft. AFP

INS Mangrol takes its name from the coastal town and fishing harbour of Mangrol in Gujarat's Junagadh district. It also carries forward the legacy of the earlier *INS Mangrol* (M85), a minesweeper that served the Navy until April 2004.

Arlekar now full-time T.N. Governor; Sudha Yadav to take charge in Karnataka

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

President Droupadi Murmu on Monday effected changes in Governors across six States.

Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar will now serve as the full-time Governor of Tamil Nadu. Mr. Arlekar, who was sworn in as Keralam Governor on January 2 last year, had been holding the additional charge of Tamil Nadu since March 12.

Sikkim Governor Om Prakash Mathur will be the new Governor of Keralam in place of Mr. Arlekar, a communique issued by the Rashtrapati Bhavan said.

Sudha Yadav has been appointed Governor of Karnataka, while Braj Mohan Ram will take charge in Odisha, Dhal Singh Bisen in Uttarakhand, and former BJP general secretary Dushyant Gautam in Sikkim.

Ms. Yadav, who replaces Thaawar Chand Gehlot, served as an MP from Mahendragarh in Haryana between 1999 and 2004. She was also a member of the BJP's Parliamentary Board, the party's highest decision-making body from August 2022 till the new team of national president Nitin Nabin took charge.



Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar and Sudha Yadav

Former MP

Mr. Braj Mohan was a Lok Sabha member between 1996 and 2004 from Palamau in Jharkhand. Mr. Bisen, who takes over the post in Uttarakhand, is a former MP from Madhya Pradesh and has served as a Minister in the State government.

He replaces Lt. General Gurmeet Singh (retd), whose five-year tenure, one of the longest in the State, came to an end in September.

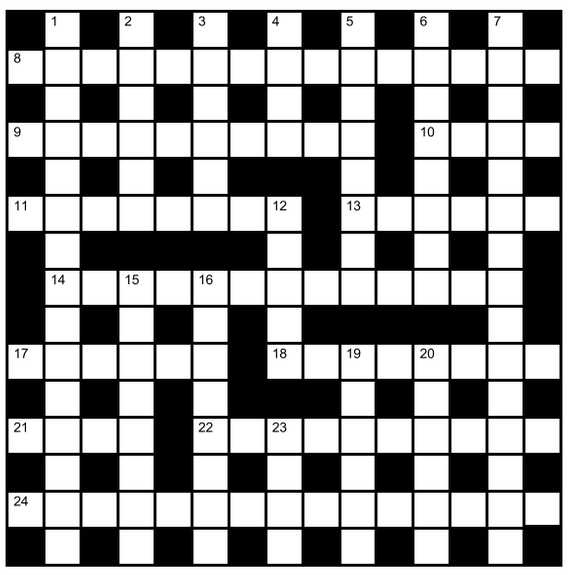
Mr. Gautam, who has been appointed Sikkim Governor, is a former Rajya Sabha member and has also served as BJP general secretary.

TH CROSSWORD + 14922

(set by Vidwan)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at *https://thehindu.com/crosswords*

SCAN TO PLAY



Across

8 Recent changes after removal of pressure, reportedly for housing of the illegals (9,6)
9 Help with a licit smuggling in future (10)
10 Approached leader retreating to the top (4)
11 Will might influence size (8)
13 Nation hides force away from the borders (6)
14 England's local troller manipulated voters list (9,4)
17 Plateau to pianissimo beholding perfect state (6)
18 It's basically most open kind of relative discrimination (8)
21 Organised first leaderless agitation (4)
22 A new sister at spy agency, the heartless harbinger (10)
24 Economic crisis that is back, involves media controlled by Mafia boss chasing capital (5,10)

Down

1 Leave males to rest around supermarket (10,5)
2 People beheaded in evil city (6)
3 Run small time gang (6)
4 Until now lacked right piece of furniture (4)
5 Pain of nail splitting of fruits like strawberries (8)
6 Popular name developed oil printing method (8)
7 Edge into Channel Islands and sail aggressively in race to outlaw (15)
12 Flier exporting Island drug (5)
15 Worthless, timeless, most honest name of sky (8)
16 Toy bear holding a California chest for beverage leaves (3,5)
19 Think of power, think without weight (6)
20 Lust! This controls right on time! (6)
23 Severus severed head and part of neck (4)

SUDOKU

				9	5		3	
2				3	6			
		5		7				1
1	4				2	8		
5	9						1	6
		6	3				7	4
6				4		1		
			7	5				8
	5		6	2				

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DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

3	2	7	6	8	4	9	1	5
1	4	5	2	9	3	7	6	8
8	9	6	5	7	1	3	2	4
7	1	4	9	6	8	2	5	3
9	8	3	4	5	2	6	7	1
6	5	2	3	1	7	4	8	9
5	3	8	7	2	9	1	4	6
2	6	9	1	4	5	8	3	7
4	7	1	8	3	6	5	9	2

FAITH

Navaratri: celebrating Shakti

Sivaratri is special to Siva and Navaratri is for Parashakti.

There are many norms for praying to one's favourite deity, but praying to Shakti is very easy, because She has immense mercy to forgive the trippings and transgressions of one. She is accessible to all and as the grama devata, She is happy to receive the love and piety offered by simple folks, said Damodara Deekshithar.

She is celebrated by all, especially during Navaratri, in various forms. On the first day She is Shailaputri. On the second, Brahmacharini. She is worshipped as Chnadraghanta on day three and as Kushmanda on day four. She is Skandamata on day five, Katyayani on day six and Kalaratri on day seven. She is Maha Gauri on the eighth day, and as Siddhidatri on day nine. On those nine days she vanquished asuras and emerged victorious on the tenth day as Vijayadasami.

As a further simplification of this, devotees pray to Durga, Saraswati and Lakshmi. Saraswati is propitiated for knowledge, wisdom and learning, Lakshmi is propitiated for wealth, and Durga is sought after for bravery. However, one should weigh in on what true wealth is.

As per Devi Mahatyam and Devi Bhagavatham, Shakti comes as Saraswati, Lakshmi and then Durga. Norms to worship Parashakti are very simple. She accepts what the devotee offers, in all piety, which would be what he or she consumes in day-to-day life. It is acceptable to Her since She is like a mother. When a child cries, the father would only know it is crying, but the mother alone would know why the baby is crying and step up. Similarly, Parashakti knows what the devotee wants.

Science's contract with society needs citizens as partners

While governments, as the patrons, are entitled to establish broad priorities and expectations, they should not use science policy as an excuse to politically micromanage research; scientists, in turn, must build broader support by involving citizens in shaping research priorities and outcomes

Biju Dharmapalan

For hundreds of years, science has operated with a social contract: science develops knowledge that improves the human condition and expands the range of what is possible while society provides public funds, infrastructure, and institutional support. Sustained investments in research have paid dividends to society, in the form of inventions and discoveries, new technologies, and more innovation in general.

Today, this contract is being strained. Governments are increasingly demanding measurable returns from public investments in research while public trust in institutions is reducing. As a result, science can no longer afford to remain an activity conducted largely for society but without society. The next phase of scientific progress must involve citizens as beneficiaries and taxpayers as well as as partners in deciding which questions science should address and how scientific knowledge should be used.



People are more likely to support a process when they believe their voices have been heard. RON LACH/PEXELS

Patrons of science

Curiosity-driven research often produces unexpected discoveries that eventually transform society. Yet governments, as major patrons of science, are increasingly asserting their right to determine where research money should go. There are legitimate reasons for this. Governments are obligated to resolve national priorities because public resources are finite. But governments misstep when their policy-driven management becomes intrusive.

When funding decisions are mainly influenced by short-term political priorities or economic returns, research areas that are not easily measurable, such as parts of the social sciences, humanities, climate research, and fundamental science, become vulnerable to being seen – unjustifiably – as producing too little bang for the buck. Yes, science must serve society, but science also works better when it retains the intellectual freedom required to challenge prevailing assumptions and explore questions whose value may not be immediately apparent.

Governments, as the patrons, are entitled to establish broad priorities and expectations, but they should not use science policy as an excuse to politically micromanage research. But the answer is also not to isolate science further from society. Instead, the answer is in the middle: scientists must build a broader constituency for science by bringing society into the research process.

To achieve this, scientists need compelling narratives about why research matters, and allies across communities, civil society, industry, education, and public institutions.

What citizens know

Inviting citizens into research does not mean replacing scientific expertise with popular opinion. A scientist trained in epidemiology knows considerably more about disease transmission than the average citizen. A climate scientist understands atmospheric processes in ways that a farmer may not. However, the reverse is also true. A farmer may possess knowledge about changing soil behaviour and crop resilience that a scientist in a laboratory may not. A forest-dwelling community may possess detailed knowledge of medicinal plants, forests, and biodiversity that is absent in formal databases.

Scientific knowledge and community knowledge are different – and they can be complementary. The challenge is to bring them together. This is particularly relevant to a country like India, which is one of the world's most biologically and culturally diverse countries. Indeed, India is too geographically vast and ecologically diverse for professional scientists alone to be able to understand every landscape by themselves. A network of citizens can provide observations across locations and seasons that conventional research is not designed to capture. For instance, a school student studying a butterfly or a birdwatcher recording a migratory species can contribute to ecological knowledge. Citizen science can transform the relationship between the public and scientific institutions.

India's long tradition of community-based conservation reveals another aspect of this argument. Sacred groves, community forests, germplasm conservation, traditional systems of resource management, and so on demonstrate that local communities have often developed sophisticated ways to understand and protect ecosystems. One of the key success metrics in research is observation, which many local communities excel at. So instead of merely entering a village to collect traditional knowledge and leaving with a publication, researchers can, and should, establish long-term partnerships with communities. Local knowledge bearers should participate in framing research questions, identifying species, help interpret the findings, and decide how knowledge is documented and used.

Rebuilding trust

Under the European Union's Horizon 2020 programme, citizens from numerous countries participated in developing research priorities. Here, while expert-led foresight exercises tended to emphasise technological advancement, citizens placed greater emphasis on strong communities, health and well-being, education, and local economies. A similar approach in India could have significant implications. Research priorities relating to groundwater, urban pollution, agricultural resilience, coastal erosion, public health, biodiversity, nutrition or climate adaptation, for example, can be developed through structured dialogue among scientists, policymakers, and the most affected communities.

Another compelling reason for citizen participation is trust. Specifically, public trust in governments and institutions is becoming increasingly fragile. Scientists and universities are sometimes portrayed as distant elites disconnected from the concerns of ordinary people. At the same time, misinformation spreads rapidly through social media and emotional narratives can compete successfully with carefully established scientific evidence. The instinctive response is often to communicate more science. But perhaps the deeper problem is a lack of participation and ownership.

People are more likely to support a process when they believe their voices have been heard. They may not agree with every conclusion but they are more likely to accept decisions when the reasoning is transparent and their concerns have been seriously considered. This is particularly important for contentious issues such as climate change, vaccination, genetic modification, artificial intelligence, and biotechnologies. Science cannot promise that every citizen will agree with every scientific conclusion – nor should it. But it can promise a fair opportunity to question, participate, deliberate, and understand.

Humility from scientists

At present, many researchers are trained to design experiments, analyse data, and publish papers but not necessarily to build long-term relationships with communities. That must change. Community engagement should be integrated into research training. Academic recognition should extend beyond publications and citations to include meaningful societal engagement and co-produced research.

Funding agencies should also encourage researchers to explain, wherever appropriate, how communities will participate in setting priorities, conducting research, interpreting results and disseminating findings.

To be sure, not every laboratory experiment requires citizen participation. The objective is also not to impose participation mechanically.

Public involvement should instead become the default expectation for research with significant societal implications, with researchers explaining why participation is inappropriate when it is not used. Should an emerging technology be deployed rapidly or cautiously? How much privacy should society sacrifice for technological convenience? How should the benefits and risks of artificial intelligence be distributed? How should climate-transition costs be shared? Such questions can benefit enormously from community engagement.

This transformation also requires some humility from scientists. Scientists must learn to listen, be willing to hear uncomfortable questions, acknowledge uncertainties, and recognise the values embedded in their own recommendations. At the same time, the public must recognise that scientific evidence cannot always provide simple answers to complex social questions.

(Biju Dharmapalan is the dean, Academic Affairs, Garden City University, Bengaluru, and an adjunct faculty member at the National Institute of Advanced Studies, Bengaluru. bijudharmapalan@gmail.com)



A polar bear is seen on ice floes in the British Channel in the Franz Josef Land archipelago. Photo taken in 2021. AFP

Climate body faces deadlock over timeline of new reports

Reuters

The decision was expected to take minutes. But after nearly three years of debate, members of the world's leading authority on climate change still can't agree on a timeline to publish its next review of the latest science on the warming planet.

Such assessments from the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) have informed every major United Nations climate agreement for three decades. But the impasse over publication dates could leave countries to decide the next phase of action without consensus on critical issues - including the extent to which some global warming might be reversible - according to interviews with more than a dozen current and former IPCC scientists, government negotiators and meeting observers.

On October 12, representatives from the IPCC's 195 member states are expected to have convened in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia's capital, for a plenary meeting many see as the last chance to agree publication dates falling before UN climate talks in November 2028. That's when governments are due to assess progress toward goals set out in the landmark agreement reached in Paris in 2015.

IPCC nations remain divided over the timeline for key climate reports, raising fears they may miss the 2028 UN climate summit and weaken science-based climate decisions

The possibility the IPCC's reports might not be ready in time for the 2028 talks has alarmed a coalition of countries pushing for more robust action. Those discussions are intended to guide decisions on climate financing and national targets to bring down greenhouse gas emissions.

Countries including India, Kenya, Saudi Arabia, Russia, and China are pressing for more time to prepare the IPCC's next reports to ensure scientists from less-resourced countries can make meaningful contributions. Some scientists struggle to publish new research in time to be included or to take time off from their regular jobs for unpaid IPCC work, they say.

The deadlock - unprecedented in the IPCC's history - comes as the organisation faces increasing pressure from governments critical of climate policies they say hurt industrial competitiveness or restrict the ability of emerging economies to use cheaper, more polluting fuels to meet development needs. The United States, the IPCC's biggest funder, quit the organisation in January.

The IPCC will publish three key reports: one on the extent and causes of climate change, another on vulnerabilities and how countries can adapt, and a third on options to avoid warming getting worse. Scientists chairing groups preparing the reports have proposed a work plan that would see all three approved by September 2028.

Robert Vautard, a French co-chair, said the proposal was based on the anticipated workload rather than the timing of the 2028 UN summit. Report timelines are typically approved in "a matter of minutes," he added.

Opponents of the chairs' proposal want the second and third reports pushed into 2029.

Thiagarajan Jayaraman, a scientist who represents India at the IPCC, said it was "short-sighted" to suggest the value of the body's work rests solely on contributing to the 2028 UN talks.

Developing countries have long argued their perspectives are not sufficiently reflected in IPCC reports because they do not have enough experts involved and because their researchers have fewer resources to publish peer-reviewed studies. The result, Thiagarajan said, is that issues of "equity and inclusivity" are in some instances "simply ducked."

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Francis Halzen won the 2026 physics Nobel. A quiz on the physics Prize

Please send in your answers to science@thehindu.co.in

Radhika Santhanam

QUESTION 1

He is an American physicist. Along with two others, he was awarded the Prize for inventing the transistor and also, again with two others, for his theory of superconductivity. Name this double laureate.

QUESTION 2

When he won the Prize he said, "I just about made it, huh? You can't be dead and win." At 96, he was still working in the lab, writing a paper, when he got a call from the Swedish Academy informing him that he had won the Prize. Name this scientist, who won the Prize for inventing optical tweezers.

QUESTION 3

Five women have won the Nobel Prize in physics. The first, born Maria Skłodowska, later became known by another name. She named one of the elements she discovered after her homeland. Decades of exposure to the substances she worked with contributed to her death. Who was she?

QUESTION 4

In 2024, the Nobel Prize in physics went to Geoffrey Hinton and John Hopfield for work that some felt belonged more to computer science than to physics. Speaking about the potential impact of the technology underlying their research, Hinton said: "I think it will have a huge influence. It will be comparable with the Industrial Revolution. But instead of exceeding people in physical strength, it's going to exceed people in the intellectual ability." What was he referring to that has become living room conversation today?

QUESTION 5

The 2025 Nobel-winning experiments on macroscopic quantum phenomena used which specific superconducting device to observe quantum tunneling without using a microscope or similar device?



Visual: This instrument uses 5,000 sensors buried deep in the ice to study what natural processes in the cosmos can accelerate subatomic particles to extremely high energies. Name it.

Answers to October 1 quiz:

1. Layer of tropical rainforests that receives most sunlight – **Ans: Canopy**
2. Hemisphere hosting the taiga; name for taiga biome – **Ans: Northern; boreal forest**
3. Name of subterranean fungal network; what 'www' stands for – **Ans: Mycorrhizal network; woodwide web**
4. Ecosystems exemplified by Sundarbans and Pichavaram – **Ans: Mangroves**
5. Basin that hosts forests covering six countries and most great ape species – **Ans: Congo**

Visual: **Lakshadweep**

First contact:
K.N. Viswanathan | Tamal Biswas | Sudhir Thapa | Partheeban Natesh | Nitya Sahu

For feedback and suggestions
for 'Science', please write to **science@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Daily page'

Winning, differently

Ruling parties sweep by-elections, but defections mar Tamil Nadu results

The by-election results in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Puducherry, declared on Friday, held few surprises. Barely five months after the April Assembly elections, the ruling party in each State/UT won all five bypolls. What varied was the scale of victory. In West Bengal, the BJP retained Nandigram and wrested Rejinagar, with strong vote shares of 76% and 63%. In Puducherry, the ruling All India N.R. Congress also registered an emphatic win – 61% of the votes – in Thattanchavady. Nandigram and Thattanchavady were vacated by the Chief Ministers, which partly explains the strong wins. But the contests in Tamil Nadu were closer. Dharapuram and Madurantakam fell vacant after their AIADMK MLAs resigned and defected to the ruling TVK, which renominated them. Both won their seats back with 37% and 40% of the vote, respectively, leading the DMK rival candidates by about eight percentage points. By-elections tend to favour the party in power, as voters prefer representatives with access to government. But the variance between West Bengal and Tamil Nadu reflects the nature of contest in two similarly sized States but with vastly different political cultures.

In West Bengal, Assembly victories have for decades worked as a winner-take-all mandate, which the ruling party extends to panchayat and by-elections. The pattern took shape during the Left Front's long rule, became entrenched during the Trinamool Congress's 15 years in power and is visible in the BJP's tenure so far. In these contests, Opposition parties have performed far worse than in Assembly and Lok Sabha elections. In Tamil Nadu, however, a three-way contest now has kept politics competitive. The wins have helped the TVK improve its tally to 109 in the House with a sanctioned membership of 234, but the narrow margins, despite a no-holds-barred campaign by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, suggest that the expected honeymoon effect did not fully materialise. The DMK, now the TVK's principal rival, has shown that it still has a solid base despite its abrupt defeat in May. For the AIADMK, finishing third in the seats it won in May only deepens worries about its decline. Its leadership will now face sharper questions about whether it can hold on to its legislators. Four more AIADMK MLAs had joined the TVK and their seats will go to bypolls. This is a regressive turn in Tamil Nadu. MLAs are resigning barely months, sometimes days, into their terms to share in the loaves and fishes of office and the ruling party re-fields them. This defeats the spirit of the anti-defection law and overrides the Assembly election mandate. That the electorate rewarded these manoeuvres should worry anyone who is concerned about the quality of representation.

Drought report

The Centre must help States once inter-ministerial team gives finding

A substantial drought seems to be inflicting Karnataka and Andhra Pradesh after the crucial southwest monsoon concluded with a significant deficiency in the most-affected regions. The national drought framework combines agricultural and hydrological indicators and ground-truthing studies, including before a distressed State can access additional support from the NDRF. In June-September, Karnataka reportedly suffered a close to 35% rainfall deficit. The government has since declared 217 of 240 taluks to be drought-hit with extensive damage to red gram, maize, cotton, and sugarcane cultivation. Andhra Pradesh experienced a shortfall of 53% in June-August and 388 of 688 mandals have been declared drought-hit. Horticulture crops over nearly 18,000 hectares are now at risk. Karnataka has also petitioned the Centre for ₹11,000 crore from the NDRF along with higher input subsidies. Andhra Pradesh has set aside ₹190 crore to protect horticultural crops and has directed drinking water conservation. The summer monsoon had its poorest showing since 2015 this year. There have been warnings of the effects of the strengthening El Niño, although an attribution study elucidating the strength of causal relationships in the present instance is pending.

In a previous era, drought declarations were beset by subjective claims, sometimes exaggerated to maximise state support. Since 2009, however, the Manual for Drought Management and updates to it and Finance Commission decisions have tightened the process. While States still have some incentives to expand their declarations, the Centre has also resisted releasing NDRF assistance before, including with Karnataka in 2024, while also increasing their own relief obligations. The Centre must desist from frustrating States and release support as soon as the findings of the Inter-Ministerial Central Team have been publicly verified. In addition to mitigating indebtedness among farmers and expanding access to relief beyond land ownership, the States also need more discipline *vis-à-vis* storing water and rationalising consumption. Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka have offered incentives and advisories, including to adopt micro-irrigation and to cultivate less water-intensive crops, but have not imposed binding limits. The Centre may also consider incentives to resist drought, even in the face of a deficient monsoon, because the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change has been warning of expanding drought-like conditions in South Asia, and broadening agricultural insurance. It must certainly not use the prospect of the more protracted, more imprudent river-interlinking project as an excuse to overlook pro-resilience aims such as sustainably using groundwater and choosing crops based on local rainfall and aquifers and availability of income support.

At sixes and sevens, the ECI's growing credibility crisis



Ashok Lavasa

A former Election Commissioner of India and a former Union Finance Secretary

Is the Election Commission of India (ECI) at sixes and sevens, idiomatically and otherwise? Will Form 6 be its undoing, and has Form 7 caused it unmanageable discomfiture? The barbs associated with these forms have further damaged the image of the beleaguered constitutional body entrusted with safeguarding the constitutional right to vote of "we, the people".

Disturbing conduct

Never before has the ECI been so severely berated, becoming the object of unprecedented public outcry, adverse media attention and social scrutiny as in recent times. It took the ECI years of toil and transparency to earn public trust; it has taken the temperament of a few individuals to erode it through their disregard for the concerns, genuine or imagined, of those who had earlier sworn by the very same institution.

The institution that was built brick by brick seems to be crumbling in a similar manner. Its record presents a disturbing pattern: a lax, and sometimes overtly partial, approach to alleged violations of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) during the 2019 general election; discriminatory treatment of Opposition parties; the hurried change, in December 2024, to the rules governing the sharing of documents, following an order by the Punjab and Haryana High Court for full disclosure, permitting the ECI to withhold video footage of voting after scheduled polling hours; the issuance of notices to political parties over alleged MCC violations by their leaders during the 2024 general election; the so-called 'fair and equal' treatment of the main political parties by exonerating their star campaigners of MCC violations; the contempt with which civil society organisations have been treated; the cavalier dismissal of complaints by the Leader of the Opposition (LoP) in the Lok Sabha about flaws in electoral rolls (ERs); the uncharacteristic bombast of asking the LoP to submit an affidavit substantiating his complaints or apologise to the nation; and the abrupt imposition, in June 2025, of the aggressive, ambitious and most unnecessary exercise of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls on nearly a billion electors. This is a deeply disturbing but consistent narrative of institutional decline and growing deformities (pun unintended).

As if the ECI's own actions were not enough to erode its credibility, a 'friendly' government further undermined it by legislating in December 2023 a selection procedure that prejudiced the credibility of the Commissioners *ab initio*. Moreover, the ruling party repeatedly rushed to the ECI's rescue whenever it came under attack, as though it were a weak ally incapable of defending itself.

In the latest public mud fight, the ECI is under attack not merely for allegedly favouring the ruling party through its controversial decisions, but also for committing "illegalities" alleged not by its critics but by fellow Election Commissioners (ECs). These relate to changes to Form 6 and the denial of access to ECINet for Electoral Registration Officers (EROs), allegedly obstructing them from performing their statutory duties.

> The Election Commission of India's actions and questions around Forms 6 and 7 deepen doubts about its impartiality and transparency

There have also been complaints of rampant misuse of Form 7 by unidentified objectors seeking the mass deletion of electors whose names were duly included in the electoral rolls (ERs).

Form 6 attached to the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960 (the Rules), is an "application for inclusion of name in the electoral roll (ER) for a first-time voter or on shifting from one constituency to another". It requires applicants to provide mandatory particulars relating to their identity, date of birth and ordinary residence, along with declarations regarding citizenship and place of birth. They must also declare that they have not applied for inclusion of their name in the ER of any other constituency and, in the case of a shift, provide details of their previous registration. Applicants must attest to the veracity of the information furnished and acknowledge that they are aware that providing false information is punishable under Section 31 of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 (the Act). Nothing further is required to establish their eligibility.

A declaration beyond the rules

However, the ECI's notification of June 24, 2025, announcing the SIR, included a Declaration Form (Annexure D) to be filled in along with Form 6 or Form 8, as in paragraphs 4 and 15 of the notification. The declaration classified applicants according to their dates of birth, aligning them with the provisions of the Citizenship Act and requiring them to submit documents to establish their eligibility accordingly. This appears to go beyond what is prescribed under the Rules. This is why the ECs termed the changes to Form 6 "illegal and unauthorised", while many suspected that the SIR was an attempt to introduce a "National Register of Citizens (NRC) through the back door".

Section 28 of the Act empowers only the central government to make "rules for carrying out the purpose of this Act". Even if the ECI unanimously decided to change Form 6, it was not competent to amend it unilaterally. In its press note of September 26, the ECI acknowledged that a "declaration" had been "attached to Form 6 for SIR", which was "upheld by the Hon'ble Supreme Court", and that "for non-SIR period, the Forms applicable as per Rules will be used".

The Chief Justice of India has since observed, "No modified Form 6 has been approved by us." In its letter dated October 1, 2026, to all Chief Electoral Officers (CEOs), the ECI stated that "any person not yet enrolled in the ER or whose name has got deleted can apply for enrolment at any point of time". It also asked Booth Level Officers (BLOs) to "compare the current electoral roll with the pre-SIR electoral roll and identify such electors whose names were there in the pre-SIR roll but who are not included in the current electoral roll and prepare a list of such electors". The BLOs were further instructed to undertake house-to-house (H2H) visits to ascertain the present status of these electors and facilitate their enrolment through Form 6 wherever they were found eligible.

While Form 6 with the Declaration will continue to be used in States where the SIR is ongoing, it will be used without the Declaration in States where the SIR has been completed. What has the ECI achieved through these changes, and what is its intent in using two versions of Form 6? Its continued use in States undergoing the SIR suggests an attempt to align an elector's citizenship status with the criteria laid down in the Citizenship Act. The information sought in the Declaration has little to do with an elector's eligibility under Article 326. Does this not amount to the ECI attempting to create a quasi-NRC?

Wider concerns

The issues pertaining to the manner in which the bulk applications to delete existing voters using Form 7 are being submitted in Uttarakhand, Karnataka and other States are equally serious, as they point to efforts to misuse or manipulate the system. By failing to take effective action against those who filed frivolous Form 7 applications, or to initiate criminal proceedings where applications were found to be fake, the ECI is being perceived as lax in safeguarding the integrity of its processes. The centralisation of data by the ECI has further fuelled concerns about the possibility of manipulation. Complaints from BLOs and EROs in West Bengal during the SIR, as well as emails sent by EROs in Goa, point to a centralised data-management system that allegedly obstructed authorised officers from implementing their decisions while allowing others without authorisation to act on their behalf.

Eleven judges heading the Appellate Tribunals in West Bengal pointed out that the technical system impeded their work. The Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) of Maharashtra also highlighted several shortcomings that prevented EROs from exercising their legally mandated judgement, based on their satisfaction, because the system disallowed it. The larger question that remains unanswered, despite several press notes issued by the ECI after it was engulfed by *The Indian Express*'s September 23 revelations, is: who filed the more than 16 lakh objections against electors whose names had been validly included after due process? This raises concerns similar to those surrounding the alleged misuse of Form 7.

The ECI's answers confirm earlier doubts, while its actions raise new and far more serious questions.

Warming Himalayas demand a rethink on development



Archana Vaidya

An advocate and the founder of the Forum for Environment Legal Policy Research (FELPR)

For decades, the fight for sustainable, climate-resilient, hazard-averse development in the Indian Himalayan Region (IHR) has gone unheeded, and the region is witnessing frequent and severe climate-induced disasters.

The catastrophic Nepal floods of August 26 are a warning that the 'global natural commons', stretching from the Hindu Kush and Karakoram to the Himalayas, are in an existential crisis. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC) and the World Meteorological Organization (WMO) have warned that warming in the high mountains of Asia is occurring at 0.3°C per decade, nearly twice the global average, "leading to glacier retreat, decreasing in turn the stability of mountain slopes and the integrity of infrastructure, threatening water security, livelihoods, ecosystems, and increasing disaster risk."

Reports released on March 21, 2026, by the International Centre for Integrated Mountain Development (ICIMOD) found that ice-loss rates across the Hindu Kush Himalaya (HKH) have doubled since 2000. "We are trying to navigate a rapidly changing future with an incomplete map," said one of the authors of the report. Warming is not uniform across this 3,500-kilometre range. According to the *Journal of Earth System Science*, the western Himalaya is warming consistently faster than the central and eastern stretches, with night-time minimum and winter temperatures rising at the most extreme rates.

Nepal is paying the price for a crisis it did not create. As it produces roughly 0.1% of global greenhouse gas emissions, it is right to demand compensation for loss and damage.

Rising temperatures, effect on glaciers

Rising atmospheric temperatures shift the balance between winter snow accumulation and summer melt, causing glaciers to retreat and thin steadily. Ice that once had a thermal profile of −6°C to −20°C now has temperatures closer to −2°C, making it far more susceptible to melting.

> The 'cement' is melting — retreating glaciers and thawing permafrost are heightening disaster risks in the Indian Himalayan Region

Meltwater pools atop glaciers in supraglacial lakes and carves vertical shafts called moulins, plunging hundreds of metres through the ice to the bedrock, where it forms a pressurised liquid layer between the rock and ice. This layer lubricates the glacier, allowing it to slide downslope faster, while the resulting subglacial (between the glacier and bedrock) and englacial (within the glacier) water channels generate mechanical forces intense enough to fracture the ice.

In high-altitude environments such as the Himalayas, permafrost – ground or rock that remains at or below 0°C – acts as geological cement, holding steep rock walls together by filling fractures, joints and pores with solid ice. As temperatures rise, permafrost melts into water, triggering rock avalanches, landslides and debris flows that threaten downstream valleys.

In Nepal, a shaking equivalent to a magnitude 5.2 seismic event was recorded by the United States Geological Survey (USGS) on August 26, when a 600-metre-wide section of ice and rock broke away from the northern flank of Langtang Himal at an elevation of 5,600 m and fell 1.2 km into the valley below. Researchers from the British Antarctic Survey recorded unusually high ground temperatures two days before the collapse, using sensors located 10 km from the site.

This mass of ice and rock landed in the Lhende Khola, a tributary of the Bhote Koshi river, damming it. When the dam broke, it unleashed a flash flood of concrete-like mud and debris – "an inland tsunami" travelling 170 km down the Bhote Koshi Valley into central Nepal. This was no isolated event. Such collapses can happen anywhere in these mountains and warming makes them more likely.

What can be done

There is no technology to prevent such collapses. The only real option is to mitigate their impact on downstream communities, which requires regional cooperation and a shared system for real-time data exchange. High-altitude satellite and drone surveillance is urgently needed to detect early signs of cliff fracturing, permafrost thaw and glacial instability. Real-time acoustic and hydrological sensors along glacier-fed rivers could detect sudden subsurface movements or flash surges and alert downstream communities immediately. Glacial lakes need continuous monitoring and, where feasible, engineered drainage.

River flood zoning must account for valley slope. Steeper slopes concentrate damage vertically, requiring infrastructure to be located much higher above the riverbed, while gentler slopes spread destruction horizontally, demanding an entirely different zoning approach.

Hydropower policy needs to be rethought, with a firm ban on construction above a defined elevation. The Avay Shukla Committee (*Court on Its Own Motion vs State of Himachal Pradesh and Others*) and the Ravi Chopra Committee both recommended restricting major hydropower projects or subjecting construction activities above 2,200 metres to detailed expert review.

The proposed Chenab-Beas river-linking project – an 8.7-km tunnel through the steep slopes of the Pir Panjal Range in Lahaul and Spiti district, near Koksar village in Himachal Pradesh, at an elevation of 3,140 metres (10,300 feet) – needs serious rethinking. The rationale for diverting more water from the western rivers of the Indus system may appear logical on paper, but the project is located in a fragile Himalayan ecosystem, and its likely environmental impacts make it eminently avoidable.

Every development activity in the IHR must be evaluated in light of the changing geological realities of the Himalayas. There should be a moratorium on all development projects until each is rigorously reassessed for its environmental impact, hazard-averseness and climate resilience.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The protests and beyond

The protests against the CEC and SIR are taking shape as a people's movement. The feeling one gets from the street is that people are determined to see to it that electoral integrity is restored for democracy to be meaningful in 'the world's largest democracy'. It is the cause — saving democracy — that is drawing crowds to the streets. It is an epic fight to preserve India as we know it. The BJP's staunch defence of Gyanesh Kumar is being seen as evidence of its "special relationship" with him. It is hoped and expected that the Supreme Court will live up to its constitutionally assigned role as the supreme sentinel of democracy when it hears (and rules on) this all-important case.

G. David Milton,
Maruthancode, Tamil Nadu

Fearless and impartial

One feels a sense of pride in the Nobel Committee, which makes its awards, particularly the Peace Prize, impartially, transcending boundaries and all forms of discrimination. Today, a superpower such as the United States is pursuing arbitrary policies and imposing its will through war and authoritarian tactics, leaving many nations struggling under the pressure. In such a situation, while U.S. President Donald Trump has actively lobbied for the Peace Prize for the past two years, it is truly admirable that the Committee has remained undeterred by pressure and honoured a truly deserving recipient.

Siddharth Bagul,
Pune

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Realising Lohia's vision among top posts



Vipul Anekant

DCP, Delhi Police. Views are personal

October 12 marked the beginning of the 60th year since Ram Manohar Lohia's passing. In his essay 'The Meaning of Equality', Lohia writes, "Equality has not been stated comprehensively. Equality is perhaps as high an aim of life as truth or beauty, but the complete meaning of equality has not been adequately investigated in serenity". Channelling that serenity, one should, at this point in history, examine the minuscule presence of marginalised sections in the highest echelons of bureaucracy, for apex posts such as Cabinet Secretary, IB Director, DG of the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF), and Director General of Police (DGP)/Chief Secretaries of States, despite entry-level representation through affirmative action.

Entry/exit barriers

Two structural features of the civil services work as barriers to the entry of the marginalised to top posts. First, inter-se seniority within a batch, maintained in the civil list of services, is fixed by the rank officers get in their UPSC (Union Public Service Commission) exam and their performance at the training academy. Officers who enter through reservation typically begin lower on the civil list due to their UPSC rank and the allocation of a higher preferred service. That place on the civil list remains rigid till retirement. Inter-se seniority, disguised as administrative convenience/fairness, functions more as a permanent memory device working silently and punitively to never allow candidates arriving through reservation mobility.

Exceptional service does not erase this initial handicap. Reserved category officers remain ranked as if frozen at birth, forever trailing their colleagues whose starting line was never handicapped in the first place. The result is a lifetime deficit that quietly excludes them from apex posts.

Secondly, the age relaxation granted to reserved categories in the civil services exam, while essential for opening the exam to historically disadvantaged candidates, shortens their total years of service. They enter later, but the retirement age remains uniform for all. Fewer years in service translate to fewer opportunities for promotion to top posts. What begins as a necessary concession at the entry gate becomes a barrier at the exit.

These mechanisms produce a subtler form of ostracism which a mere selection in the exam cannot automatically neutralise. Officers from marginalised sections spend decades knowing that the arithmetic of the civil list places them at a permanent disadvantage within their own batch; top posts/empanelment will find them last in their own batch. This can be called administrative untouchability; not the crude kind, but a paperback version of psychological injury, dressed in an otherwise seemingly neutral language concerning the civil list, inter-se seniority, rank and batch position.

The most educated, articulate and influential intellectuals from these communities are systematically sidelined from top positions, policy making, and informal channels of power causing a persistent deficit in their social capital. The community is thereby deprived of its strongest advocates inside the system, weakening the pace of collective mobility. Lohia had warned that when more than four-fifths of a nation's vital leadership is drawn from only one-fifth of its population, atrophy follows. The same rationale applies to administrative leadership.

Some measures to correct the system can include an equal number of service years regardless of the age of entry, with the retirement rules being aligned with entry relaxations. After training, all batchmates should be treated at par, ending the lifelong shadow of inter-se seniority that resurrects the very birth-based hierarchy the Constitution buried. The UPSC examination should determine entry, not serve as a permanent retrospective judge for someone's entire career. The civil list can be redesigned on more egalitarian lines.

Lohia insisted that the talk of equality in abstraction without concrete results is either hypocrisy or lethargy of the mind, while insistence on a single formula of equality establishes the status quo. India, he said, suffers from a complete divorce between abstract equality as a dream and concrete equality as it exists. Representation at the entry level that evaporates at the top is precisely that kind of divorce.

To realise Lohia's vision, equality should cease to be a distant ideal and instead become an operative reality in the corridors of power.

Lohia had warned that when more than four-fifths of a nation's vital leadership is drawn from only one-fifth of its population, atrophy follows

A common language for justice



Sincy Wilson

Assistant Professor of Law, Vels University (VISTAS), and a legal researcher specialising in constitutional and administrative law, and international environmental law



Vaishali R. Venkat

When a nation speaks in different tongues, how do its courts determine which language serves as its official language? This question was placed before the Supreme Court as a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) on September 25, 2026. The petitioner requested a direction to the Union Government to constitute a commission that would recommend the use of Hindi as the official language of the Supreme Court, with the petitioner's counsel arguing that the plea was firmly grounded in constitutional provisions.

The Bench, comprising Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V. Mohana, however, observed that reforms related to language were already being carried out in a phased manner through administrative measures. Justice V. Mohana clarified that granting such a relief would require a constitutional amendment. Further, the CJI noted that, as part of preserving the country's linguistic diversity and respecting regional languages, the court was already providing brief descriptions of its reports in Hindi, with the initiative to be gradually extended to other regional languages.

In doing so, the court appeared to draw a distinction between changing the language regime of the judiciary and making its work more accessible in Indian languages. The distinction raises a deeper question: if judicial work is made accessible in multiple Indian languages, who has the authority to decide the language in which courts conduct their proceedings?

Perhaps, the way forward is not to replace one language with another, but to make the work of the court accessible in more Indian languages

Who gets to decide?

For justice to be administered fairly, that question must ultimately be answered within the constitutional framework governing judicial language. Under Article 348(1)(a) of the Constitution, until Parliament provides otherwise by law, English is the prescribed language for all proceedings before the Supreme Court and every High Court. To date, Parliament has not enacted any law under this provision to replace English.

However, under Article 348(2), the Governor of a State, with the prior consent of the President, may authorise the use of Hindi or any other regional language used for the State's official purposes in proceedings of the High Court. Yet, the proviso to Article 348(2) makes it clear that such authorisation does not extend to judgments, decrees or orders passed by the High Courts.

Further, Section 7 of the Official Languages Act, 1963, provides an additional mechanism for allowing judgments, decrees or orders in Hindi or any other language used for official purposes of the State concerned, provided an authoritative English translation accompanies them. This provision has enabled Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar to use Hindi in proceedings before their respective High Courts, subject to the previous consent of the President and other constitutional and statutory safeguards.

The next question is who has the constitutional authority to alter it. This question brings into play the doctrine of separation of powers between the legislature, the executive and the judiciary. Generally, the judiciary cannot issue a writ of mandamus compelling Parliament to enact a particular law, amend the Constitution or establish a commission for that purpose. Such matters fall within the Parliament's legislative domain.

Even if the question of constitutional authority is settled, another dilemma remains: must a court speak in one language to speak to a nation of different tongues? How can the Supreme Court retain a common language for its proceedings and at the same time ensure that its work remains accessible?

From a practical standpoint, the Supreme Court has recognised the importance of a common language in judicial proceedings. In *Madhu Limaye & Anr v. Ved Murti & Ors* (1970), the Court observed that "the language of this Court is English" and held that an intervener who insisted on addressing the court in Hindi could not participate as the members of the Bench could not follow his arguments.

Perhaps, the way forward is not to replace one language with another, but to make the work of the court accessible in more Indian languages. For example, the Supreme Court's SUVAS (Supreme Court Vidhik Anuvaad Software), an AI-based translation tool, enables judgments to be translated into 16 languages.

Such an approach can respect linguistic diversity while preserving consistency in justice. To be truly heard, justice must not merely speak; it must also be felt and understood.

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Contextualising WWF's report on wildlife population decline

The Living Planet Index report shows that exactly 50% of populations were in decline, 43% were increasing, and the remaining 7% were stable

DATA POINT

Hannah Ritchie

There has been a 73% decline in wildlife populations since 1970, according to the 2026 Living Planet Index report. As with previous editions, it makes for a concerning read, despite this year's title being about the "Science of Hope".

While these trends are worrying, the numbers presented in the Living Planet Index (LPI) report, released by the Worldwide Wildlife Fund (WWF), are often misunderstood or misreported. The headline figure from the 2026 update of the LPI shows that studied wildlife populations declined by an average of 73% from 1970 through 2022, as shown in **Chart 1**. The data covers mammals, birds, reptiles, amphibians, and fish; it doesn't yet include invertebrates or plants.

To clarify what this doesn't mean – it doesn't tell us anything about the number of species lost; the number of populations or individuals that have been lost; the number or percentage of species or populations that are declining; or the number of extinctions.

The authors of the LPI go to great lengths to explain this. Yet, there is inevitably a long list of headlines claiming that we've "lost 73% of wildlife", "73% of species have gone extinct", or "73% of species are declining". All of these are incorrect. But then, what does this metric actually tell us?

Across the 35,803 wildlife populations studied, the average decline was 73%. This doesn't mean that 73% of populations are in decline; in fact, around half of the studied populations were in decline, while half were either increasing or stable.

To calculate the LPI, researchers collect data on the change in wildlife numbers across tens of thousands of populations. While the data is measured relative to 1970, very few populations have data stretching back this far. Many populations only have data for much shorter and sparser timelines. For every population, the change in numbers over time is calculated, giving a rate of change. It can be positive, negative, or zero. To obtain the final LPI number, researchers take the geometric mean of the rates of change across all these populations. They also provide different weights to different populations, which affects the final result.

The 2022 Living Planet Index reported an average decline of 69% since 1970. In 2024, it reported a 73% decline. And this latest report finds the same figure. From this, you might assume that wildlife populations dropped by four percentage points between the 2022 and 2024 editions, and nothing has changed since then.

But that's not the case. Almost none of this change has happened in the last few years, and the new LPIs should not be seen as simple extensions of the previous ones.

Instead, the entire trend line for the LPI has shifted as the project has gained access to data from more populations and species, and the types of populations included have changed. Since the last report, the number of populations in the LPI increased by around 1,000 (a 3% increase), and the number of species by about 300 (a 5% increase). An important change from the 2022 to the 2024 report was that both native and non-native species were included in the former, but since then, only native species have been included.

In this particular release, the number of populations and species from Africa increased substantially. The number of populations increased by 14%, and the number of species by 38%. Data coverage of this region, which had been underrepresented in previous reports, has increased.

Chart 2 compares the LPI for 2022, 2024, and 2026 across different regions. Here, one can see that whole lines have shifted, rather than things changing dramatically in just the last four years. Almost as many populations are increasing as decreasing.

Across the entire dataset, exactly 50% of populations were in decline, 43% were increasing, and the remaining 7% were stable.

Chart 3 shows the share of populations in the LPI that have trended in a given direction for different taxonomic groups. Around half of wildlife populations have declined in numbers. The rest were either increasing or stable. So, not all populations are struggling. This is not to dismiss the steep decline many populations are seeing. Instead, it's useful to know this so we can direct resources more efficiently to the areas and populations that need them most. It's more effective to target restorative and protective efforts to populations in serious trouble than to assume that all populations are struggling.

The index also varies from region to region. Latin America and the Caribbean have seen the most severe decline of any region. It experienced an average decline of 95% across its studied populations. In recent decades, it has experienced intense deforestation and expansion of agricultural land: the primary driver of habitat loss. It is also a biodiversity hotspot, being home to many endemic (unique) tropical species. These species are often highly specialised, and don't adapt well to changes in local conditions.

Africa is still rich in biodiversity. It's the only continent with a significant number of large mammals left. Unfortunately, it has dramatically declined in recent decades, with an average decline of 80% since 1970. Asia has also seen a decline of 49%. Europe has seen the smallest decline of all the continents, with an average of 23% since 1970.

Hannah Ritchie is Deputy Editor and Science Outreach Lead at Our World in Data

Is wildlife vanishing?

Data were sourced from the 2026 Living Planet Index (LPI) report by the Worldwide Wildlife Fund (WWF). This analysis was published by OurWorldInData, a non-profit website from the University of Oxford and the Global Change Data Lab



CHART 1 : The LPI measures the average decline in monitored wildlife populations. The index value measures the change in abundance relative to the year 1970 (i.e. 1970 = 1)

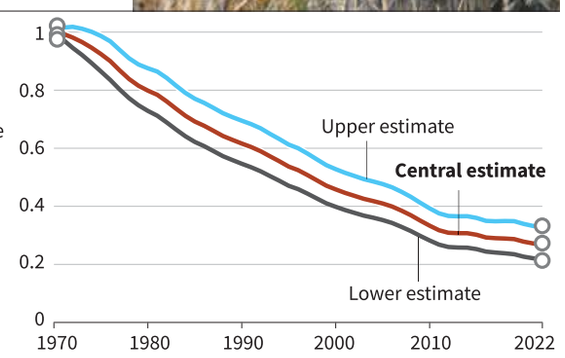


CHART 2: The 2022 Living Planet Index reported an average decline of 69% since 1970. In 2024, it reported a 73% decline. The latest report finds the same

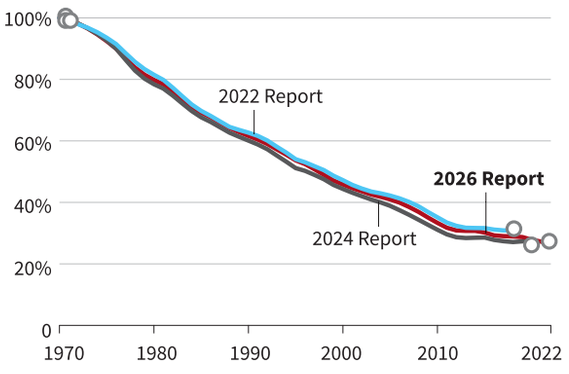
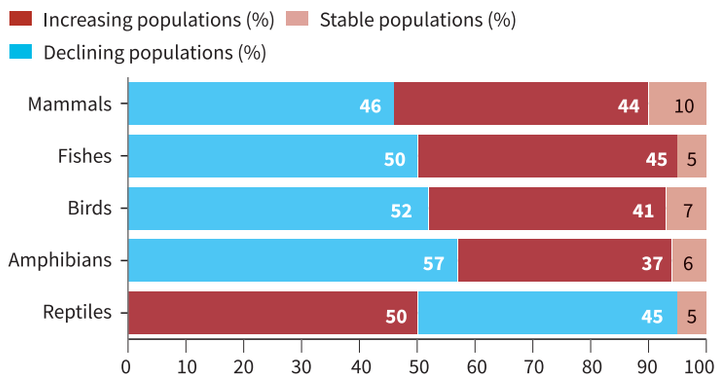


CHART 3 : The share of globally studied populations in each taxonomic group with increasing, stable or declining numbers



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu

FIFTY YEARS AGO OCTOBER 13, 1976

Nuclear steam generator from BHEL

Tiruchi, October 12: The first nuclear steam generator manufactured at the BHEL, Tiruchi, for the 235 MW Madras Atomic Power Project II, Kalpakam, rolled out last evening. It was an occasion for joy for the scores of engineers and skilled and unskilled technicians who had put in dedicated work to make this project a success.

As the steam generator cannot be moved by rail because of its huge size, it is being sent by road and is expected to reach Kalpakam on October 16.

The BHEL, Tiruchi, has undertaken the manufacture of eight numbers steam generators for the MAPP II. The eight generators, along with the turbo-generators to be supplied by the BHEL, Bhopal will generate 235 MW.

For completing the first steam generator, the Tiruchi factory had to equip itself with specialised machinery, nuclear clean room and a number of highly trained and qualified welders, supervisors, and engineers. The second, third and fourth generators are in fairly advanced stage of manufacture and will be completed before April 1977. The entire order for the supply of eight steam generators will be honoured by 1977-1978.

For the Rajasthan atomic power station, the steam generators were imported from Canada. In the course of manufacture of the steam generators, the BHEL successfully developed the technique of hot pull-outs required for the heavy water headers which eliminated the welding of the nozzie to the main header pipe. These heavy water headers were earlier imported from Canada. But the BHEL, by using this technique, has developed the heavy water headers indigenously.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO OCTOBER 13, 1926

The Indian currency league

Poona, October 12: The Indian Currency League, recently formed, opened their campaign this evening of educating public opinion in favour of 1sh 4d. ratio and against 1sh. 6d. per rupee recommended by the Currency Commission. Sir Purshotamdas, Sir Victor Sassoon, Messrs B.F. Madon, Jamnadas Dwarkadas and Professor Kale addressed the first public meeting held under the League's auspices with Mr. N.C. Kelkar in the chair.

Text&Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Decline in Bangalore's office workspace leasing in Jan-Sept

26 in per cent. Bengaluru, India's largest office market, witnessed a 26% year-on-year decline in workspace leasing to 16.7 million sq ft in January-September, according to Knight Frank. Real estate consultant Knight Frank India on Monday released its data, which showed that total office leasing remained flat at 66.7 million square feet across eight major cities. PTI

Fine imposed by Norway on Xandr over Grindr data sharing

9.6 in $ million. Norway's data protection authority has fined Microsoft's adtech unit Xandr 92 million crowns ($9.61 million) for unlawfully relaying Grindr users' sensitive data to advertisers, it said on Monday. Xandr relayed data revealing the sexual orientation of users of Grindr, a dating app for LGBTQIA+ people, to firms in automated ad auctions. REUTERS

Share of 2026 funding received by UN refugee agency

35 in per cent. Deep funding shortfalls are forcing the UN refugee agency to make painful cuts across its humanitarian operations worldwide, its chief said on Monday. The UN High Commissioner for Refugees has secured only $3 billion, or 35% of the $8.5 billion in funding it requires for 2026, High Commissioner Barham Salih said in Geneva. REUTERS

Surge in Equity MFs in September despite stock market volatility

31 in per cent. Equity mutual fund schemes saw a net inflow of ₹38,306 crore in September, registering a 31% rise from the preceding month, as investors continued to pour money into mid-cap and small-cap funds despite heightened stock market volatility. The inflow was higher than the ₹29,329 crore recorded in August, as per the data by Association of Mutual Funds in India. PTI

Social media posts taken down by Delhi Police

300 Delhi Police is monitoring various social media platforms to curb the spread of misinformation amid protests in the national capital, with around 300 posts allegedly aimed at spreading rumours or creating public unrest taken down, police sources said on Monday. PTI

COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Comparing SIR 2002-04 and 2025-26

Unlike previous SIRs, which had elaborate processes for preparing fresh rolls to ensure that no eligible elector would be taken off the rolls, the current SIR exercise adopts a flawed process that has led to the exclusion of lakhs of eligible voters; a point-by-point comparison is provided

EXPLAINER

Rangarajan R.

The story so far:
There have been renewed protests against the special intensive revision (SIR) process. Former Election Commissioners and Supreme Court judges have also questioned the exercise in its current form. As a counter, there have also been former judges and bureaucrats who have supported the current SIR process.

What is SIR?
Section 21(3) of the Representation of the People Act, 1950 (RP Act) authorises the Election Commission of India (ECI) to carry out a special revision of the electoral roll for 'any' constituency or part of a constituency in such manner as it may think fit.

The ECI had decided in June 2025 to carry out an SIR exercise across the country, starting with Bihar in Phase I. Phase II, held between October 2025 and February 2026, covered nine States and three Union Territories. Phase III, which commenced in May 2026, covered 16 States and three Union Territories. In May 2026, the Supreme Court held that the ECI was well within its constitutional mandate to conduct an SIR for 'many' or 'all' constituencies in a State.

How was the previous SIR done?
The Special Intensive Revision has been conducted on eight different occasions in the past, with the last one taking place between 2002 and 2004. They key guidelines issued in May 2002 for the last SIR, which have a bearing on the issues raised with respect to the current exercise, are summarised here.

First, the SIR required enumerators to conduct door-to-door verification using a preliminary list generated from the then existing roll. Elected Panchayat members could be voluntarily involved for assistance during the process.

Second, detailed guidelines were provided for supervision. Supervisors were required to randomly check at least 25% of the households covered by enumerators. Where an enumerator reported to the supervisor that a particular house had been locked during repeated visits, the supervisor was required to visit the house to verify this. Senior officers – Assistant Electoral Registration Officers (AEROs), EROs and District Election Officers – were required to check a minimum of 12%, 5% and 2% of the households, respectively.

Third, with regard to citizenship, the guidelines specified that the onus of proof of citizenship lay with the applicant who applied for inclusion of his/her name in the electoral roll for the first time. However, they also referred to the guidelines laid down by the Supreme Court in *Lal Babu Hussein and Others* (1995) which require the ERO to attach adequate 'probative value' to an applicant's presence in the existing roll.

Fourth, electors who had shifted residence were treated like a "transfer" rather than a deletion. Their entries in the preliminary list were not erased but struck through and marked "S" and enumerators had to record who reported the shift, besides the constituency or address to which the elector had moved. If an entire family had shifted, supervisors had to personally verify such cases. Since all areas were enumerated at the same time, the shifted electors were enrolled at their new address during the same exercise. The Chief Electoral Officer then acted as a clearing house to ensure that the old entry was deleted from the final roll. Only those missed at their new address had to apply during the claims and objections period.

Finally, the guidelines categorically mentioned that claims and objections presented in bulk by any individual/organisation or political party should be refused and rejected summarily. The final roll was to be prepared only after all claims and objections had been duly disposed of.



On the ground: BLOs verify voter details during the SIR exercise in Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh in July 2026. G.N. RAO

What are the key issues with the current SIR?
The key issues in the current SIR process are summarised here. First, the electors who could not be found, or who did not return or fill in the form, were excluded from the draft electoral roll, even if they had voted in previous elections. Unlike in 2002, those recorded as "shifted" were not enrolled at their new address through the same exercise. Under normal course, they would be required to file Form 8 (for shifting residence) at their new place of ordinary residence. Otherwise, if they are missed out, they would be required to apply afresh through Form 6, which is meant for new electors. This goes against the ECI's own Manual on Electoral Rolls (2023) which requires that a shifted elector who can be traced should be served a notice, and in cases where they cannot be traced, a notice must be pasted at their last known address in the presence of adult witnesses and the name should be deleted only after the notice period expires.

Second, the requirements of supervision of the current SIR are not as elaborate as the last SIR. The notification before Bihar's SIR mandates 10% random verification by supervisors and only requires regular monitoring meetings by ERO with AEROs, Supervisors and booth-level officers (BLOs) to ensure that work done is not superficial.

Third, the requirement for electors to trace themselves or a parent to the electoral rolls prepared during the last intensive revision, nearly two decades ago, or to produce documents to establish citizenship, is perceived as shifting the onus of proving their eligibility for inclusion in the rolls onto the common electors.

Fourth, software generated 'logical discrepancies', including spelling differences, more than six voters linked to one ancestor and parent-child age gaps outside the range of 15 to 45 years, among other factors, resulted in the arbitrary exclusion of lakhs of eligible voters.

Finally, there have been reports of filing of Form 7 (objection forms) in bulk by individuals for removing the names of electors from rolls at various places. In order to avoid the filing of such objection forms in bulk on unsubstantiated grounds, the ECI, only on October 9th, had issued instructions setting a cap on the number of objection forms that can be filed by an individual.

Apart from these procedural issues, legal concerns have also been raised regarding the validity of the declaration attached to Form 6 (used for enrolment of new electors), the use of Form 6 for re-enrolment of electors deleted from the draft rolls, and the cumbersome procedure for the disposal of a large number of appeals.

What can be the way forward?
The right to vote is a crucial edifice on which our democracy rests. The SIR process has resulted in the deletion of around 13.3 crore voters across the three phases. Around 2.7 crore (20%) were deleted due to death and 1.01 crore (8%) were flagged as duplicate entries. A significant portion of the 9.5 crore voters (71%) fall under the 'absent, shifted and others' category. Many of these 9.5 crore voters could be eligible for re-enrolment on completion of the SIR process.

Considering the renewed issues that have been raised surrounding the process, there should be a detailed audit of the rolls that have been finalised so far.

Eligible claims for re-enrolment should be expedited, including through home visits, and roll updations. Door-to-door enumeration should be the prescribed procedure for States where SIR is ongoing, and electoral rolls should be finalised only after the disposal of all claims and objections. As per the proviso to Section 21(3) of the RP Act, the existing pre-SIR rolls can continue to remain in force and be used for upcoming State elections, pending the completion of SIR rolls after due process.

(Rangarajan R. is a former IAS officer and author of 'Courseware on Polity Simplified'. He currently trains at Officers IAS Academy. Views expressed are personal.)

THE GIST

- The current SIR exercise has resulted in deletion of around 13.3 crore voters across the three phases. Around 2.7 crore (20%) were deleted due to death and 1.01 crore (7.6%) were flagged as duplicate entries. A significant portion of the 9.5 crore voters (71%) fall under the 'absent, shifted and others' category
- In the previous SIR in 2002-04, stringent guidance was provided to enumerators for door-to-door verification, maintenance of rolls and deletions
- Considering the issues raised around the current exercise, there is a need to expedite eligible claims for re-enrolment through home visits and door-to-door enumerations. The pre-SIR rolls can continue to remain in force pending the completion of the current SIR

PULSE CHECK



Unpaid and unseen: India has millions of informal, unpaid family caregivers who need to be recognised and upskilled as trained caregivers. GETTY IMAGES

Why does India need a trained workforce for elderly care?

India's 60-plus population is projected to touch 347 million by 2050, underscoring the need for a robust caregiving ecosystem; a formal training programme, building on existing small-scale initiatives, could promote gender parity in caregiving and recognise informal, unpaid family caregivers

T.C. Suseel Kumar
R. Sudhakar

Every day Sreeni wakes up at 4.30 am and checks on his mother. If she is unsteady on waking up, he will assist her to the raised toilet and wait outside as she independently uses it, assuring her that help is just outside. There is a schedule of medicines, clearly sorted and kept by her bedside. The BP monitor and the glucometer reassure him that everything is in the range for her age. He learnt it all by himself, one emergency visit after another to the hospital. Hip pain was ignored till it became a debilitating fracture, a sudden loss of consciousness detected as low sodium – each crisis was a hard lesson in the trial-and-error reality of informal caregiving. Every day millions like Sreeni wake up and perform their respective self-taught routines to take care of their parents or dependants.

As our country's population ages over the next two decades, the topic of caregiving and the need for formal training for the task will assume larger dimensions, and this is precisely what the Budget 2026-27 has highlighted in a timely manner with the announcement of training of 1.5 lakh caregivers aligned to the National Skills Qualifications Framework.

The NITI Aayog's August 2026 report "Reimagining Care: Strategies for Empowering Caregivers in Viksit Bharat@2047" frames caregiving as an economic activity rather than just welfare work, and this is the first time that such an intention is explicitly articulated by the Government at a national policy level, which indicates that the urgency has been acknowledged by policymakers.

To put it in perspective, India's 60-plus population, estimated at approximately 149 million in 2022, is projected to touch 347 million by 2050, forming roughly 20.8% of the total population. Assuming NITI Aayog's estimate that 10% of the population today is engaged in caregiving while being untrained and unpaid, the current total works out to about 146 million.

The planned 1.5 lakh formally trained workforce is just a drop in the ocean even by today's requirements. The caregiving ecosystem will be at a serious juncture if we don't plan now.

Gender parity in caregiving

For most of its history, India never needed a long-term care system because it had one: the joint family. Three generations under one roof was an insurance contract written in spirit and practised willingly. In the present scenario, with micro family units, most of the time, it is the housewives who take upon themselves the additional task of caregiving, having no formal training, learning by trial and sometimes serious error. Combined with the need to manage their own household chores, such situations increase household stress considerably. The aged who need assistance and the differently abled, about 26.8 million, are surviving, thanks to the love, care and affection of these unpaid, informal care givers.

An NSO survey has worked out that women, on average, spend 299 minutes per day on unpaid domestic work and caregiving, whereas for men it is only 97 minutes. What is required is an appreciation of the situation and the demands of caregiving being shouldered by both genders. A formal training programme, designed exclusively around caregiving, covering the detection of age-related events needing attention in the elderly, assessment of needs, continuous monitoring protocols, emergency care and psychological interventions, ideally attended by at least two family members, would improve the sharing of the duties and responsibilities.

Skilling and upskilling

If we need to have a large number of skilled, formally trained caregivers in a few years' time, we need to start in earnest.

Two structures are functioning in India, albeit on a small scale and untested. Kudumbashree is a State mission based in Kerala that runs a network of self-help groups. It launched the K4 Care training programme in February 2024 under which its members qualify as certified geriatric/patient/disability care executives. Recent data shows that only 838 have completed the course, a rather slow progress. We can incentivise and accelerate the programme.

The other group is the ASHA workers for whom the NHSRC (National Health Systems Resource Centre) has prepared a Training Manual on Elderly Care, with training delivered via Ayushman Bharat Health and Wellness Centres. However, granular details as to the number of ASHA workers who have completed this training are not available publicly. A meaningful intervention here can have a positive impact.

Informal caregiving is not always physical, like mobility assistance or medicine management. Age-related cognitive decline – as seen in Alzheimer's and Parkinson's disease – involves several emotional challenges as well. Any national curriculum must factor in geriatric mental health and behavioural management along with physical care protocols.

The way forward

There are millions of informal, unpaid family caregivers. We need to validate and upskill them into recognised caregivers.

Kudumbashree and ASHA workers who are formally trained, can serve as trainers to train more people, allowing the chain to continue. The National Caregiver Council (NCC), as envisaged in the NITI Aayog report, can act as an apex body. It can set benchmarks and supervise skill development, update training modules, standardise curricula, come out with useful FAQs and regulate and manage a national caregiver portal with a list of certified caregivers.

Transforming India's care economy is an economic strategy waiting to be unlocked. By creating such a robust ecosystem, India can turn informal dedication into professional expertise with great economic value. For millions like Sreeni, being recognised as a caregiver for the elderly and being trained formally to deal with the associated challenges bring dignity to the relationship.

Just as India is recognised the world over for its healthcare nursing professionals, its approach to managing the challenges of elderly care too could be adopted as the compassionate alternative to the many models being practised globally. The fact that this has been announced as a Budget item is just the seed, and operationalising it at the ground level is where the final success lies.

(T.C. Suseel Kumar a former Managing Director and R. Sudhakar is a former Executive Director, LIC. Views expressed are personal.)

THE DAILY QUIZ

Please send in your answers to dailyquiz@thehindu.co.in

As the latest edition of the Indian Super League kicked off this weekend after uncertainties around its future, here's a quiz on football clubs in the country

Vighnesh P. Venkitesh

QUESTION 1
Considered the oldest Indian club in existence, this team made history in 1911, becoming the first Indian club to win the IFA shield. Name the club and the nickname given to the winning squad.

QUESTION 2
Name the first club from south India and the State in which it was set up.

QUESTION 3
The Durand Cup, one of the oldest and most prestigious football competitions in India, established in 1888, was won by a domestic club for the first time in 1940. Name the club that beat the Royal Warwickshire Regiment 2-1 to end the British monopoly and mark a turning point for Indian football.

QUESTION 4
This club was named the best in India by the English FA in 1951 after it won the IFA shield three times in a row. Name the club.

QUESTION 5
Name the team of under-15s who famously defeated its corresponding squad of European powerhouse Liverpool 6-0 this year.



Visual question: While yet to be successful in terms of titles, this ISL club generated a huge fan following and is known for the atmosphere at its home ground. Name the club, which recently went through a management crisis, and the UAE-based group that acquired its ownership last month. H. VIBHU

Questions and answers to the previous day's daily quiz:
1. The Salem witch trials took place in this year. **Ans: 1692–1693**
2. This accused farmer was executed on August 19, 1692, after maintaining his innocence during the trials. **Ans: John Proctor**
3. This accused man was subjected to *peine forte et dure*, a form of judicial torture involving the application of heavy weights, after refusing to enter a plea. **Ans: Giles Corey, who was pressed to death on September 19, 1692**
4. The number of people hanged during the Salem witch trials, and the ones who died in prison. **Ans: 19 people were hanged, while at least five others died in prison. Giles Corey was separately pressed to death**
5. Name of the enslaved woman whose confession played a pivotal role in the early witchcraft accusations. **Ans: Tituba, who was enslaved by the Reverend Samuel Parris**
Visual: This 1953 play by Arthur Miller dramatises the Salem witch trials and uses them as an allegory for political persecution in 20th-century America. **Ans: The Crucible**
Early birds: KN Viswanathan | Sukdev Shet | Mohan Lal Patel | Sunil Madhavan | Tariqa Bali



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the opposite of "tomboy"? (Keshava Rao, Kakinada)
Unfortunately there is no word which is the exact opposite. This is another example of how sexist the English language is. A girl who dresses like a boy and behaves like one is called a "tomboy". When you call a girl a "tomboy" you are not passing any judgment on her. When a boy begins to behave like a girl, he is laughed at. He is universally condemned. A word that is commonly used to describe such a person is "sissy". When you call a boy a "sissy", you are implying he lacks the qualities, which you would associate with the male of the species. The word "sissy", unlike the word "tomboy", has a negative connotation. Most people would say that it is okay for a young girl to behave like a boy, but it's not okay for a boy, no matter how young, to behave like a girl. Here is an example.

What's that sissy Ramu doing over here?

The word "sissified" is being used these days to mean "effeminate".

The words "sissify" and "sissified" are mostly used in informal contexts.

Which is correct? "The inspection was made/done"? (W. Srinivasulu, Alur)
Both are acceptable. One can either "make" an inspection or "do" an inspection. It's also possible to say, "carry out an inspection". Here are a few examples.

We made the inspection last week.

The inspection was done last week.

The inspection was carried out last week.

What is the meaning of "putative"? (S. Barani Dharan, Chennai)
The word "putative" means, generally believed or accepted to be true. You are not really sure if something is true or not, but you, like others, believe that it is. For example, if I say the "putative leader", what it implies is that I believe that he is the leader but I am not really sure. Here are a few examples.

There have been many attempts to capture the putative Abominable Snowman.

The police shot and killed the putative leader of the terrorist organisation.

What is the difference between "in spite of" and "despite"? (Ramakrishna Bhat, Hubli)
There is no difference; the two words can be used interchangeably. The only thing that you have to remember is that you shouldn't use the word "of" with despite. Here are a few examples.

Despite the pain, he continued to work.

In spite of the pain he continued to work.

What is the meaning of "testing the waters"? (D. Shivakumar, Secunderabad)
When you "test the waters" what you are doing is finding out the opinions of people before you actually go ahead and do what you plan to do. This is a term that is normally used in politics and business. Here is an example.

I think we should test the waters before we open a hotel in this part of town.

Published in The Hindu on March 26, 2002

Word of the day

Brash:
offensively bold

Synonyms: cheeky, nervy

Usage: *His brash manner offended several people at the meeting.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/brash

International Phonetic Alphabet: /ˈbɹæʃ/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'

INBRIEF



Volvo introduces electric luxury SUV EX90 at ₹1.26 cr.

With 25% of its sales volume coming from electric vehicles, Volvo Car India has announced the introduction of EX90, an new all-electric luxury SUV, at an introductory priced of ₹1.26 crore (ex-showroom). The launch of the six-seater family SUV marks Volvo's first-ever software-defined vehicle offering in the Indian market. It is developed on Volvo's new SPA2 platform. The company has opened bookings for the EX90 and deliveries are slated to begin from January 2027. An introductory offer will be valid on all bookings made before December 31, 2026. This includes an 11kW wall box charger and a three-year service package, with Volvo Cars dealerships offering a 65% buyback offer after three years, the company said. The vehicle is powered by the NVIDIA DRIVE platform and Qualcomm Snapdragon 8155 cockpit technology.

Coal stocks at thermal plants hold above 18 MT as of Oct. 10

Domestic thermal power plants had coal stocks of 18.205 million tonnes (MT) as of October 10, with supplies averaging 2.49 MT per day, the government said on Monday, assuring that stocks were adequate. The Coal Ministry said stocks had remained "stable" at above 18 MT since September 29, even as thermal power plants continued to consume coal at a daily rate of less than 3 MT. Thermal power accounted for more than 60% of electricity generated during peak demand. "The stabilisation reflects coal supplies keeping pace with daily consumption at power plants and the supply to the plants with critical stocks is being closely monitored, with requirement-based redistribution of coal to vulnerable stations to ensure adequate supplies and uninterrupted power generation," the ministry said. The rate of stock depletion – the gap between coal consumption and incoming supplies – has moderated significantly, from 0.24 MT per day in September to 0.06 MT per day during the first 10 days of October. The improvement in supplies has been accompanied by an increase in rail freight movement. "Daily rake loading in October has ranged between 447 and 482 rakes," the government said.

SIPs register record inflow of ₹32,490 cr. in September

Despite global challenges, tightening monetary cycle and muted returns from the domestic equity market, equity MFs received ₹38,306.55 crore, marking it the 67th consecutive month of inflows

Gowri Lakshmi
MUMBAI

Amid rapidly evolving geopolitical landscape and global headwinds, foreign institutional investors (FIIs) remained net sellers in September, according to the latest data released by the Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI) on Monday.

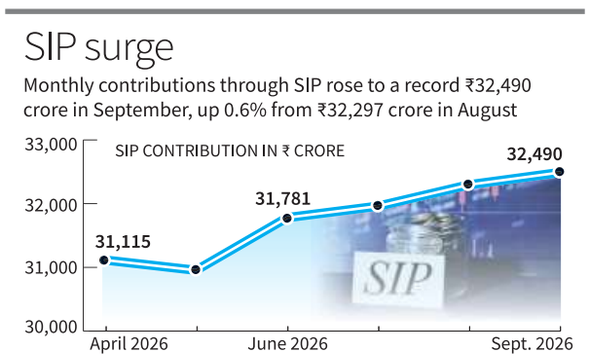
On the other hand, Systematic Investment Plan (SIP) participation continued to rise, with retail investment participation in September marking a record inflow of ₹32,490 crore last month.

Overall SIP assets now account for 21.6% of total industry assets at ₹17.86 lakh crore.

Despite the global challenges, tightening monetary cycle and muted returns from the domestic equity market during the month, equity mutual funds received an inflow of ₹38,306.55 crore, marking 67th consecutive month of inflows.

However, assets under management of the mutual fund industry declined by 5.1% on month to ₹82.64 lakh crore (₹82.64 trillion) in September. The decline was driven primarily from outflows in debt funds, which stood at ₹17.64 lakh crore, and on account of mark to market losses.

"The industry has added 27.13 lakh folios during this particular month, taking the total count to 28.62 crores, up by over 0.9% from 28.35 crores in August. The equity funds have remained the largest contributor, accounting for 66.7% of the total folios, with around 17.70 lakh issued during this particular month," AMFI Chief Executive Venkat N. Chalasani said. As per the data, net outflows stood at ₹1.3 trillion in the previous month, compared with ₹41,353.60 crore in August.



SOURCE: ASSOCIATION OF MUTUAL FUNDS IN INDIA

Abu Dhabi National Oil Company open to long-term deals with India for LPG

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI


Nasser Omair Al Muhairi

The Abu Dhabi National Oil Company (ADNOC) is open to further long-term liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) supply agreements with India and sees significant potential to deepen cooperation across crude oil, liquefied natural gas (LNG), naphtha, trading, shipping and strategic storage, Nasser Omair Al Muhairi, its Acting CEO (downstream industry, marketing and trading business) told *The Hindu* in an exclusive interaction.

"By combining [ADNOC's] supply, trading and shipping capabilities, ADNOC is well-positioned to provide Indian customers with reliable long-term LPG access, greater flexibility and enhanced energy security," he said.

Mr. Al Muhairi described India as one of ADNOC's most important energy markets.

Indian Oil had signed a strategic collaboration agreement with ADNOC in May during Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the United Arab Emirates (UAE). The agreement seeks to expand LPG supply and trading opportunities, including through ADNOC's global trading unit, and potentially pave the way for a long-term sale and purchase agreement, building on the LPG term contract in place since 2023.

Mr. Al Muhairi said ADNOC's "reliability, operational resilience and proximity" to key demand centres positioned it as a trusted partner in meeting India's growing energy needs.

ADNOC supplied more than 5,00,000 barrels of crude oil a day to India in 2025, accounting for "almost one in ten barrels of [India's] crude imports", Mr. Al Muhairi said.

Leading supplier

The company is also among India's leading suppliers of LNG and naphtha.

"Building on this foundation, we see significant opportunities to deepen cooperation across crude, LNG, LPG, naphtha, trading, shipping and strategic storage," he said.

ADNOC's ambition, he added, extended beyond supplying more energy to Indian customers to providing "greater security and flexibility while supporting investment and growth across the energy value chain."

Mr. Al Muhairi said that ADNOC is working to increase its oil production capacity to five million barrels a day by 2027.

It is also expanding domestic gas production and broadening access to global LNG supplies.

"Recent market conditions have reinforced the value of this integrated approach, with logistics and export infrastructure helping maintain reliable and flexible supply during periods of disruption," Mr. Al Muhairi said.

GE to double annual component sourcing

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

GE Aerospace aims to double the sourcing from India to $400 mn by 2030 from $200 mn in 2025

GE Aerospace said it aims to nearly double its annual component sourcing from India to $400 million by 2030, from about $200 million in 2025, as the company expands its presence in the country's growing aviation market.

The company expects its footprint to grow significantly over the next decade, with its joint venture with Safran, CFM International, anticipating a substantial increase in its installed engine base in India. CFM International had a fleet of more than 1,400 commercial engines in India as of December 2025. This is expected to rise to 3,200 engines over the next nine to 10 years.

"This will mean that nine out of 10 engines in India will be powered by either GE or CFM within the next decade," Vikram Rai, GE Aerospace's South Asia CEO, told journalists.

The expansion comes amid rising aircraft orders by Indian airlines that seek to capitalise on growing passenger traffic and increasing air travel demand.

LTTS bets big on manufacturing AI

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI

L&T Technology Services (LTTS) is betting on artificial intelligence (AI) for manufacturing and operations to offset pricing pressure from AI-led efficiencies in parts of its engineering business, as it seeks to monetise the technology through proprietary tools, licences and new industrial applications, chief executive Amit Chadha said on Monday.

Speaking at the unveiling of the company's Engineering Intelligence (EI) Lab for Manufacturing and Operations in Bengaluru, he said AI was reducing the effort required for engineering tasks while opening up new business opportunities in products and manufacturing.

"The third part of the business is AI for manufacturing and operations, which is what this lab is about. And this, again, is a net new for us," he said, outlining LTTS's three areas of AI activity: engineering, products, and manufacturing and operations. Mr. Chadha said AI was reducing the effort involved in generating code, models, diagrams, mechanical drawings and components. LTTS is developing proprietary tools and working with technology partners to help clients complete such tasks faster.

Coffee sector plans AI-led mechanisation push with IIT support

Mini Tejaswi
CHIKMAGALUR


Kurma Rao

India's coffee industry is exploring a collaborative initiative to develop artificial intelligence (AI)-based farm equipment, mechanisation technologies, and tools with the Coffee Board of India proposing a joint effort involving planters' associations, growers' bodies and Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) in Dharwad and Roorkee.

Kurma Rao M., Chief Executive Officer and Secretary of the Coffee Board, called for closer coordination among the Board, the Karnataka Planters' Association (KPA), the United Planters' Association of Southern India (UPASI) and other industry stakeholders to accelerate technology development. He was speaking at the KPA's annual conference in Chikmagalur on Monday.

Highlighting the need to integrate engineering with agriculture, Mr. Rao said the Coffee Board had constituted a committee on mechanisation involving experts and industry stakeholders. The Board was collaborating with IIT Roorkee, which had developed a prototype for a harvesting machine suited to Indian conditions.

Discussions were also under way with IIT Dharwad, which is working with the KPA on technological interventions in agriculture.

Mr. Rao suggested that the institutions and industry bodies pool their expertise rather than pursue parallel initiatives. The UPASI's technical research foundation (TRF) could also contribute to the effort, particularly in developing AI-enabled solutions for farm operations, he recommended.

Mechanisation, especially harvesting, has emerged as a priority for the sector, given the need to address labour-related challenges and modernise cultivation practices. India-specific equipment could help improve operational efficiency while responding to the requirements of coffee-growing estates, he further said.

Karnataka accounts for nearly 70% of India's coffee production, making technological improvements in the State particularly significant for the industry. Mr. Rao also underlined the importance of sustained collaboration between research institutions and growers to translate prototypes and technical interventions into practical, field-level solutions.

HCLTech posts 21% YoY jump in Q2 net profit

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

HCLTech on Monday reported a 21.2% YoY growth in consolidated net profit for the quarter ended September 2026, at ₹5,132 crore compared with ₹4,235 crore in the year-ago period.

The Noida-based company's revenue from operations in the second quarter stood at ₹35,620 crore, up 11.5% compared with ₹31,942 crore in the same quarter last year. Advanced AI revenue stood at $219 million, up 78% YoY in constant currency (CC) in the second quarter.

Addressing a press conference, C. Vijayakumar, CEO & MD, HCLTech, said, "We delivered a strong quarter with new bookings of $3.3 billion, up 27% YoY, taking first half bookings to a record high. EBIT margin expanded 131 bps QoQ to 18.2%. Our AI propositions were resonating well with our clients, giving us confidence in our growth trajectory."

Roshni Nadar Malhotra, Chairperson, HCLTech, said, the accelerating growth in Advanced AI revenue validated the company's business strategy.

Meanwhile, HCLTech and Anthropic have signed a global partnership to expand enterprise agentic AI deployments.The partnership would also cover AI Force integrations, with safeguards and human oversight for high-impact changes, it said.

Agilisium aims to cut CS hire below 30%, eyes $500 mn revenue in next 5-7 years

Balasubramanyam C.P.
CHENNAI


Raj Babu

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is prompting life sciences technology company Agilisium to overhaul its hiring strategy, with founder and CEO Raj Babu aiming to reduce computer science (CS) graduates to less than 30% of new recruits and bring in more professionals from biotechnology, microbiology, pharmacy and medicine.

The strategy rests on the belief that professionals with domain expertise in pharmaceutical science and clinical processes can be trained to use AI and develop software more easily than conventional programmers can acquire specialised knowledge of life sciences.

"I am pushing for computer science to be less than 30%," Mr. Babu said during an interaction with journalists in Chennai on Monday. "We are hiring business people and we are training the business people to do the development and the programming." Founded in 2014, Agilisium entered the life sciences segment in 2018. While its earlier hiring was dominated by CS graduates, it now recruits from institutions such as the National Institute of Pharmaceutical Education and Research (NIPER) and Indian Institutes of Management, as well as biotechnology and microbiology programmes. Its recruits include MBBS doctors, dentists and PhDs.

Mr. Babu believes AI is reducing the need for multiple layers of intermediaries between business teams and software developers. Domain experts can increasingly work directly on business problems, using AI to build solutions, while computer science graduates can focus on validating the quality of the output.

The approach is central to Agilisium's forward-deployment expert (FDE) model, which combines domain knowledge with technology skills, consultative thinking and first-principles problem-solving. Training involves about four months of formal instruction, followed by three to six months of hands-on experience.

Of the company's global workforce of about 1,400, nearly 100 employees have been trained as FDEs. Agilisium aims to increase that number to more than 700 next year. An AI platform under development is expected to scale training through workflow-specific modules, including one for clinical-trial validation.

The company is targeting $100 million in revenue next year and aims to reach $500 million within five to seven years. Its life sciences business has been growing at about 45% annually, Mr. Babu said.

The U.S. currently accounts for 95% of its revenue, with India contributing the remaining 5%. At the $500-million revenue mark, Agilisium expects the U.S. share to fall to about 70%, while India could contribute 15-20% and Europe 5-10%, making India its second-largest market.

Mr. Babu said the company was bootstrapped, financially sound and not seeking external funding. It would consider a strategic partner if the arrangement brought capabilities and accelerated growth beyond what capital alone could achieve.

Agilisium works with technology partners, including Anthropic's Claude, Amazon Web Services and Databricks.

It is also looking to partner with specialists in clinical research, research and development, and cell and gene therapy.

Agilisium is expanding in Hyderabad, which Mr. Babu expects to become its largest Indian hub over the next few years.

PC market witnessed massive contraction in Q3 2026: Gartner

Mini Tejaswi
BENGALURU

Steep downturn has effectively dragged shipment volumes back down to levels last seen in Q1 2023

Global personal computer (PC) market witnessed a massive contraction in the third quarter of 2026, with worldwide shipments plummeting 22.4% year-over-year to total 55.4 million units, according to data released by market tracker, Gartner.

This steep downturn has effectively dragged shipment volumes back down to levels last seen in the first quarter of 2023. Unlike previous market slumps driven by excess inventory, this recent collapse was primarily triggered by severe component cost inflation, it said. "The impact of higher memory and storage costs is now fully reflected in PC pricing. DRAM costs surged five times year-over-year in the second quarter, and PC vendors passed those higher component costs on to customers, driving the steep decline in PC shipments during the third quarter," said Namrata Banerjee, Principal, Research at Gartner. PC shipments have fallen to levels last seen in early 2023, though the market dynamics were noticeably different, Ms. Banerjee added.

A fivefold surge in DRAM (Dynamic Random-Access Memory) year-over-year during the second quarter forced PC vendors to pass these higher expenses onto customers, significantly raising average selling prices and making device replacements unaffordable for many buyers.

The crunch spared no major industry players, as all top six worldwide PC vendors reported shipment declines. Market leader Lenovo mirrored the broader industry with a 22.4% year-over-year drop, leveraging its supply chain scale to maintain its top position. HP Inc. suffered the most severe blow among the leading players, recording a sharp 30.9% decline due to its high exposure to price-sensitive consumer and mainstream business segments, according to Gartner.

Meanwhile, tech giant Apple managed to weather the storm better than its peers, registering the lowest shipment decline among the top six vendors and gaining 1.7 percentage points in market share on the back of its mainstream MacBook portfolio.

Scarce component availability forced manufacturers to reprioritise high-priced configurations, prompting corporate clients to limit spending on AI PCs and workstations instead of executing broad-based deployments.

West Asia LNG industry remains a hostage of war



In the firing line: The Iran war, now in its eighth month, has dealt a heavy blow to Qatar. REUTERS

Reuters
LONDON

While West Asia oil exports have rebounded in recent weeks, Qatar's vast liquefied natural gas export facilities remain hobbled. Until a durable resolution of the U.S.-Israeli war with Iran is reached, Gulf shipments will be heavily curtailed, leaving the global LNG market seriously strained.

Qatar is the world's second-largest producer of LNG behind the U.S. It accounts for around a fifth of global capacity at nearly 80 million metric tonnes per year.

The Iran war, now in its eighth month, has dealt a heavy blow to Qatar. The country was forced to shut down much of its main LNG complex at Ras Laffan shortly after the start of hostilities and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

Iranian missile attacks also knocked out around 17% of Qatar's export capacity, costing the country tens of billions of dollars in lost annual revenue and inflicting damage that could take years to repair. The economic blow has been among the biggest in the region. The IMF forecasts Qatar's gross domestic product will contract by 8.6% in 2026, compared with pre-war expectations for 6.1% growth. The severe disruption to Qatar's LNG exports, alongside a drop in exports from neighbouring UAE , has sent shockwaves through global gas markets. The supply hit was partially cushioned by a sharp increase in U.S. exports, which rose by around 14% in 2026 from a year earlier to 123 million tonnes – but the gap in the global LNG market remained large.

The impact was felt most acutely in Asia and Europe, which rely heavily on LNG imports and have limited alternatives to replace disrupted Gulf supplies. Asian and European LNG prices hit their highest level since early 2023 in late September, nearly tripling from pre-Iran war levels. While QatarEnergy, the country's national energy company, has indicated it will be able to restart LNG production within weeks once Hormuz reopens, LNG importers should not get too optimistic. A deeper look at Qatar's current situation suggests its LNG industry won't be returning to pre-war norms any time soon.

The outlook for Gulf crude exports certainly has improved. Iran's grip on Hormuz appears to have weakened in recent weeks, allowing a sharp increase in oil exports from the region.

West Asia crude shipments through Hormuz rose in September to around 80% of pre-war levels at 16 million barrels per day, according to data analytics firm Kpler. Producers appear increasingly confident transiting the waterway with U.S. Navy support, even as Iran's strikes on shipping have risen in recent weeks to the highest number since the war began. The increase in exports has allowed Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Kuwait and Iraq to raise domestic production meaningfully. Yet LNG traffic in the Gulf has barely recovered. While Qatar's LNG exports rose in September to their highest level since the start of the conflict at 1.6 MT, that was still less than a quarter of the pre-war average, said Kpler.

Central banks face a tough test. Will they be good cops or bond villains?

Central banks currently appear reluctant to rebuild holdings of sovereign debt, yet those holdings played a significant role in the swelling public borrowing over the past decade; That means either an improbable fiscal tightening will need to emerge or political knives will be sharpened

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
LONDON

A stand-off between central banks and their cash-strapped governments may well be looming as an intensifying bond market crunch reopens questions about the political independence of the banks well beyond their interest-rate policy.

Central banks currently appear reluctant to rebuild holdings of sovereign debt, yet those holdings played a significant role in the swelling public borrowing over the past decade. Moving forward, that means either an improbable fiscal tightening will need to emerge or political knives will be sharpened.

Numerous elections in the U.S., France, Italy and Spain over the coming year mean significant spending cuts are unlikely to be on the agenda. If bond markets continue to tighten – as we've seen in recent weeks – political pressure on central banks to steady the ship will rise even further.

Seeing the problem coming like a slow-motion car crash, central banks are trying to nuance their position.

On one hand, a post-pandemic consensus has built around further "normalisation" of their bond-packed balance sheets. This includes a retrospective disdain for using bond accumulation as a monetary policy tool.

On the other hand, policymakers want to keep all options open for temporary fixes in the event of market malfunctioning or another left-field shock.

Bank for International Settlements (BIS) boss Pablo Hernandez de Cos this week laid out some principles for using emergency tools if conditions get rough, using the example of the Bank of England's (BoE) limited and brief support for stressed British gilts during the budget blow-up in 2022.

"A key challenge is to bolster market confidence without overstimulating the economy in the longer term," he said of such emergency tools.

"Central banks should try to better distinguish programmes for market functioning from those for monetary stimulus."

But the problem with a middle-ground, only-in-emergencies approach is that sometimes debt markets can get squeezed even when there isn't an acute crisis.



Money matters: People walk past the Bank of England building in London, Britain. REUTERS

Just look at the current global bond sell-off. Markets are not necessarily malfunctioning, and despite the clear energy hit from the Iran war, there's no global shock on the scale of COVID-19 or the 2008 banking crash to justify a red alert. Yet markets continue to inflict maximum pain on government debt-service bills.

Should this continue, alongside a relatively hot AI-infused economy and above-target inflation rates, monetary policymakers could find themselves in a very tough spot. If central banks do step in, the lines between "backstops," monetary policy and direct government support could become blurred, and central bankers could once again find themselves criticised for enabling rising government debt loads.

Yet governments across the developed world may expect them to do just that if sovereign bond yields keep increasing.

Rising debt-service bills are coming at a time when ageing demographics in most Group of Seven (G7) economies have already been heaping pressure on pension and healthcare systems, while defence spending is set to spiral higher amid increasingly fraught geopolitics.

Pointing to forecasts that global government debt will exceed annual global GDP by 2030, International Monetary Fund head Kristalina Georgieva this week warned rich governments to deliver credible fiscal-consolidation plans urgently and not fall back on central banks to bail them out. "I would call this 'monetary cowboys', running to the rescue of the fiscal agents, and my message is: please don't."

> A key challenge is to bolster market confidence without overstimulating the economy in the longer term
>
> **PABLO HERNANDEZ DE COS**
> Bank for International Settlements

For context, we need to rewind a bit.

Of the multiple reasons cited for the intense government bond market sell-off in recent months, a big question revolves around the gaping hole left in debt markets by the gradual withdrawal of G7 central banks from the swelling debt piles they facilitated following 2008. The sell-off has pushed long-term U.S. sovereign borrowing costs to their highest in almost a quarter of a century.

Perhaps the best way to understand how artificially cheap borrowing distorted the picture is to examine how quickly governments accumulated debt when their central banks were buying bonds and effectively underwriting large chunks of it.

The Washington-based Institute of International Finance recently estimated that even though average government borrowing costs across the G7 are back at mid-2008 levels, annual interest expenses are 85% higher because G7 government debts have almost trebled to more than $60 trillion in the interim.

Advanced economies collectively are now paying over $3.3trillion to service bonds alone, it said, which is more than their estimated spending on either AI, defence or clean energy.

But coinciding with, and aggravating, the recent surge in government debt costs has been the steady pruning of central bank balance sheets over the past four years. The aggregate G7central bank balance sheet peaked at over $30 trillion of bonds in early 2022 and has been cut by about a third since then. Along with the sharp rise in central bank policy rates to choke off inflation, that one-third reduction has coincided with a 40% drop in long-term G7 government bond indexes and a four-percentage-point spike in their implied borrowing rate.

Have central banks exited too much or too quickly, and should they pause that withdrawal until they rethink it?

Quantitative easing

Opinion on the wisdom of so-called quantitative easing (QE) – massive central-bank bond-buying programmes – has done an almost 180-degree turn since the inflation spikes and debt explosions of the pandemic and its aftermath.

For many, the banking crash of 2008 and 2020's COVID-19 lockdowns justified extraordinary one-off balance sheet reactions from the Federal Reserve and others. But many also now criticise the continuous use of bond buying as an ongoing monetary tool, arguing that it underwrote the massive expansion of government debt over the past 20 years.

Much of the central bank world now feels the experiment may have been misguided at best, both because it tiptoed into quasi-fiscal territory and because of a variety of market distortions and inequality questions that arose from what was essentially direct support for wealthier asset owners.

New Fed Chair and long-time balance-sheet-expansion sceptic Kevin Warsh claims the whole 18-year QE episode "borders on fiscal policy." He has already set up one of his Fed reform taskforces to look at ways to reduce the balance sheet holdings further.

On the other side of the pond, the BoE is still actively selling gilts, albeit with recent plans to concentrate sales in short-dated paper.

And the European Central Bank (ECB) is still actively running down its balance sheet, which amounts to more than 40% of euro zone GDP, even as the region faces echoes of the 2011-12 euro debt crisis in French bond markets. A change of ECB leadership is also on the horizon, and the leading candidates don't appear to have an appetite for a return to the 2010s and the firefighting activism of former chief Mario Draghi.

Twitchier treasuries

There is also the question of who is holding government debt.

The reduction of G7 central bank bond holdings has coincided with reduced pension-fund demand for long-dated government debt as defined-benefit schemes dwindle and pension savers retire.

Those gaps left by long-term investors keen on safety and steady coupons have increasingly been filled by more speculative, short-term players such as hedge funds, who are much more sensitive to big price shifts, vulnerable to short-term interest rate changes and prone to herding in volatile conditions.

Hedge fund activity in sovereign bond markets has been the focus of regulators for years. While everyone welcomes the demand and liquidity they provide, there is now growing concern about the flipside of that if this "fast money" base gets twitchy.

Some efforts have been made to reduce excessive leverage in government bond markets, but no matter how that pans out, the scale of hedge fund activity in these markets, and by extension the exposure of the banks and trading houses that provide them with leverage, makes for a more skittish environment.

"These buyers are more inclined to sell bonds in response to higher short-term interest rates – funding leg sensitivity – and charge a higher price for the risk of further upward moves," wrote Carlyle strategist Jason Thomas. "When coupled with the growth in the outstanding volume of debt, this new class of investors has left bond markets more fragile and sensitised to front-end repricing."

This sensitivity helps to explain the recent disturbance in Treasury markets, which seems to have been driven largely by the Fed changing course on short-term rates.

SMBC Nikko's rates strategist Joseph Abate cites Fed studies trying to quantify that sensitivity. Fed economist Phillip Monin estimates that hedge fund demand for cash-futures arbitrage plays has increased fourfold since 2020 and is now 3.5% of outstanding Treasury supply. Another Fed study last month by Daniel Beltran and Canlin Li found that the market's sensitivity to new supply had doubled over the past decade, with every 1% increase in new debt, some $300 billion or more, increasing 5-year yields by 8 basis points.

Regulators, governments and central banks are watching this closely. But any planned tightening of rules could well have adverse effects at a politically risky moment. While the answer, in theory, may be reducing the supply of government debt, in practice, that is very unlikely to occur.

The alternative solution lands back in the lap of now more hesitant central banks – kicking and screaming perhaps.

How Atmanirbhar Bharat can help cut crude shipment costs

Anil Devli

One does not need to be a diehard optimist to understand that every catastrophe or a seemingly Black Swan event brings with it challenges as well as opportunities.

Take the example of the current war in the Gulf region and the ongoing oil crises - it is obvious that shipping costs have inflated. The plug has been pulled and India has been forced to look to replace the crude oil it was traditionally buying from the PG region which pre-war stood at roughly 50 to 60%. Refineries in India are now compelled to source crude oil farther away from India. As the distances have increased, so has the time taken for a round voyage. Diversions due to geo-political risks in the Red Sea region have accentuated the voyage days leading to a a scarcity of ships and consequently freights skyrocketing. Last week Indian Oil Corporation (IOCL) is reported to have hired a VLCC for a record-shattering freight of $47.75 million (₹458 crore) for a single voyage to ship crude oil from East Coast Mexico to Paradip.

While the market will be driven by extraneous circumstances, one is concerned about the payment of such high freights to non- Indian entities. Here lies an excellent opportunity for Indian charterers to turn this into a gain for the Indian economy instead of a drain of forex. The super tanker Zourva is a 12-year-old Maltese-flagged VLCC owned by Minerva Marine Inc. This is the highest freight rate paid for an India-bound crude parcel ever. One observes that often such lucrative contracts which provide huge earning opportunities are awarded to foreigners and foreign ships. What we are missing out is that this is also a big opportunity for Indian company and the 'mantra' of PM Modi of vocal for local. Contracts and times like these now present the opportunity to Indian flag companies to carry these long distance crude oil to Indian shores.



Costing a bomb: Last week, IOCL is reported to have hired a VLCC for a record-shattering freight of $47.75 million (₹458 crore) for a single voyage to ship crude oil from East Coast Mexico to Paradip. PTI

Double whammy

While all Indian refiners are impacted by oil prices, the freight paid to foreign ships completes the double whammy. It may be serendipity that has landed this shipment contract with a foreign shipping company.

However, some smart and strategic thinking on the part of Indian PSUs could have diverted this shipment from landing in the lap of a foreign entity and the huge freight from being paid to a non-Indian shipping company. Awarding the contract to Indian ships or floating the tender strategically when a suitable Indian flag tonnage was available would have ensured strategic control over supply chains and ensured that the massive freight of more than ₹400 crore would have found itself within the Indian economy. This would have been a true win-win for the Indian economy and adherence to the policy nudges of the PM of India to use local and generate business with Indian companies.

At the height of the 2017 Doklam face off with China, the eyesore of an oversight was widely reported in July 2017 that India, through the Indian oil companies, made its very first purchase of crude oil from the U.S.

The 1.6 million barrels were to be transported on a Very Large Crude Carrier (VLCC) and that the cost of the cargo commodity, that is crude oil on an ex-ship basis was reported to be 'very competitive'.

While this news was commendable, the strategic blunder was the fact that the carriage of cargo was awarded to Petrochina which meant that Chinese flag ships would transport this cargo.

At the time of conflict with China, India had handed over one more lever to China our cargo as well as our freight.

Its time that our charterers observe the principles of 'Serve from India' and - "Atmanirbhar Bharat".

In these days of rising freight and uncertainty of supply chain stricking partnerships between Indian ships and Indian charterers will lead to control over supply chains, saving of flight of valuable foreign exchange (forex) as freight and control our our economically sensitive cargoes.

(The writer is the CEO of the Indian National Shipowners Association)

TEHRAN

Iran says 'deeply concerned' over Houthi-Saudi Arabia escalation



X/@IRIMFA_SPOX

Iran said on Monday that it was "deeply concerned" by escalating attacks between Yemen's Tehran-backed Houthis and Saudi Arabia, after 14 people died in two days of strikes on Riyadh's airport. Foreign Ministry spokesman Esmaeil Baqaei said Tehran was ready "to help facilitate dialogue between the parties". AFP

ANKARA

Kurdish militants pull out of camps in Iraq in peace push with Türkiye



AP

Kurdish militants have withdrawn from four camps in northern Iraq as part of a peace effort with Türkiye, according to a report on Monday. The Kurdistan Workers' Party, or PKK, vacated the camps in the Baze area of northern Iraq's Metina region, near the Turkish border, Turkey's state-run Anadolu news agency reported. AP

KANO

Gunmen kill 24, including eight soldiers, in two attacks in Nigeria



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Gunmen have killed 24 people, including eight soldiers and a policeman, in two separate attacks in northwest and central Nigeria over the weekend, residents and aid workers said on Monday. There has been a rise in attacks, blamed on gangs engaged in kidnapping for ransom and cattle rustling and on jihadist groups. AFP

ADDIS ABABA

Ethiopian govt. forces enter key Tigray town near Eritrea border



AFP

Ethiopian federal forces and their allies entered a key northern Tigrayan town near the Eritrean border without a fight, residents told AFP on Monday, after it was abandoned by rebels. The fight between the forces and the Tigray People's Liberation Front, which Ethiopia says is backed by Eritrea, erupted in late September. AFP

Riyadh vows response after deadly airport hits

Saudi Arabia says the Houthi attacks have tested its resolve and that its retaliation would be decisive; Trump says he is considering joining the strikes; Houthis continue their missile attacks

Agence France-Presse
RIYADH



An image from CCTV video shows passengers taking cover during Saturday's strikes at the Riyadh airport. SAUDI MEDIA MINISTRY VIA AP

Saudi Arabia's Energy Minister on Monday said the country had been tested but would mount a "serious" response after a string of attacks on Riyadh's international airport by Yemen's Houthis that left 18 people dead.

"Energy security can't be taken for granted," Prince Abdulaziz bin Salman told an energy conference in Riyadh, as oil prices topped $105 a barrel. "The events of recent weeks are serious, our response must be equally serious." He added, "For Saudi Arabia, these circumstances have tested our infrastructure, our institutions, our people, and our resilience."

On Saturday, Houthi strikes killed 13 people and wounded hundreds at King Khalid International Airport – the deadliest attack on Saudi soil in more than a decade. Four people died in earlier attacks on Wednesday and Thursday, and another was killed on Sunday. Operations remained suspended at the sprawling airport on Riyadh's outskirts on Monday.

The atmosphere in Riyadh remained tense on Monday, as state broadcaster Al Ekhbariya said the military coalition was responding to drone and missile threats, and Australia's embassy warned its citizens in the city to shelter in a safe place.

The Houthis on Sunday claimed multiple attacks over the previous 24 hours, including on the airport, and threatened to keep targeting Saudi transit hubs, calling them "a theatre of operations for our forces".

Hours later, the coalition said yet another projectile had struck Riyadh airport, sparking a fire, while air defences intercepted a missile nearby.

Riyadh's airport was not the only one to suffer a deadly attack: early on Monday, officials said one person had been killed and 11 wounded in a strike on Dammam airport. The Saudi-led coalition said on Monday that it had also "intercepted and destroyed" a Houthi heading for the southern city of Khamis Mushait, home to a major military base.

Despite vast spending on military hardware, the Houthi attacks on oil, military and transport facilities across the large, mostly desert country are stretching Saudi defences. The anti-Houthi coalition called Saturday's attack a "full-fledged war crime". The attack drew condemnation from the UN and leaders including U.S. President Donald Trump, who said he was considering joining Saudi strikes against the Houthis.

A Houthi official on Monday warned the U.S. it would receive a "painful response" if it entered the war in Yemen.

"If the U.S. becomes involved in the aggression against Yemen, we will not deliberate over the decision to respond, rather, there will be a swift and painful response targeting the US and all its interests in the region," Houthi political bureau member Mohammed Al Bukhaiti said.

Houthis tighten siege of key city in Yemen

Agence France-Presse
TAEZ

Houthi fighters have tightened their siege of the Yemeni city of Taiz, where fighting has killed more than 60 people in the past 24 hours, military sources from both sides told AFP on Monday.

The Houthis have blocked all exits and carried out several attacks overnight, said a military source loyal to the internationally recognised, Saudi-backed government that holds the city.

The violence killed 22 members of the pro-government forces, the source said.

The Houthis lost at least 40 fighters, according to military sources from the Iran-backed movement, who said they were sending reinforcements.

The Houthis were keeping up their fight in Taiz governorate despite coming under Saudi airstrikes, the sources said.

On Sunday, the health ministry warned of a "humanitarian catastrophe" in the city, with medicine, medical equipment and fuel "on the verge of running out".

Pakistan detains hundreds from Imran Khan's party

Agence France-Presse
PESHAWAR



Police detain a PTI supporter during an anti-government protest demanding the release of Imran Khan in Peshawar on Monday. AFP

Pakistani authorities have detained hundreds of members of Imran Khan's party, police officials told AFP on Monday, as a protest movement in support of the jailed former Prime Minister appeared to falter.

The detentions followed the central government's imposition of emergency rule on Sunday in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, the provincial stronghold of Mr. Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) party, after major protests demanding his release.

Two police officials, speaking on condition of anonymity, said 278 PTI members had been detained in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa since the emergency declaration.

The central government disbanded the PTI-led government under the emergency measures that it says were imposed due to deteriorating security in the border province, which is also battling militant attacks.

In the provincial capital Peshawar, police were deployed in large numbers on the first full day of emergency rule. Makeshift barriers formed from shipping containers and razor wire to block traffic to Peshawar's administrative zone remained in place. More than a dozen police personnel were deployed at each of the container checkpoints, equipped with protective shields, batons and tear gas shells.

Schools were also closed on Monday and digital monitor Netblocks reported "major disruption to the internet connectivity" in parts of the province the previous night.

PTI figures have called for fresh demonstrations in the wake of the emergency announcement, but sporadic protests on Monday drew far smaller crowds than the "long march" days earlier.

PTI said on Sunday the province's Chief Minister Sohail Afridi had been arrested hours after the extraordinary constitutional measures were announced by Pakistan's presidency.

The party has vehemently opposed the constitutional measures, describing them as undemocratic and a grab for power by the federal government.

Mr. Khan has been behind bars since August 2023, facing scores of charges ranging from corruption to inciting violence, following widespread anti-establishment riots in May that year.

He and his legal team reject the allegations, branding them politically motivated.

Russia doesn't want to accept 'energy truce', says Zelenskyy

Agence France-Presse
KYIV



Volodymyr Zelenskyy

Russia does not want to accept an "energy ceasefire" in Ukraine announced by U.S. President Donald Trump, Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said, accusing Moscow of attacking six sites on Monday.

Mr. Zelenskyy earlier promised to respond if Russia refused to agree to the truce, as Moscow indicated it would not adhere to the U.S. President's calls for a pause in attacks on power infrastructure.

Mr. Trump sowed confusion on Sunday with a surprise announcement on his Truth Social network that there was an agreement on both sides to end their punishing long-range strikes on power plants and oil refineries.

"It is increasingly evident that Russia is unwilling to accept an energy ceasefire proposed by the United States," Mr. Zelenskyy said on social media.

"Today alone, the Russians have attacked six energy facilities in Ukraine. Thirty-three people were wounded across the country," he added.

Mr. Zelenskyy had said Ukraine would back the ceasefire.

"If Russia does not agree to an energy ceasefire, we will respond," he told the Warsaw Security Conference.

Moscow has refused to say if an "energy ceasefire" was in place and appeared to reject Mr. Zelenskyy's offer of a 60-day pause in hostilities for elections to be held in Ukraine – which both the Kremlin and the White House have demanded.

"We don't want a ceasefire, we want long-term peace," Kremlin spokesman Dmitry Peskov told reporters, saying President Vladimir Putin would only order his troops to cease fire on election day itself.

"I do not think he (Zelenskyy) deserves a respite," added Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov.

Ukraine's Western allies have all backed a pause in attacks targeting the energy sector, as Europe's deadliest conflict since World War II nears its fifth anniversary and winter approaches.

But they have lined up to condemn Mr. Trump's announcement to allow Russia to supply diesel exports, with gas prices surging before U.S. midterm elections next month and Mr. Trump's Republicans expected to be hit hard.

'Dominance'

Mr. Putin claims the Donetsk region as a whole and has previously rejected face-to-face talks with Mr. Zelenskyy, making European leaders sceptical about whether he would accept any temporary pause in the bitter fighting.

Poland's Prime Minister Donald Tusk told the Warsaw conference that Moscow was "not interested in a ceasefire or in de-escalation or peace".

"It is interested only in domination," he said, urging European and US unity to ensure Ukraine's "survival" against Russia's attempts for "dominance".

Russia has previously attacked Ukraine's energy sector before winter, leaving many Ukrainians without power or heating as temperatures dropped as low as -20 degrees Celsius.

According to Green Deal Ukraine, an expert group, Ukraine's power generation capacity was 39.5 gigawatts just before Russia's full-scale invasion in February 2022.

But that had plunged to 13.5 GW in September this year.

School protest rocks France as Macron urges 'respect'

Agence France-Presse
PARIS

Some 130 French high schools remained closed on Monday, the Education Ministry said, with authorities hoping the protest movement that has rocked the nation in recent weeks would ease ahead of half-term holidays.

Students have blocked entrances to hundreds of lycees, high schools for children aged 15 to 18, with squads of riot police deployed and occasionally violent clashes resulting.

Pupils have complained about absent teachers, overloaded timetables, overcrowded classes and dilapidated classrooms, among other grievances.

Student rallies have been planned for Tuesday, ahead of wider public demonstrations against the rising cost of living that are expected on Saturday.

President Emmanuel Macron told reporters that the pupils' grievances would take time to address and urged restraint from protesters. "These are issues that deserve time, consultation, discussion, and respect," he said.

The government last week promised some 3,000 substitute teachers for 114 badly affected high schools.

United colours



Divided house: Supporters of Brazilian President and presidential candidate Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva of the Workers' Party gather along Copacabana Beach during a rally in support of Lula's campaign for the October 25 runoff election in Rio de Janeiro on Monday. AFP

British PM says IRGC 'certainly directed' airbase plot; Tehran rejects allegations

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Britain's government Monday accused Iran's Revolutionary Guards of being behind a major scare at a U.K. airbase used by the United States, as allies including Washington warned Tehran against hostile acts.

U.K. Prime Minister Andy Burnham told the British parliament that Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) "almost certainly directed" an incident at Royal Air Force Fairford in southwest England last month.

The U.S. abruptly withdrew all its B-1 bombers from the site last week.

Mr. Burnham said Britain's assessment of the incident was that it "is highly likely to have been coordinated in Iran, almost certainly directed by Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guard".

Meanwhile, Iran denied any involvement in the incident at the Fairford airbase, which has been used by the U.S. in its war with Iran. "The Iranian ambassador in London, Ali Mousavi, has again categorically rejected the accusations concerning Tehran's role in the incident at the Fairford military base," news agency IRNA reported.



Necessary network: The UNHCR responded to 22 emergency declarations in 18 countries this year. AP

UN refugees chief sounds the alarm on funding crisis

Agence France-Presse
GENEVA

The UN refugees chief warned Monday about being "asked to do the impossible", with his agency over-stretched by a huge funding shortfall and heavy displacement. Barham Salih, the United Nations' High Commissioner for Refugees, said the UNHCR had slashed its workforce due to budget cuts, while the number of forcibly displaced people remains near record highs.

"We are asking more of the refugee response at precisely the moment when fewer resources are available to sustain it," he said. "As of October 9, we have funds available of $3 billion, representing 35% of the requirement of the $8.5 billion needed for 2026." The UNHCR is currently forecasting funding of approximately $2.68 billion for 2027. "I recognise the budget pressures governments face," he said, "but there is again a difference between doing more with less and being asked to do the impossible.

Mr. Salih said that UNHCR has responded to 22 emergency declarations in 18 countries this year – including 17 newly-declared emergencies in 15 countries. The former Iraqi President – himself a one time refugee – spelled out the bleak situation while opening UNHCR's annual executive committee meeting, which runs until Friday.

He said that since 2024, nearly 8,000 people had left UNHCR, with its workforce falling from nearly 20,000 to just under 12,000.

The expertise that has left the agency cannot be easily replaced, he said.

Crisis deepens as Islamabad ousts PTI government in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa

The military-backed government in Pakistan has imposed emergency rule in the Opposition PTI-ruled Province, citing rise in terrorist attacks; the move comes amid a prolonged stand-off with the party of jailed ex-Prime Minister Imran Khan and a worsening security situation in the Province

NEWS ANALYSIS

Kallol Bhattacherjee

The Government of Pakistan on Sunday imposed emergency rule in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, the restive northwestern Province where the PTI – Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf, the party founded by imprisoned former Prime Minister Imran Khan – has been in power. In a social media post, President Asif Ali Zardari said he had approved the summary recommendations of the Cabinet that had earlier met under the leadership of Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif.

Mr. Zardari cited growing incidents of terrorism in the Province and dismissed the provincial government saying "terrorist attacks have increased to an unprecedented level of violent intensity...".

With the announcement of the proclamation of emergency under Articles 232 and 234 of the Constitution of Pakistan, political power has passed on to the Province's Governor, drawing widespread protest and outrage on the streets.

The PTI, the ruling party in the Province, has been agitating for the release of its leader Mr. Khan for over three years. In recent months, they had announced plans for a long march to Islamabad. The march that had been scheduled for September 27 was later postponed to October 4, as the government and the PTI continued to negotiate.

As talks foundered, the military-backed federal government attracted attention as a security blanket consisting of shipping containers and blast-proof barricades came up in vital locations of the capital conveying the message that the government would not allow the protest to reach Islamabad. The war of nerves between the PTI in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and the Centre in Islamabad has been brewing since August 2023 when Mr. Khan was arrested.

While Chief Minister Sohail Afridi came to power in October 2025, the province has been dealing with multiple centres of power as Faisal Karim Kundi, the Governor, was chosen as the representative of the federal government.

But popular support remains firmly with the imprisoned former Prime Minister.



Rallying for release: Supporters of PTI take part in a march in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, calling for the release of Imran Khan. AFP

Opposition's response

Mahmood Khan Achakzai, Leader of the Opposition in the National Assembly (NA) of Pakistan, has announced they will launch a peaceful protest against the decision of invoking emergency provisions of the Constitution while dismissing a democratically elected government in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

Separately, the PTI is holding protests in different parts of the country and hundreds of leaders, including Mr. Khan's three sisters, have courted arrest. In addition, according to reports, some of the tribal chiefs have called for armed resistance against the military-backed government.

Since coming to power in October 2025, Mr. Afridi has made the release of Mr. Khan as the main agenda of his government and shortly before the imposition of emergency, he had reiterated that the only way to diffuse the situation was to release Mr. Khan from Adiala Jail. The Federal government accused the provincial government of failing to control terrorism whereas the PTI is accusing Islamabad of highhanded repression.

The security situation in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa has been volatile for decades but in recent months, the main factor behind the worsening security situation has been the disjuncture between Islamabad and the provincial ruling party.

In brief, the Province has been facing a two pronged crisis – one a political battle with the Centre and second a worsening security situation involving terror groups with cross border links.

Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's Chief Minister Sohail Afridi and other leaders have been blaming Islamabad for following "wrong policies" that have helped in the flourishing of terrorism in the province.

The PTI had gone to the Supreme Court seeking intervention to help Mr. Khan. The top court permitted the former Prime Minister to receive better treatment at the Shifa International Hospital of Islamabad and allowed his family members to meet him. However, the government did not follow the instructions. Instead, he was taken to the state-run PIMS (Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences) during the night of August 20-21, where he was declared medically fit.

The Taliban trouble

The military-backed federal government has been alleging the Taliban is sending the Tehreek e Taliban Pakistan (TTP) fighters for attacks inside Pakistan using the Province as a staging ground for attacks in different parts of Pakistan.

On the other hand, critics of the government have been alleging that Pakistan has been training the officials of the pre-Taliban Afghan security establishment for launching attacks against the Taliban.

Khalilullah Safi, an expert on Islamic State-Khorasan Province (ISKP), pointed out to *The Hindu* there is considerable ground to suspect the military establishment in Pakistan is extending support to the ISKP. "What's happening in KP [Khyber Pakhtunkhwa] is linked to the overall plans that Pakistan military has for Afghanistan, Iran and even Central Asia," said Mr. Safi.

The Taliban in Afghanistan holds the dominant position, and as a result, the ISKP has been pushed out. The situation inside Khyber Pakhtunkhwa is amplified by the frequent border clashes between the Taliban and the Pakistani military. Atif Mashal, Afghanistan's former ambassador to Pakistan, said the Pakistani military is acting according to its regional agenda by getting the government to impose emergency in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.

"The declaration of emergency, in my view, has not occurred solely due to the protests of the PTI. It appears the protests serve as a superficial pretext. But behind it lies another regional agenda of Pakistan's military leadership, one that deems the militarisation of these areas essential for its implementation," Mr. Mashal said on X. In a warning to the military establishment, he further said, "the era of managed instability seems to be drawing to a close".

European Union adopts 1,600 new sanctions on Russian war industry

Agence France-Presse
BRUSSELS

The European Union on Monday formally added almost 1,600 new individuals and entities to its sanctions blacklist over Russia's war on Ukraine, in a bid to keep pressure on Moscow.

"This is the single largest expansion of our sanctions list since Russia started its war," EU foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas wrote online.

"Europe is again showing a united front. More than half are connected to the production chain for ballistic missiles," she said.

"We are making it significantly harder, slower and more expensive for Russia to produce the weapons it uses to kill Ukrainians," she added.



This is the single largest expansion of EU's sanctions list since Russia started its war, says foreign policy chief Kaja Kallas. AFP

Ukraine and its European backers have been left reeling by a decision from President Donald Trump last week to lift sanctions on Russian diesel as part of a deal to supply the United States.

The measures will take the EU's sanctions blacklist on Russia – which includes key figures like President Vladimir Putin – up to some 3,500 listings.

EU countries are still smarting over a push from France and Luxembourg last month that saw sanctions lifted on prominent Russian billionaires Alisher Umanov and Mikhail Fridman.

That move – which in Usmanov's case was linked to a French prisoner release deal in Azerbaijan – drew stinging criticism from Kyiv.

Alongside its blacklist on individuals and entities – the 27-nation EU has also imposed multiple rounds of sanctions on swathes of Russia's economy.

But there is fear that momentum is running out on new sweeping sanctions as EU countries increasingly struggle to agree targets that do not harm their own economies too much.

Life in line



A slow squeeze: A Palestinian child waits beside plastic jerrycans at an olive mill in Al-Zawayda, in the central Gaza Strip, where residents queue for hours to have their olives pressed despite fuel shortages and operational difficulties. AFP

Filmmaker follows Russian journalists into exile in six-hour-long documentary

Associated Press

Julia Loktev's new documentary begins almost like a tense Hollywood spy thriller. The journalists she's filming on her iPhone scramble to get out of Russia, many without a plan or lodging and with only a carry-on suitcase full of hastily packed things, hoping they're not held up at the border.

At nearly six hours, *'My Undesirable Friends: Part II – Exile*, which opens in select theaters this weekend, is the second half of Ms. Loktev's portrait of Russian journalists and the culmination of a five-year project. It began with Ms. Loktev filming a group of independent journalists in Moscow in the fall of 2021 as Vladimir Putin was starting to declare some reporters "foreign agents."

Four months later, the situation changed dramatically: Russia launched a full-scale invasion of Ukraine and many journalists fled the country on only a few hours' notice. Ms. Loktev kept filming, following her subjects as they reported on the war in exile.

"People hear, they're like, 'Oh my god a six-hour film about journalists? That's really scary.' But it's actually not," she told *AP* in a recent interview. "It's kind of a hangout film. It's a friendly film."

She did it again!

In the attention economy, a nearly six-hour documentary about anything might sound like a hard sell. Ms. Loktev knows this.

She went through it with the first film, *My Undesirable Friends: Part I – Last Air in Moscow*, which was shortlisted for an Oscar nomination and is currently streaming on MUBI.

That documentary – a portrait of journalists working in a society on the verge of shutting down all press freedoms – is nearly five and half hours long.

Now she is doing it again, and neither time with the help of a traditional theatrical distributor. A publicist even recently told her that she's hearing that people don't want to watch it because they're "kind of tired about hearing about press freedoms and authoritarianism."

"I'm like, that's really interesting, because authoritarianism isn't tired of them," Ms. Loktev said.

But the thing about the *My Undesirable Friends* movies is that somehow, despite the heavy subject matter, the sprawling runtime and the many characters, they don't feel like homework. You also don't need to see "Part I" to dip into "Part II."

The main reason is that her subjects, most of whom are in their 20s and 30s, are so engaging and relatable despite being in extraordinary circumstances. It's also why she didn't tire of filming them.



Julia Loktev's *My Undesirable Friends: Part II—Exile,* shot on iphone over five years, is part two of her portrait of Russian journalists. AP

"The film is so much about perseverance and how do you keep telling the story when attention moves away?... How you maintain optimism, or at least enough optimism, to get up the next morning and do your job?"

Since 2021, Russian authorities have labeled dozens of outlets and journalists as "foreign agents" – a designation aimed at discrediting them that also prevents them from selling advertising. They have also outlawed and imprisoned journalists. Many outlets have moved their newsrooms abroad since the first weeks of the war in Ukraine and are accessible in Russia via virtual private networks, or VPNs.

Ms. Loktev was born in the former Soviet Union in 1969 and immigrated to the U.S. with her family when she was 9 years old.

She continued speaking Russian with her mother, which made it easier to parachute into this world. Her entry point was Anna Nemzer, who worked for the independent television news network TV Rain.

'Simply showing reality'

Ms. Loktev filmed everyone with her iPhone, which helped her almost disappear into the background. Part II had her traversing European countries constantly as everyone had dispersed.

After the invasion, Ms. Loktev left Russia a little later than her subjects: She wanted to make sure she had uploaded her footage to the cloud before attempting to exit the country with her tourist visa.

She'd been warned that when an official is looking at a passport a little longer than usual and says that the "computer is hanging" that it means "they're checking you out." "I was standing there... at the airport in Moscow and I'm like, 'Is there an issue?' and they're like, 'No, no our computer's just hanging,'" she said. "It was hanging for a good 20 minutes. I tried not to pee my pants."

Several of the subjects, including Ms. Nemzer, joined Ms. Loktev at the Venice Film Festival for the film's world premiere.

Many still work as journalists from afar. But one switches focus midway through the second film: Peter Ruzavin, a former Russian journalist who is married to a Ukrainian journalist, decided to enlist in the Ukrainian Army. He said he realized that although his journalism was showing reality, it wasn't changing it.

"We need not to run away from Putin. We need to fight him," Mr. Ruzavin, who has served in the Ukrainian Army for over two years, said in Venice.

While its is not an exposé on war crimes, it is a reminder, she said, of what the journalists in the film are trying to do when everyone else's attention has shifted. "I think that's something that we're struggling with now in a way with the film, I'll be honest, is that everybody moves on to the next thing," she said.

The fantasy, she said, would be to make a "Part III" – "if ever the political situation in Russia changes." "But I think we might be very old by then."

PENALISED

Powell, Rutherford reprimanded for breaching ICC Code of Conduct



K.R. DEEPAK

West Indies' Rovman Powell and Sherfane Rutherford were reprimanded for breaching the ICC Code of Conduct during the second T20I in Ranchi. Powell was found guilty of breaching the code relating to the abuse of cricket equipment while Rutherford was pulled up for showing dissent at the umpire's decision.

TOUGH JOB

You need to execute your plans on batting-friendly pitches: Springer



K.R. DEEPAK

The Indian bowlers did a lot better than us. But there were a few balls that we could have put away and maybe brought the game a little closer. If you don't execute your plans on such (batting-friendly) pitches, you will get hit for a six or four. It has been a tough challenge for me — West Indies' Shamar Springer.

IN AND OUT

Kushagra replaces Pant in India-A squad for the first two NZ games



R. RAGU

Wicketkeeper-batter Kumar Kushagra was on Monday named as the replacement for the injured Rishabh Pant in the India-A squad for the first two matches of the tour of New Zealand. Pant, who led Rest of India in the Irani Cup, sustained a left-side strain and his injury appears to be more serious than it initially looked.

DOMINANT SHOW

Litton smashes a ton, Bangladesh closes in on victory in one-off Test



FILE PHOTO

Bangladesh pushed towards a big win over Afghanistan in the one-off Test in Abu Dhabi after a brilliant century from Litton Das helped it set a target of 479. **The scores:** Bangladesh 346 & 372/7 decl. in 105.2 overs (Shanto 82, Mushfiqur 81, Litton 102) vs. Afghanistan 240 & 132/3 in 50 overs (Rahmat Shah 50).



Setting 'em up: A six followed by a wicket has become bowler Dhir's template in the series against the West Indies. K.R. DEEPAK

Dhir and the art of bouncing back

WI IN INDIA

S. Shrivathsan
INDORE

If you want to learn the art of instantly bouncing back in an international cricket contest, dial Naman Dhir.

Conceding sixes in an unforgiving format for the bowlers may put many off but not Dhir. Whether you believe it or not, each of the 26-year-old's first five wickets in T20Is have come immediately after maximums.

While it occurred thrice in the opening India-West Indies match in Lucknow, history repeated itself in the third game in Indore on Sunday, when the off-spinning all-rounder sent back Shimron Hetmyer and Kamil Pooran.

Dhir has not been afraid to tease batters, but he revealed that his primary duty was to deliver tight spells. "My responsibility is to bowl two or three economical overs. In T20 cricket, an attacking option can also be a defensive option because there is nothing better than taking a wicket," he told JioStar.

Better understanding

"Being a batter helps me understand the [rival] batter's stance, backlift, guard and the shots he can play. I do not have many variations, so I have to rely on my line and length and vary my pace," Dhir added.

His wicket-taking ability has allowed India to go with four frontline bowlers.

"I have been seeing him since his u-14 days. The way he is bowling, he is going to do well for India in the next years as well," Abhishek Sharma was all praise for his India and Punjab teammate.

Dhir would not mind being hit for a six as long as it brings a wicket the very next ball.

Lively Abhishek switches off before turning it on

The dashing India opener says opposition-specific pre-series training and 'uncomfortable' sessions have been important to stay on top of his game; happy that his plan went really well

S. Shrivathsan
INDORE

As Abhishek Sharma readied himself to tackle the press, one could not help but admire the glitter of his jewellery.

But even that did not come close to the spark which radiated off his effervescent strokeplay in the 14-run victory over the West Indies in the third T20I here on Sunday. For a change, the India opener opted to begin his eventful ride on first gear rather than going full throttle from ball one.

Abhishek, mindful that Roston Chase had had his number in the previous two duels, played the ball along the ground against the off-spinner and speedster Shamar Joseph in the opening part of the Power-Play. The calm was followed by a storm, whose impact Windies could not survive until the 10th over.

The 26-year-old, known for treating bowlers with disdain, had to "respect" Chase and play a waiting game in order to be successful in the match.

"It (hitting mostly on the off-side) was not a deliberate plan. But I knew that they had a plan for me, so I had to play better than that. With the off-spinner bowling the first over, it was a battle between him and me. "I gave him respect in the first over because he has been bowling really well in this series. My plan went really well," Abhishek reflected on his approach during the 30-ball 69-run knock.



Powerplay: Abhishek says hitting on the off-side was not a deliberate plan. K.R. DEEPAK

For the marauding southpaw, opposition-specific pre-series training and "uncomfortable" sessions have been vital to stay on top of his game.

"Preparation is really important if I want to continue playing like this and utilise the PowerPlay. It depends on the team and the bowlers I am going to face," Abhishek said.

"I want to execute my plan really well and dominate as well. As an attacking batter, I have to be ready for all plans when facing world-class bowlers. I make myself uncomfortable in practice so that I am not surprised in a match," he added.

> Preparation is really important if I want to continue playing like this and utilise the PowerPlay. It depends on the team and the bowlers I am going to face

Abhishek's assault was so good that the Men in Maroon immediately switched to damage-limitation mode: he raced to his 14th T20I half-century off just 18 deliveries.

Trying to pull him back

"He is a world-class player... kudos to him. We tried to be as defensive as possible and make him get singles and doubles rather than boundaries. It was a matter of trying to pull him back," Shamar Springer admitted after being at the receiving end.

After all, for India, Abhishek is the gift that keeps on giving.

Adapting to different balls and conditions crucial: Suthar

S. Prasanna Venkatesan
JAIPUR

In a short span of time, Manav Suthar has impressed in each of his three outings with three different types of balls in three different conditions.

The left-arm spinner made his Test debut against Afghanistan at Mullanpur in June with the SG ball, took five or more wickets against Sri Lanka at Galle in August with the Kookaburra, and starred for Warwickshire against Essex in a County Championship Division One match at Chelmsford in September with the Dukes ball.

Suthar on Monday said adapting quickly to different balls and conditions was crucial. "To adjust, I practise a little more with whichever ball is going to be used in the match. That is what I try to do," he said.

"I try to adapt not just the ball, but the conditions too. How the wicket is going to play, what the weather is like, how the wind is blowing, how much drift to expect - I try to see how quickly I can adapt to all of that."

It is especially windy in New Zealand and Suthar has been studying footage for a better understanding of the New Zealand conditions as part of his preparation for the India-A Tour of New Zealand. Asked whether he was studying the lengths to bowl, the pace through the air, or how the ball behaved off the surface, he said he was looking at "everything."



Suthar. FILE PHOTO

The 24-year-old added that his experience of bowling with the Kookaburra in Sri Lanka would help him adjust more quickly in New Zealand. "Absolutely. If you have already played with a particular ball, it takes you a little less time to adjust. That will definitely help," he said.



On song: Renshaw's brisk 82 in the second innings helped Australia set a huge target. AFP

Renshaw shines again as Australia pushes for win

AUS IN SA

Agence France-Presse
DURBAN

Matt Renshaw top-scored for the second time in the match and took a key wicket as Australia pushed for victory on the fourth day of the first Test against South Africa at Kingsmead on Monday.

South Africa, set an improbable 421 runs to win, was 102 for four at close.

Renshaw followed his marathon 190 in the first innings with a brisk 82 in the second as Australia hurried to 314 for six in 58 overs before declaring.

Opening bowler Josh Hazlewood struck twice before Renshaw, a part-time off-spinner, claimed his first Test wicket when he had South Africa captain Temba Bavuma caught at short-leg.

Australian captain Pat Cummins had Tristan Stubbs caught behind three overs later, leaving the World Test champions with an almost impossible task on Tuesday if Bavuma is to retain his unbeaten captaincy record.

The scores:
Australia 390 & 314/6 decl. in 58 overs (Maddinson 48, Renshaw 82) vs. South Africa 284 & 102/4 in 41 overs (Markram 45 batting, Bedingham 46).

Marathas outlast Archers in an exciting shootoff

APL

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Mighty Marathas rallied to beat Chero Archers in a thrilling contest of the Archery Premier League season 2 at People's Plaza on Monday.

Archers, in trademark fashion, started strongly and took the first set. But there was little to separate the teams in the second and third, and the points were split. The final set was also a high-scoring affair and it needed a double check of where the arrows landed before Marathas levelled the scores and took the proceedings into a hit-or-miss shootoff.

Aman Saini and Dhiraj Bommadevara nailed their arrows into the yellow ring.

Mathias Fullerton was the only one to do the same for Archers, giving Marathas a 2-1 win via the tiebreaker.

Later, the Chola Chiefs struggled from the beginning. It was such a woeful display that it couldn't even get the last arrow out in time and could fare only marginally better in the second set.



Calm and composed: Aman nailed the arrow into the yellow ring in the hit-or-miss finale. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chiefs substituted in Deepika Kumari and Marcus D'Almeida for the third set, but the damage could not repaired. Though the two stepped up, Mete Gazoz nailed a 10 with his final arrow to hand defending champion Rajputana Royals a comfortable win.

Prithviraj Yoddhas' bid to climb to the top of the table was spoiled by Kakatiya Knights.

Nico Wiener, back in the team, was on song as Knights raced to a 4-0 lead. Nico, Neeraj Chauhan and Elia Canales did enough in the final set to seal the contest despite Jyothi Surekha having a rare off-day.

The scores:

Mighty Marathas drew with Chero Archers 4-4 (74-76, 76-76, 77-77, 77-76). Marathas won 2-1 via tiebreaker.

Rajputana Royals bt Chola Chiefs 5-1 (71-63, 74-69, 78-78).

Kakatiya Knights bt Prithviraj Yodhas 6-2 (77-76, 76-75, 72-76, 77-73).



Match-winner: Jithin latched on to a rebound to give NEUFC's campaign a fine start. RITU RAJ KONWAR

Jithin's late strike helps NEUFC stun Bagan

ISL

Sports Bureau

NorthEast United FC rode on an additional time strike by Jithin M.S. to shock Mohun Bagan Super Giant 1-0 in its Indian Super League season-opener in Guwahati on Monday.

Both teams started aggressively with the host creating a chance in the opening minute. However, Mohun Bagan goalkeeper Vishal Kaith was alert to the challenge. The visitors responded with a promising set-piece opportunity in the ninth minute, but Lee Erwin's effort struck the woodwork, keeping the scores level.

The visitors came close to taking the lead in the ninth minute when Lee Erwin's effort from a set-piece situation struck the woodwork. Mohun Bagan continued to press after the break, but NorthEast goalkeeper Gurmeet Singh made crucial saves to keep his side in the contest.

With five minutes of time added, NorthEast mounted one final attack. The Bagan custodian saved the initial effort, but the rebound off the post fell kindly for Jithin, who made no mistake in finding the net.

The result: NorthEast United FC 1 (Jithin 90+2) bt Mohun Bagan Super Giant 0.

City-PSG game the cynosure of all eyes

CHAMPIONS LEAGUE

Associated Press
GENEVA

The football schedule gods had a sense of humour making Manchester City's return to the Champions League after a devastating verdict of financial rule-breaking a game against Paris Saint-Germain.

Man City hosts title holder PSG on Wednesday in a standout meeting of Middle East state-backed clubs who were on parallel narratives for much of the past 15 years that now have wildly diverged.

The schedule:

Tuesday: Lens vs. Sporting CP and Sabah vs. Slavia Praha (both 10.15 p.m.); Inter Milan vs. Club Brugge; Arsenal vs. Lille; Atletico Madrid vs. Manchester United; Leipzig vs. PSV Eindhoven; Villareal vs. Napoli; Galatasaray vs. Barcelona; Viking vs. Bayern Munich (all at 00.30 a.m., Wednesday).

Wednesday: Feyenoord vs. Como and LASK vs. Liverpool (both 10.15 p.m.); Manchester City vs. Paris Saint-Germain; Roma vs. Real Madrid; Aston Villa vs. Fenerbahce; Real Betis vs. Porto; Bodo Glint vs. Borussia Dortmund; Shakhtar vs. AEK Athens; Bratislava vs. Stuttgart (all at 00.30 a.m., Thursday).

INBRIEF



Double delight for Maaya in W35 Lagos tournament

It was a day to remember for teenager Maaya Rajeshwaran at the W35 Lagos tournament in Portugal on Sunday as the 17-year-old, who entered the tournament as a qualifier, defeated Spain's Celia Cervino Ruiz 6-4, 6-2 in Sunday's final to become the youngest Indian to win a professional singles title since Sania in 2004. Maaya also claimed the doubles crown alongside Ukraine's Yelyzaveta Kotliar after beating Australia's Lizette Cabrera and Spain's Maria Martinez Vaquero 6-7(2), 6-1, [10-5] to cap a memorable week in which she did not drop a set in singles.

LIV golfers to be denied European Tour membership

Players who opt to compete on the breakaway LIV Golf circuit in 2027 will not be allowed to be members of the European Tour, officials said on Monday. Some of the world's leading players have been given conditional releases in recent seasons, which meant they could compete on both circuits. But DP World (European) Tour chief executive Guy Kinnings said players must now "make a choice". "Players need to make a choice," said Kinnings. "We have rules and regulations which are there to protect our tour and which our members must all abide by. Players who are not willing to comply with our rules and regulations should not be seeking to join our tour." LIV players such as Jon Rahm and Tyrrell Hatton are currently eligible to play on the European Tour under one of its membership categories. LIV Golf's future is uncertain after it filed for bankruptcy protection in September following the withdrawal of financial backing from Saudi Arabia's Public Investment Fund.

Rahul and Revanth send Karnataka on a leather hunt

The duo's 202-run partnership for the sixth wicket ensures that the hosts finish in pole position after exposing the inadequacies of the bowling attack; Shikhar scalps three and Madhav two

RANJI TROPHY

N. Sudarshan
VIJAYAWADA

S.V. Rahul and Revanth Reddy, 19 and 22, one making his debut for Andhra and the other with just five First Class appearances, pinned Karnataka on the mat by helping their side take a 57-run lead on day two of the 2026-27 Ranji Trophy opener at Mulapadu near here.

In his first innings for Andhra across formats, southpaw Rahul remained unbeaten on a fine 108 (187b, 10x4) while wicket-keeper-batter Revanth made a sparkling 97 (143b, 13x4).

The two, who have plied their trades together from junior cricket, combined for a brilliant 202-run partnership that lasted nearly two full sessions and helped Andhra close at 331 for six at the ACA Stadium on Monday.

The host was in a spot of bother at 116 for five, having lost its main batter Shaik Rasheed for a well-made 54 (121b, 4x4).

But Rahul and Revanth wore down an inexperienced Karnataka attack, which had three bowlers making their debuts and two others with a combined 13 caps.



Oozing class: Rahul's innings was a combination of composure and flair. K.V.S. GIRI

The spinners - Shikhar Shetty, Madhav Bajaj and Ritesh Bhatkal - were inconsistent with their lengths, and the fact that just seven of the 90 overs on the day were maidens was enough evidence of Karnataka's inadequacies.

R. Smaran & Co. did not help themselves by reprieving Rahul on 40, when K.L. Rahul dropped him at slip off Ritesh.

Initially, S.V. Rahul was composed and steady whereas Revanth was all action and busy.

The former got to his half-century in 102 balls with a lofted boundary over long-off. The latter reached the milestone from just 59 balls with a slapped four to the mid-wicket boundary.

But from there on, they marched shoulder to shoulder, moving into the 70s, 80s and 90s within a few balls of each other.

S.V. Rahul got to 99 by driving Ritesh superbly down the ground before completing his hundred with a single.

Revanth, though, had to be content with just a new career-best First Class score - previous best was 22 - after being caught by K.L. Rahul at slip off left-arm spinner Shikhar.

But they were 97 priceless runs.

The scores:
Karnataka — 1st innings: 274 in 82.2 overs.
Andhra — 1st innings: Hemanth Reddy c Smaran b Shikhar 1, Abhishek Reddy lbw b Shikhar 30, T. Vijay c Rahul b Madhav 4, Shaik Rasheed lbw Madhav 54, Ricky Bhui c Rahul b Bhatkal 18, S.V. Rahul (batting) 108, Revanth Reddy c Rahul b Shikhar 97, V. Sasikanth (batting) 6; Extras (b-5, lb-5, w-1, nb-2): 13; Total (for six wkts. in 95 overs): 331.
Fall of wickets: 1-5, 2-10, 3-53, 4-92, 5-116, 6-318.
Karnataka bowling: Abhilash 12-0-49-0, Shikhar 22-2-72-3, Madhav 30-3-88-2, Manvanth 4-0-33-0, Ritesh 25-2-71-1, Karun 2-0-8-0.

RANJI TROPHY SCORES — ROUND ONE, DAY TWO

Elite: Group A: At Rajgir: Uttar Pradesh 540 in 153.1 overs (Madhav Kaushik 150, Rinku Singh 112, Aaradhya Yadav 84, Zeeshan Ansari 58, Abhinandan Singh 43, Amod Yadav 4/91) vs. Bihar 44/2 in 18 overs.
At Panaji: Baroda 472/8 decl. in 157 overs (Shivalik Sharma 62, Shashwat Rawat 69, Deepak Hooda 52, Mitesh Patel 81, Atit Sheth 99) vs. Goa 5/1 in three overs.
At Srinagar: Madhya Pradesh 196 & 59/4 in 27 overs vs. Jammu & Kashmir 120 in 46.3 overs.
At Nagpur: Vidarbha 428 in 129.4 overs (Yash Rathod 134, Akshay Wadkar 198, Sagar Udeshi 4/86) vs. Pondicherry 107/1 in 41 overs (Ritesh Gudge 59 batting).
Group B: At Hyderabad: Tripura 134 & 106/7 in 35 overs vs. Hyderabad 294 in 103.2 overs (Tanmay Agarwal 54, Ruthik Yadav 61, Rahul Radesh 40, C.V. Milind 40, Sandip Sarkar 8/96).
At Vijayawada: Karnataka 274 vs. Andhra 331/6 in 95 overs. (Shaik Rasheed 54, S.V. Rahul 108 batting, Revanth Reddy 97).
At New Chandigarh: Assam 373 in 117 overs (Denish Das 103, Sibsankar Roy 143 n.o., Sarupam Purkaystha 66, Umesh Yadav 5/70) vs. Punjab 3/0 in two overs.
At Rajkot: Saurashtra 392 in 110.4 overs (Chirag Jani 83, Ravindra Jadeja 102, Prerak Mankad 129, Dev Aditya Singh 5/67) vs. Chhattisgarh 122/3 in 55 overs (Anuj Tiwary 72 batting).
Group C: At Jamshedpur: Jharkhand 587 in 179.5 overs (Shikhar Mohan 143, Utkarsh Singh 71, Virat Singh 108, Aditya Singh 147, Vaisakh Chandran 5/166) vs. Kerala.
At Kalyani: Delhi 240 vs. Bengal 304/3 in 79 overs (Sudip Kumar Gharami 122 batting, Abishek Porel 114 batting).
At Ahmedabad: Odisha 324 in 113 overs (Gourav Choudhary 137, Sandeep Pattnaik 69) vs. Gujarat 205/2 in 55 overs (Aarya Desai 94, Vedant Trivedi 94 batting).
At New Delhi: Maharashtra 333 in 110.1 overs (Prithvi Shaw 70, Ankit Bawne 118, Vicky Ostwal 50, Arjun Sharma 4/75) vs. Services 74/1 in 28 overs.



Sandip... spinning a web. NAGARA GOPAL

Group D: At Lahli: Himachal Pradesh 253 in 113.4 overs (Akash Vasisht 113 n.o., Anshul Kamboj 4/59) vs. Haryana 178/4 in 46 overs (Ankit Kumar 59, Yashvardhan Dalal 69 batting).
At Mumbai (Brabourne Stadium): Railways 278 vs. Uttarakhand. 260/4 in 84 overs (Kunal Chandela 43, Avneesh Sudha 75 batting, J. Suchith 50 batting).
At Jaipur: Rajasthan 363 in 115.3 overs (Rohan Rajbhar 95, Sumit Godara 49, Karan Lamba 113, Mahipal Lomror 66) vs. Tamil Nadu 167/4 in 50 overs (N. Jagadeesan 55, Pradosh Ranjan Paul 58).
At Mumbai (Wankhede Stadium): Mumbai 429 in 136.5 overs (Ayush Mhatre 48, Musheer Khan 65, Siddesh Lad 86, Tanush Kotian 58, Tushar Deshpande 44, Mohit Avasthi 56 n.o., Rohit Dhanda 4/78, Raj Bawa 4/73) vs. Chandigarh 78 in 19.1 overs (Deshpande 5/17, including a hat-trick) & 0/1 in one over.
Plate: At Rangpo: Sikkim 245 vs. Meghalaya 238/5 in 89 overs (Kishan Lyngdoh 78, Swastic Chettri 72 batting).
At Nadiad: Mizoram 183 & 30/3 in 23 overs vs. Manipur 251 in 91 overs (Langlonyamba Keishangbam 54, Kangabam Priyojit Singh 87, Kishan Singha 51, Khiangte Vanrotlinga 5/66).

Krystallos stuns the field in Taj Mahal Plate

RACING

HYDERABAD: The 10-to-1 longshot Krystallos, ridden by P. Sai Kumar, sprang a surprise in the Taj Mahal Plate, the main event of Monday's (Oct. 12) races. The winner is owned by Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram & M/s. Mukteshwar Racing LLP and trained by L.V.R. Deshmukh. Trainer R.H. Sequeira saddled three winners on the day.

1. NIRMAL PLATE (DIV. II) (1,200M): STAR COUNCILLOR (Dhanu S. Deora) 1, Goddess Of Light (Gaurav S) 2, American Affair (Ashad Asbar) 3 and Svalpaviryasaktih (Santosh Raj) 4. 5-1/2, 1-1/4 and 6. 1m, 13.60s. ₹51 (w), 12, 17 and 12 (p). SHP: 46, THP: 34, FP: 192, Q: 71, Tanala: 381. Favourite: Goddess Of Light. Owners: M/s. Mahesh Yadav & Laxman Singh Parmar. Trainer: Laxman Singh.

2. NAWAB MEHDI JUNG BAHADUR MEMORIALTROPHY (1,100M): VITAL SIGN (Vikram Singh) 1, Arthisha (D.S. Deora) 2, Clara (Arjun S) 3 and Flying Fury (G. Naresh) 4. 3-3/4, Neck and 2-1/2. 1m, 06.46s. ₹72 (w), 12, 13 and 17 (p). SHP: 23, THP: 44, FP: 820, Q: 339, Tanala: 4,124. Favourite: Flying Fury. Owner: Mr. S. Pathy. Trainer: R.H. Sequeira.

3. SADDLE UP PLATE (2,000M): CONCORDIA (B.R. Kumar) 1, Aakarshaka (Md. Ismail) 2, Vespucci (Arjun) 3 and Hoping High (Mohit S) 4. 2-3/4, 7-1/2 and 5-1/4. 2m, 08.89s. ₹39 (w), 32 and 10 (p). SHP: 38, THP: 65, FP: 64, Q: 19, Tanala: 426. Favourite: Aakarshaka. Owner: Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram. Trainer: R.H. Sequeira.

4. NAWAB MEHDI JUNG BAHADUR MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,100M): SHOOLIN (Dhanu S. Deora) 1, Sunny Day (V.S. Shekhawat) 2, Romantic Grey (Surendra S) 3 and Bold Beauty (Bhawani S) 4. 2, 1-1/2 and 3-3/4. 1m, 06.81s. ₹20 (w), 13, 12 and 18 (p). SHP: 42, THP: 40, FP: 104, Q: 59, Tanala: 174. Favourite: Shoolin. Owner: Mr. Rohit Gupta rep. Rolli Stud Dairy Agri. Farm. Trainer: Magan Singh.

5. NIZAMABAD PLATE (1,100M): N R I CYRPTO POWER (P. Trevor) 1, Costa Mesa (P. Sai K) 2, Nkalanzinzi (Surya Prakash) 3 and Farsiris (Kuldeep Jr.) 4. 5-1/4, 6-1/2 and 1/2. 1m, 06.13s. ₹15 (w), 13, 12 and 45 (p). SHP: 39, THP: 190, FP; 47, Q: 34, Tanala: 1,318. Favourite: N R I Crypto Power. Owner: Mr. Ravinder Reddy Male. Trainer: R.H. Sequeira.

6. MIRZA ZUNNUR AHMED MEMORIAL CUP (1,400M): PRINCE OF WALES (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Surrealist (Ajay K) 2, Greif (Swarup S) 3 and Pole Star (Trevor) 4. 1-1/4, 3/4 and 1-1/2. 1m, 25.94s. ₹21 (w), 11, 31 and 25 (p). SHP: 58, THP: 77, FP: 138, Q: 130, Tanala: 1,716. Favourite: Prince Of Wales. Owner: Mr. Rajendran rep. Rapar's Galloping Stars LLP. Trainer: D. Netto.

7. WWW.HYDRACES.COM TROPHY (1,200M): YALI (P. Trevor) 1, French Lieutenant (Kuldeep Jr.) 2, Mix The Magic (Mukesh K) 3 and La Quinta (P. Sai K) 4. 2-1/2, 5-3/4 and 3/4. 1m, 12.82s. ₹20 (w), 10, 12 and 21 (p). SHP: 28, THP: 39, FP: 35, Q: 22, Tanala: 115. Favourite: Yali. Owners: Mrs. Anasuya Gupta rep. A.G. Bloodstock LLP & M/s. Abhiroop Gupta, Shantanu Sharma, Bal Krishan Agarwal & Aditya Ghosh. Trainer: Bharath Singh.

8. TAJ MAHAL PLATE (1,600M): KRYTALLOS (P. Sai Kumar) 1, Secret Saint (Trevor) 2, Noble Heart (Afroz K) 3 and Dapper Look (Gaurav S) 4. 5-1/4, Neck and 1-1/4. 1m, 39.40s. ₹53 (w), 23, 17 and 19 (p). SHP: 25, THP: 60, FP: 219, Q: 90, Tanala: 1, 248. Favourite: Secret Saint. Owners: Mr. C. Aryama Sundaram & M/s. Mukteshwar Racing LLP. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.

9. NIRMAL PLATE (DIV. I) (1,200M): DOUBLE BUBBLE (Mukesh Kumar) 1, Veera's Lakshmi (Ajay K) 2, Queen Dali (Ashad Asbar) 3 and Suryavanshi (Surya Prakash) 4. 1-1/2, 1/2 and 3/4. 1m, 14.19s. ₹57 (w), 10, 38 and 11 (p). SHP: 95, THP: 58, FP: 1,640, Q: 606, Tanala: 2,832. Favourite: Queen Dali. Owner: Mr. S. Pathy. Trainer: D. Netto.

Jackpot: (i) 70%: ₹13, 407 (8 tkts.) & 30%: 3, 535 (13 tkts.); (ii) 70%: 2, 698 (260 tkts.) & 30%: 272 (1,102 tkts.).

Mini Jackpot: (i) 1,229 (201 tkts.), (ii) 1,095 (48 tkts.).

Treble: (i) 1,163 (21 tkts.), (ii) 131 (187 tkts.), (iii) 397 (108 tkts.).

LIVE TELECAST

Ranji Trophy: day 3, JioHotstar, 9 a.m.
Afghanistan vs Bangladesh: Only Test, day 5, FanCode, 11 a.m.
South Africa vs Australia: First Test, day 5, Eurosport & FanCode, 1 p.m.
Champions League: Sony Sports Ten 1, 2 & LIV, 10.15 p.m. & 12.30 a.m. (Wednesday)

East Bengal faces tough test against Iraq's Al-Shorta

ACL II

Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

East Bengal FC will host Iraq outfit Al-Shorta SC at the Salt Lake Stadium on Tuesday in its first home fixture of the AFC Champions League Two campaign. The Indian Super League champion enters the Group D encounter with one point, having secured a 2-2 away draw against Jordan's Al-Hussein SC last month. However, surrendering a two-goal lead in Amman exposed the defensive frailties East Bengal needs to address while meeting a physically imposing Al-Shorta side.

With home support expected to provide a significant boost, the Kolkata giant will look to capitalise on familiar surroundings. That Al-Shorta squandered a few chances in its first outing and the uncertainty over the fitness of striker Hussein Ali offer East Bengal an opportunity.

Al-Shorta arrives in Kolkata as the group leader after opening its campaign with a 1-0 victory over Oman's Al-Seeb. The Baghdad-based team will be keen to build on that result and consolidate its position at the top. The visitors' physical strength and the threat from counterattacks could pose serious problems for East Bengal, which recently lost to Mohun Bagan Super Giant in the IFA Shield final.

The kick-off is at 7.15 p.m.

We need to learn how to deal with the outside noise: Maresca

EURO LEAGUES

Agencies
ROME

Surprise package Cagliari continued its impressive start to the Serie A season by holding Juventus 1-1 on Sunday to remain fourth, two points above the Turin giants in sixth. Juventus required a late equaliser from Randal Kolo Muani to rescue a point after Daniel Maldini's opener as tempers flared between the coaches.

Manchester City silenced a hostile Liverpool crowd in its first match since being found guilty of breaching Premier League financial regulations but there is a deep sense of uncertainty over what it actually means.

Enzo Maresca's men are top of the table with six wins out of six after their impressive 3-0 win at Anfield on Sunday.

Yet those points could count for nothing unless City are successful in its appeal against the findings of an independent commission that found it guilty of more than 100 breaches of Premier League rules.



Toughing it out: Maresca is happy with the fight his side showed to win at Anfield. AFP

"We need to learn how to deal with the outside noise because of the situation, and the noise will be always there," Maresca said. "But at the same time, we need to try to make our noise, and that is win games, like we have done today, because at the end of the game, our fans, they were singing, so the noise was from us, not from Liverpool."

"We were all together," Maresca said. "I think for the importance of the game, Liverpool away, Anfield away, it's a good idea from the club to be all together, the togetherness that in this moment we need."

Top results: LaLiga: Racing Santander 2 (Zabiri 32, Martin 47) drew with Valencia 2 (Raba 2, Otorbi 65).

Serie A: Sassuolo 1 (Odenthal 68) drew with AC Milan 1 (Rabiot 63); Cagliari 1 (Maldini 20) drew with Juventus 1 (Kolo Muani 81).

SNAPSHOTS

FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia from Oct. 20

BENGALURU: Six of Asia's leading women's basketball clubs will compete in the FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia 2026 to be held at the Sree Kanteerava Indoor Stadium from October 20 to 25. The tournament will feature the domestic league champions of China, Japan, South Korea, Chinese Taipei, Philippines alongside Indian Railways, India's national champion.
"Hosting the FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia 2026 is a proud moment for Karnataka and reflects our commitment to promoting sports and providing athletes with opportunities to compete at the highest level," said G. Parameshwara, Deputy Chief Minister of Karnataka, at a press conference here on Monday.
"The FIBA Women's Basketball League Asia is an important platform for bringing the best women's club teams in the region together and showcasing the growing strength of women's basketball in Asia," said K. Govindaraj, President of FIBA Asia and Secretary of the Karnataka State Basketball Association.



Ribhav.

The teams: Denso Iris (Japan), Cheongju KB Stars (South Korea), Sichuan Yuanda Meile (China), Akari Sparks (Philippines), Cathay Life Tigers (Chinese Taipei) and Indian Railways.

WPL: Norris traded to Mumbai Indians from UP Warriorz

The United States' left-arm pacer Tara Norris will join Mumbai Indians for the Women's Premier League (WPL) next year following a successful trade deal with UP Warriorz. The 28-year-old Norris, who was signed by the Warriorz for a sum of ₹10 lakh ahead of the 2026 season, will join MI for the same fee, the WPL said in a statement on Monday. Norris made history at the inaugural WPL auction after becoming the first player from an Associate nation to be picked by a franchise. She represented the Delhi Capitals in the opening season and became the first bowler to register a five-wicket haul in WPL.

Ribhav, Paranjay begin campaigns with convincing wins

Top seed Ribhav Saroha, who won the under-18 boys' title last week, began his under-16 campaign with a 6-4, 6-2 victory over Raghav Sarode while third seed Paranjay Siwach defeated Bhavik 6-1, 6-1 at the Fenesta Open National tennis championships in New Delhi on Monday.

Other top results (round-of-64):
Under-16: Boys: Rishi Yadav bt Govardan Suresh 6-2, 6-0; Ishayu Desai bt Nibras Hussain 4-6, 7-5, [10-8]; Vivaan Mirdha bt Mahijith Kaura 6-1, 6-2; Jeevith Sathish bt Charchit Boora 6-4, 6-2; Divey Malik bt Sai Kanithi 7-6(3), 6-3.
Girls: Tejaswi Manneni bt Miraya Agrawal 6-2, 4-6, [10-5]; Manvi Gupta bt Purvi Patwa 6-3, 6-0; Unnathi Muralidhar bt Janhavi Sawant 6-3, 6-3; Shravee Deore bt Anihlle Meka 6-2, 6-4; Rishita Yadav bt Harini Kanithi 6-2, 6-4.

Antonelli dares to dream with a historic crown in sight

FORMULA ONE

Reuters
SINGAPORE

Mercedes' Kimi Antonelli said he is allowing himself to dream about a historic world title which is within reach at the next race in Austin, Texas, after the 20-year-old sealed his 14th podium finish of the season at Sunday's Singapore Grand Prix. The title would make Antonelli Formula One's youngest ever champion and Italy's first since 1953.



Antonelli. AFP

Antonelli's third place in a Singapore Grand Prix that was controlled from start to finish by Red Bull's Max Verstappen was scrappy, as he flirted with a penalty for testing the track's limits.

But it was enough to extend his lead over teammate George Russell to 102 points and when asked if he dared to dream of clinching the title in Austin later this month on the long journey home he said: "For sure. I know it's very close, I know it's there, but I just need to make sure that I keep doing the best I can."

Bowlers — a fraternity that has been on a hiding

There is much to be said of the advantages of chasing in India at this time of the year, when the dew is quite pronounced and gripping the ball in the second half of a match, especially for the spinners, is practically impossible



K.R. DEEPAK

R. Kaushik

Not till the sixth outing in a cluster of eight did a team batting first finally manage to successfully defend a total. India's 14-run victory in Sunday's third Twenty20 International had to be earned the hard way, but at least it provided some solace to a fraternity that has been on a hiding to nothing since West Indies' snappy white-ball tour of India began in Thiruvananthapuram on September 27.

There is much to be said of the advantages of chasing in India at this time of the year, when the dew is quite pronounced and gripping the ball in the second half of a match, especially for the spinners, is practically impossible. It's not as if bowlers don't account, or prepare, for this scenario. At practice, they often use wet, slippery balls to try and replicate the conditions they will most likely be confronted with in a match situation, but the nets does not entail the same pressure to deliver as a match, and therefore no amount of training can translate to perfecting a most difficult craft.

It is certainly no coincidence that the Indore victory came when there was no dew, thereby facilitating a hint of reverse swing expertly utilised by Arshdeep Singh, India's highest wicket-taker in T20Is. Of course, India were also well served by the likes of Prince Yadav and Nitish Kumar, who delivered pinpoint yorkers at the death with great regularity. But even here, their cause was helped by a dry ball which they could send down with control, unlike a slippery orb that doesn't quite leave the hand as the bowler would like it to be.

Veritable run-fest

The One-Day International series provided a veritable run-fest, with Thiruvananthapuram somewhat of an outlier even though the Caribbeans got off to a frenetic start. John Campbell and centurion Justin Greaves added 135 for the opening wicket in just 114 deliveries to raise visions of a mammoth target on a pancake pitch until Kuldeep Yadav spun a wicked web in the middle overs with his tantalising left-arm wrist-spin. Again, Kuldeep operated in natural light with dew still to make an appearance; his craft shone through as he finished with four for 40 to ensure West Indies didn't post more than 295, a total reined in with a whopping 50 deliveries to spare as Shubman Gill and Virat Kohli tore into the bowling.

Run-making touched ridiculous proportions three nights later in Guwahati. And yes, ridiculous is being used advisedly.

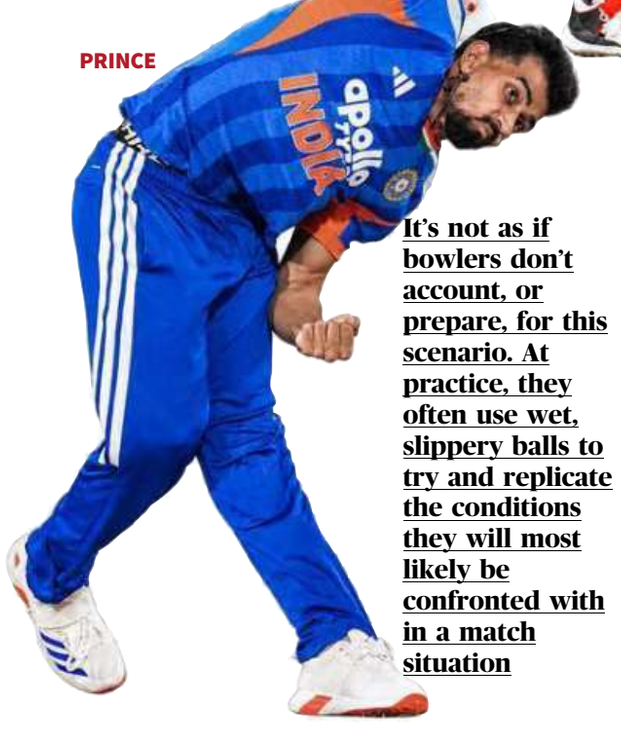
Campbell, red-hot skipper Shai Hope and the impressive Amir Jangoo provided the first instance of three batters slamming hundreds in the same ODI innings, propelling West Indies to 405 for seven. That's more than eight runs an over for 50 overs, an extraordinary accomplishment that would guarantee victory 999 times out of 1,000. Only once before, a decade back, had a larger score been hunted down (by South Africa against Australia) internationally, so West Indies would have entertained some designs of squaring the series, but only some designs because they knew that even a run-rate of 8.10 didn't hold any guarantee.

Their worst fears came true as the prayers of the Guwahati crowd were comprehensively answered. As facetious as it might sound, there was an unmistakable inevitability to India's march to victory, this time attained also by eight wickets with 39 deliveries to spare. At the forefront again was Gill, who joined his predecessor Rohit Sharma as the only batter to smack more than one ODI double-ton. Gill's partner-in-crime in the decimation of the bowling was Rohit; their opening salvo of 255, in 158 deliveries - is this even real?! - made this singularly one-way traffic. Evidently, no score is safe anymore. India mounted their highest successful run-chase but they did so without breaking sweat. It was great for the fans, who soaked in a very popular home victory, but what about the bowling fraternity? What about them indeed?



ARSHDEEP

NITISH



PRINCE

White-ball bowling hasn't quite evolved as dramatically and with as much impact as batting, which is understandable because cricket is, after all, a batter's game.

It's not as if bowlers don't account, or prepare, for this scenario. At practice, they often use wet, slippery balls to try and replicate the conditions they will most likely be confronted with in a match situation

Boot on the other foot

More carnage was to follow in New Chandigarh in the final, dead-rubber ODI, though this time, the boot was on the other foot. Hope's grin on calling right lit up an already bright Saturday afternoon, a grin that would have made a Cheshire cat weak with envy when Jayden Seales packed off Gill and Kohli in the third over to leave the hosts gasping at four for two. To get to 351 from that point was a terrific accomplishment, aided by the fact that the early bounce and lateral movement dissipated under the unforgiving sin.

West Indies had never scored that many to win a match, and at various stages, it seemed as if they wouldn't again, but their skipper didn't buy into that theory. Having kept wickets for 50 wickets and picked up a groin twitch along the way, he made the most of a fortuitous promotion as opener - where he has tasted unparalleled ODI success - with an innings for the ages. Hobbling and wincing, he found a second wind to batter India into submission, raising victory with ten deliveries to spare.

Two National record chases in four nights set it up beautifully - for everyone except the bowlers - heading into the five-match T20I series. Once again, the start was flattering; West Indies floundered against Indian spin in high-scoring Lucknow, shot out for 171 with Axar Patel, Kuldeep and debutant Naman Dhir taking seven wickets between them. It was a total India would have reeled in in their sleep; with skipper Shreyas Iyer choosing that night to bring up his maiden century, it was all over in the blink of an eye, with 32 deliveries in reserve. Were we in store for a more equitable contest between bat and ball?

No sir, we certainly were not.

Over to Ranchi, and game two. Sanju Samson, that infuriatingly inconsistent opener who oscillates between the dreamy and the nightmarish with frustrating frequency, shed a lean trot with a blazing 82, and the captain and his deputy, Tilak Varma, produced an exhilarating final kick to propel India to 249 for five. It was worth more than West Indies' 405 in the second ODI in all ways imaginable, yet it proved remarkably inadequate. Remarkably.

India plucked out Kamil Pooran - no relation to the more celebrated Nicholas - and Shimron Hetmyer off successive deliveries through the express Mayank Yadav in the very first over, and when Mayank also cleaned up Rovman Powell, West Indies were up against it at 58 for three. Hope - who else? - and Sherfane Rutherford pushed back spectacularly. There was no time to rebuild, no point in steadying the rocking boat. They both teed off, the left-handed Rutherford and his right-handed captain matching each other blow for pulverising blow while adding 120. Rutherford missed out on a century but Hope wasn't to be denied, powering his team past the finish line with Romario Shepherd for company. It was the second time in three matches (and two different formats) that West Indies had completed a record chase. That they reached 252 with nine deliveries to spare amply demonstrated the dominance of the bat over the ball, which is why India's 14-run win in Indore assumes greater significance even though they had an impressive 223 to defend.

At the interval, the pundits were busy dissecting if 223 was enough. Imagine that. More than 11 runs an over, and the experts are debating if the team batting first was a few short. Where are we headed? Is this how it is going to be, with towering edifices erected in the evening and razed to the ground by night? Will game after game follow a monotonous pattern of ball-bashing, aided by flat decks, small boundaries, light bats with extended sweet spots, and a profusion of power and cheekiness that leave bowlers tearing their hair out in frustration?

Both after winning in Guwahati and losing in Ranchi, India head coach Gautam Gambhir called for a greater balance between bat and ball. He lamented the punishment the bowlers (from both sides) were being subjected to. He did acknowledge that India should have done better in Ranchi when they had nearly 250 on the board, and you couldn't argue with that because in some ways, as harsh as it might sound, the bowlers have readymade excuses and therefore carry the belief that they can be excused any mauling.

It's against this backdrop that one recalls Josh Hazlewood's remarks during IPL 2026, when he held forth on the challenges of bowling in T20 games, especially in the first six overs when only two boundary-riders are allowed.

"I think it's definitely nice for the crowds to watch balls flying into the stands," the Australian quick, one of the heroes of Royal Challengers Bengaluru's back-to-back IPL triumphs, observed in April. "From a bowler's point of view, it almost takes the pressure off a little bit because the batsmen are expected to get off to good starts. They're expected to score big runs, they're expected to get 230 runs probably every T20 innings they play."

The Aussie great then held forth on the virtues of defensive bowling, reiterating that especially in 20-over cricket, it is not always imperative to go looking for wickets every ball. "If you can get a batter on two off six balls, the pressure that they're under in that situation is huge," he pointed out. "You can just see a player almost melt out there in the middle, they just cannot find the gap, cannot find the boundary. I feel like that's the biggest pressure in the game now, it almost releases the pressure (on the bowlers) a little bit."

That's something Gambhir alluded to in Ranchi, and Nitish harped on after the Indore victory.

While it is true that the best dot ball is the one that comes with a 'W' attached to it, when the dice is loaded in favour of the batter and the odds are stacked against the bowler, it is essential to bowl within oneself and do the unglamorous rather than embrace bluster and bravado. Defensive bowling is a fine art - ask a Fanie de Villiers, or a Gavin Larsen or Chris Harris - and doesn't mean that one doesn't have the requisite skills to take wickets. It's just an honest and intelligent acknowledgement of how things stand instead of giving in to ego and trying to show who the boss is.

White-ball bowling hasn't quite evolved as dramatically and with as much impact as batting, which is understandable because cricket is, after all, a batter's game.

But unless these 'my batting strongest' battles are more evenly spaced out, we are in real danger of killing the goose laying the golden eggs.



MAYANK

K.R. DEEPAK

THE GIST

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